Lean Left

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38055511.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M, M/M, Multi, Other

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
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Additional Tags:
Unofficial Sequel, Hordak Redemption (She-Ra), Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Entrapta Being Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak-centric (She-Ra), Original Character(s), Spoilers

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by machashe

Summary

Etheria is in a state of flux in the aftermath of the defeat of Horde Prime. With reparative work well underway, the rebellion welcomes new companions and new challenges in Bright Moon and beyond. Glimmer struggles to balance her grief and her duties as Queen, Entrapta and Hordak face the ceaseless struggle to understand and be understood, and Adora and Catra endeavor to persevere on the path towards healing.

But when the Best Friends Squad Expanded Edition stumble upon ancient secrets that have the potential to change their lives forever, it is up to Glimmer to decide if its worth the risk. After all, what's more important than family?

Notes

Well. Here goes. This is my first rodeo when it comes to fanfic. Hopefully not to shabby... it's definitely an... ambitious choice lol.

It should be noted that I'm a staunch supporter of the canon ships and this work puts Entrapdak front and centre. In case that isn't your bag.

Enjoy? I hope? and... my heartfelt gratitude to the team who made She-Ra a thing... so that this fever dream of an idea could take root in my head.

Also, shout out to https://fionapeakgames.itch.io/first-ones-translator for letting me run away with all of these crack nerd ideas.

P.S. The title honestly has not much all to do with the story. It's almost an inside joke with myself relating to another fandom altogether so. Don't read much into it.

Pinnacle Trials

Chapter Summary

> In the wake of Horde Prime's defeat, the issue is raised of what Hordak owes to Etheria.

"We have seen the consequences of Horde Prime's… gaze.” Catra offered with air quotes. “But with all due respect, Sparkles, Hordak shat the bed here all on his own." Her tone was snide. Entrapta, indignant, motioned to speak, but someone beat her to the punch.

"That only stands if you’re willing to acknowledge the parallel between Hordak and yourself, Catra." Perfuma huffed. Catra's ears flattened. Whether in embarrassment or rage it was unclear. Adora suspected both.

“She has a point, Wildcat.” Scorpia shrugged. They looked to Catra expectantly. Adora knew it wasn’t her place to defend her here.

"Thank you, Scorpia." The acknowledgement came from her back teeth, but it was sincere. She locked eyes with Perfuma. "Yes. I do."

"So he deserves the opportunity to make things right--just like you and me!" Entrapta blurted before deflating slightly with a nervous laugh "Well… we're trying…"

Perfuma hummed in contemplation for a moment. "He did stand against Horde Prime… even if he was… unsuccessful."

Mermista groaned, flinging an arm outward in frustration. "He did that for Geek Princess. Not for Etheria." Her kingdom had seen the most recent and severe damage at the hands of the horde.

Glimmer held her hands up sharply. The room froze. Her presence in the throne room had taken on a unique gravitas. She no longer

felt that she was holding a place. Playing dress up in ill-fitting clothes.

"Agreed. His actions against Horde Prime are irrelevant to the reparations owed…but–" She stifled another pending outburst from Entrapta. "It's not an irrelevant example of the beginnings of reform." She gestured for the guards to bring him forward.

Though it had only been a matter of weeks since Horde Prime was expelled, they had been surprised to discover how many of Hordak's memories of Etheria had been retained… and how willing he was to acknowledge them. He stepped forward with the condescending rigidity that Catra so reviled, but he looked only to the floor with his hands clasped firmly in front of him.

"Well, Hordak, what do you have to say for yourself?" Glimmer folded her hands in her lap. Anticipation settled, blanketing the room like heavy snow. He did not stir immediately. The stillness was eerie. After years of explosions and aggression… to sit solemnly in the same room as Hordak was, as Perfuma would put it… a challenge. Finally, he spoke, though his gaze didn't shift from the ground.

"I find the concept of apology to be flawed. With Prime, forgiveness was yet another form of manipulation; never granted, only alluded to. I do not strive to be forgiven." Glimmer narrowed her eyes at this. Her mouth was a taut thin line of disapproval. Micah observed the ghost of Angie in her expression… not for the first time. Catra found that she had been holding her breath.

"Under the gaze of Prime, I was punished for my imperfections. Redemption was not possible. Not unless it served Prime above myself. I chose to think the same of Etheria. I made that error long before Prime validated it. On the front lines of his Eternian war," Adora stiffened. Catra placed a calming hand atop her clenched fist. "I had already begun to question the perception of Prime. Upon arriving here I could see the beauty of this planet, that it held more value than I, in spite of what Prime's decree would have been– this curiosity and disloyalty repulsed me. As he

once said… there were moments where I faltered. When I wished he would not come for me.” Catra’s eyes strayed to Entrapta; her expression unreadable.

“I resented the value I saw in this planet and sought to destroy it. To punish it…. To use it as a tool to punish– myself." He failed to cover a clipped, mirthless laugh with a cough. "...One last tribute to the glory of Horde Prime." He unfolded his clasped hands… turning them over for inspection before shifting, clenching them militantly behind his back. It was only then that he lifted his gaze from the floor. Unwavering, Glimmer met his eye with regal discretion.

"Etheria is not a tool to be used. Not by myself, or the Eternians. Not even by those of Etheria. It is a bastion of wonder to be honoured and cultivated. I should rightfully lose the privilege to do that in the Fright Zone… out of respect to those I exerted my will over." His gazed flicked unexpectedly to Catra–but only for a moment. She looked away dismissively; but her stomach had bottomed out. The maelstrom of emotion that followed was too much to contemplate in a room full of people. Grateful to Melog’s silent presence at her back, imperceptible to all but Catra, she stifled it as best she could.

"Very well." Glimmer addressed the delegation. "What is proposed?" It was then that Adora finally spoke.

"Hordak expresses a desire to be in service of Etheria. We have considerable work left to do to untangle the insidious web of tech and manipulation applied by the Eternians… it seems fitting that he be instrumental in that."

"He is excellent with tech!" Entrapta gushed inappropriately. Catra rolled her eyes.

"I just want to chuck him onto Beast Island or leave him to the Waste… so that’s a sign we probably shouldn’t." She conceded begrudgingly.

"Actually…" Perfuma and Mermista contemplated in unison. Startled, they grimaced. Mermista gestured for Perfuma to go first.

"They are the locations most wounded by Eternian intervention… in most need of healing." Perfuma offered optimistically.

"...It would be nice for him to be the one getting whooped by giant bugs for a change." Mermista didn't disagree. Each delegate looked to their companions with a juvenile sense of incredulity. Could it really be that simple? Entrapta's eyes sparkled hopefully. Clearly thinking about long buried pits of ancient tech instead of the idea of fitting punishment.

"In that case… what term seems reasonable?" Asked Bow.

"Ten years." Micah, often very quiet in the throne room out of deference to Glimmer, was firm on this. It was not lost on Glimmer… the specificity of this number. So aware in the moment of the absence of her mother. Grief, never buried, swelled in her chest; but she would defer it.

Glimmer rose from her place on the throne and gestured outward magnanimously.

"Hordak's submission to the greater good of Etheria shows promise. I approve the proposed terms of his release. He will submit ten years of reparative labour to the restoration of Etheria. The delegation will reconvene as necessary to discuss where need is greatest. For now, that is Beast Island without question." The group nodded together. "As recommended, I also decree permanent banishment from the territory formerly known as the Fright Zone. Hordak will be escorted to Beast Island by select delegates of the Princess Alliance at moonrise."

Hordak offered a brief, acute bow. "I submit my dedication to cultivate the natural wonders of Etheria under your rightful direction."

Damn right; Glimmer thought, fighting the urge to smirk.

On Stranger Tides

Chapter Summary

> Hordak tries to make sense of his future as Mermista contends with the past.

Though tall for an Etherian, the queen of Salineas only came to his shoulder. Hordak endeavored a discreet glance toward his escort. Her eyes were trained forward, unwavering. She had been stone cold silent since she had volunteered to escort him back to his chamber. Hordak was unfamiliar with her personally; but was very familiar with what she represented… and what he owed to Salineas. He kept his head down, unsure of where this hallway would lead. *Maybe nowhere?* He thought suddenly. For all anyone's talk of fair trial and punishment… he really had no reason to believe in the sentence they had put forward to him. His established concept of fairness… it wasn't this. He thought again to Catra and Entrapta sitting council in the Princess Alliance. Then again, maybe there was precedence for such mercy. Before long, they were at his chamber. Did she really plan to escort him without making any comment? He paused for permission to enter. She didn't waste a glance on him. This, he was used to.

"I'm only going to say this once." Her tone was cold and flat. It snaked through the silence like an icy current. "Stay out of my waters and as far as I'm concerned, we never have to speak again." He offered a single firm nod; could his continued silence convey sufficient deference? "Cross my kingdom, though, and Glimmer's edict won't mean shit." She waited, as did he, until finally deciding that he should risk a reply.

Her fists clenched as his gravelly baritone resonated. "Understood." A final stilted moment of silence passed between

them before she turned, sharply, and left him adrift in the hallway without another word or glance. He had expected to be confined when he was initially escorted to Bright Moon, but by all accounts he seemed free to roam as he pleased. It was very confusing. He stared into the unlit depths of his room. For a moment he considered inspecting the garden. Sleep would not come easily to him and it was only early dusk; but, he couldn't wrap his mind around the freedom he had been afforded. As he stepped across the threshold, soft lights bloomed in the fixtures overhead. Magic; such a truly confounding resource. He paced aimlessly as he turned things over in his mind.

To think by this time tomorrow he would be dropped, again, unceremoniously in an unfamiliar place… tasked with setting up a base and executing the will of Bright Moon. It was equal parts relieving and alarming, this sharp parallel. That moment two decades prior seemed to manifest itself. Adrift on this unfathomable planet with no clear direction and so thoroughly, consumingly alone.

It was different this time, though, Bright Moon had given him permission to speak his mind. His fate had been something worthy of discussion. These people… asked more of him than Horde Prime ever had… and yet… presented him with opportunities with which he could never have previously dreamed. Of course, there was also Entrapta.

It seemed that agency would be expected, no, required… He was not yet sure how this decision would impact communication with her. Would it be possible? Could she– Would she– escort him? He knew nothing of her time on the island. Was it perilous? Was it possible that she would… refuse? An energy that he had no name

for simmered inside. It was his longest standing companion: this whispering of his own worthlessness.

Before he knew what he was doing; he was assaulted by noise and debris. He had knocked an ornament from its dias. It had splintered against the adjacent wall. Decimated; the floor was now littered with shards. It only served to fuel his fury. How could he justify this? What could he do? It was dizzying. It was certain he would be punished. Had he really ruined everything before it had even begun–

"Oh, Hordak…" He was wrenched from his rising panic by Entrapta's melodic warble. He wheeled around to discover her in the doorway. Her visor glinted. Tools threaded through her hair and a tray of– he hesitated to call it food– in one hand. She descended upon him, dragging a cart behind her as she approached. She absently flung her various items onto every available surface. She knelt, sweeping up the evidence of his recklessness, to pour it into a nearby bin. They may as well have been in the lab after another misfire of his exosuit. He was grateful to discover that Wrong Hordak was not in tow. Their initial meeting had not gone well.

"I leave you alone for five minutes and you're already in a tizzy." Entrapta tutted as her hair coaxed him into a nearby chair.

"Never ." He laughed to himself as the tension from moments before was suddenly a more distant memory than the one blossoming in his mind.

“Well, I’m here now and oh!” Her eyes sparkled; arms flung wide. “I have *SO* many things to show you!”

–

Mermista was unusually solemn as they approached Salineas faster than natural order would allow. Sometimes it paid off to be betrothed to a goddess of the sea. Seahawk, altogether too pleased with himself as usual, approached her with his trademark familiarity– the kind that she only ever really allowed when they were alone.

“You are sulking, dearest, who’s boat are we to set aflame?” he draped an arm around her as he crooned. She rolled her eyes and smirked; a winning achievement.

“No one’s… everyone’s.” She seemed torn between laughing, sighing and crying. “There is just… so much to be done and… nowhere for my anger to go.” The waves surged, rocking the boat, their journey, no doubt, would remain intermittently… choppy.

“Do you believe Bright Moon’s edict to have been unjust?” He offered this without judgment. She knew if she answered yes he would turn the ship right around and demand some sort of recount.

“That’s the problem!” she threw up her hands, pushing him away, sea mist rained over them. “I don’t want justice. I want the sweet

taste of revenge!" She deflated. "Except… Not really. Not in a way that can be appeased." Seahawk's heart lurched as his stomach did. For all his nautical rollicking, nothing brought seasickness quite like an unsatisfied Mermista. He steadied himself against the hull.

"Setting anyone's boat aflame… even Hordak's… won't bring anyone back." Mermista pulled herself inward, clutching her stomach. "As much as I still want to pop him one." The waves settled, though a spirit still simmered beneath. Tentative, he approached again. This time, she leaned into his arms as he cradled her in her disappointment.

"You know you need only say the word, my love." He teased half-jokingly. She snorted.

"Yeah, yeah." But for now, peace was better–not *good* , but better. They braced together and stared once more out into the sea.

Catch and Release

Chapter Summary

> Catra, ever restless in the twilight, wanders the halls of Bright Moon in search of something. Of what, she can't say.

The cool night air whispered against Catra's fur. Even the wind in this place felt overly familiar. She paced the garden absently in the twilight. She had found herself here more than once now in her restlessness. Someone still tended it, apparently, in Shadowweaver's… absence. Catra ripped a rose from its stem and crushed it. With impulses like this she was never going to get on Perfuma's good side. She smiled a little. Maybe that was OK. She let the petals flutter to the ground. If she could just shake this crawling feeling that seemed to pool in her elbows; she could get some goddamn sleep. Catra departed the garden sharply. She would not find answers there. It was then that Melog popped out from a nearby bush. They never startled Catra somehow. She paused so that Melog could catch up. They slipped out of view as they padded softly toward the castle halls together. It was easy for her to lose her place here. Before long, after a wrong turn or three, she was alerted to the rumble of nearby discussion. Slowly, it dawned where she had found herself.

Catra flung her back flush against the cool wall just beyond the entryway of Hordak's quarters; cloaked by Melog. She didn't know exactly what she was doing here. Eavesdropping, evidently. "I do not understand why Catra– I do not understand Catra." Hordak corrected himself. "...I will not pretend to, but I understand that my influence over the Fright Zone lead to the choices she did make." Catra bit back a hiss. Active accountability was difficult… admitting others held influence over her was worse. How was it possible that she had stumbled upon this, of all conversations? What would even facilitate it? The buzzing of various tools could also be heard. *Of course.* The fact that she was witness to this

alien vulnerability spoke to… whatever the hell was going on between him and Entrapta.

"I'm not Catra… but she was definitely very mad at you." Entrapta offered unhelpfully. Catra stifled a groan. *Understatement of the century.* Despite being invisible, she was hesitant to overstep any further than she already had… yet she couldn't bring herself to pull away.

"I would have harmed her regardless. I expected broken trust… and in doing so… manifested it." His tone shifted to a low growl. Catra struggled to hear it; emotionally and tangibly. She suddenly understood Hordak's past reliance on Imp… and Entrapta's on her experiment logs.

"Catra… was not like Shadowweaver." Catra stiffened at his mention of her name. Glimmer had said once… as they sat back to back on Prime's ship–that grief comes for us all– but not if Catra had anything to say about it. "I never anticipated anything less than betrayal from Shadowweaver… but Catra–" He paused sharply. Catra felt as if he had noticed her presence. She knew he hadn't, but the hammering in her ribs seemed loud enough to alert anyone for miles.

"...I see better now… that I did not give people room to build trust in me… " He pressed on more urgently; shocking Catra. It was then that she conceded to peeking into the entryway. The two figures stood upright in the center of the room. Entrapta was hoisted up by her hair due to Hordak's height; working on some sort of issue with one of his exosuit's shoulder joints. Catra realized that he was wearing gear she had never seen before. It was a chaotic, yet sharp looking patchwork. Even if the slick

chrome of scrap from Prime's armada still made Catra sick to look at… it was then that she wondered if Hordak might feel the same. Additional Eternian data plates were installed at key points: his bracers and abdomen. Somehow, the original, not lost to time as Catra would have assumed, had been reinserted in that same earnest and intimate point. Entrapta had to have been working on this for… weeks… months maybe.

"Entrapta." His firmness was startling. He had clutched at Entrapta's shoulder, forcing her to stop her work. Catra was dumbstruck watching him lift his hand tenderly toward Entrapta's face. This show of intimacy was too much. She stepped away and fled down the hall as if she had been caught. Her figure flickered in and out of view as she outpaced Melog intermittently. She had set out without a plan and– evidently, would leave no more sure of her footing than when she had started. One more moment to swallow; to bury. She couldn't discuss this with Adora, *not a chance* .

"Stupid." She whispered to herself in the dark. The anxious energy bled away with each step. Her pace began to slow. The sentiment of Hordak's admission rattled around in her head. He had validated just the sorts of things that she had hoped to believe in the Fright Zone; the sorts of things she would use to taunt Shadowweaver; to berate herself. It gnawed at the few fragments of her past that she had least felt partially justified in. Her coercion of Hordak… ceaselessly pushing for something resembling safety, stability, power… She did know that she was no longer that person anymore than Hordak was. How the last few months had changed them… more than both of their lives combined. It was beyond imagining. Moments like these threatened to swallow her whole– but as she finally crept softly into the chamber she shared with Adora, and carefully into their bed with Melog at their feet, she reached for faith in herself, as she reached for Adora. This new world of hers was too bright,

cloyingly pink, and occasionally downright obnoxious… but there was hope here too where she looked for it.

Left Field Testing

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta does her best to soothe Hordak in all of his uncertainty before his departure to Beast Island.

Hordak tenderly lifted Entrapta's visor; revealing her open expression. She blinked as she lowered her tools. Entrapta was often told that she was bad at gauging personal space; but his deft movement called her attention to just how close they were.

"You have not asked me to speak for my actions as the others have. Why?" his tone was measured.

"Glimmer had you answer for the mistakes you've made, right? That about covers it… I made the same ones too." Her thoughts about him began and ended with the new clarity that he had not chosen to leave her– as she had thought for months on Beast Island– that, and the necessity of finishing this exosuit.

"I owe you irreconcilable debts. You continue to invest so much time to this. With your efforts needed by Etheria…I understand that our duties could… separate us." He struggled to clarify. "This alone does not disturb me–You have proven yourself my friend still." He brought his fingertips to the focal shard of Eternian data embedded in his newly furnished chest plate.

"If it was up to me, I would be right there with you on Beast Island… it is absolutely brimming with possibility, Hordak. The wealth of artifacts… it's wonderful." Her mirth was so startlingly pure. He realized that she did not carry this same fervent, burning uncertainty within her.

"I don't understand where your trust comes from. I…" He shook his head. "– I want it." Basking in the light of Horde Prime, he had been meant to be above desire. He had known… somewhere, somehow, that Horde Prime could have healed him if he had truly

wanted. To have been left to die had been such a familiar flavour of disrespect. That long-loathed seed that burrowed deep– the imperfection of his frailty was nothing compared to this identity and pride for which he had truly been cast out. He begged it to be one more imperfection that Entrapta might call beautiful.

"I don't understand how we could be lab partners without trusting each other, Hordak." Entrapta tilted her head to the side, incredulous. "I don't have a single reason not to want to be here– and isn't that the wonder of science? No matter where we are, with the technology we have at our fingertips… we can discover everything there is to discover… and–" She pushed her visor back down. A wisp of her hair snaked forward to tap a small node installed near the joint she had been focusing on. Her ensuing laughter echoed. She had installed a comms system and linked it to her upgraded visor. "Hmm… a splash of feedback… and we'll have to do range tests of course…" Mumbling, she severed the audio feed. "Now hold still!" Dumbstruck. He did as he was told.

Entrapta pondered in the silence that followed. He hadn't touched the offering of petite snacks she had brought to his room; though that wasn't much of a surprise. She struggled to define what he was asking of her in his anxiety. Unsure of how to placate him, she could only do what she had always hoped to do… express what she could through the language of tech.

Finally finished, she lifted her visor to admire her work. Her gaze inched up his angular frame. She reached, inspecting his palm. He allowed her to slowly test each joint. Heat rose in his cheeks as her fingers caressed his hand, swept up his arm and across his chest.

She relaxed the tendrils of her hair; steadying herself with a palm pressed firmly to his chest as she sunk to the floor. He clasped it impulsively, imploring her to meet his eye. She stared up at him with that open expression of hers; inviting him to solve this next great foreign equation.

“I don’t know what it is that needs to be said… but I feel it… that there is something worth saying.” He murmured. A knowing smile bloomed across her face; chin jutted upwards, teasing.

“I think we’re saying it. Don’t you?” She leaned in, her cheek now pressed against him. Arrested, he held her face to his chest. She enveloped him. Drawing him nearer with her free hand; her swathes of hair twining them together. Hordak struggled to name his feelings; but of this he was certain. In this moment he was happy.

A Cat in Hell's Chance

Chapter Summary

> In the wake of Hordak's trial, the Princess Alliance gathers in the war room to discuss next steps.

"...Well if you're sure…" Glimmer was dubious. Scorpia shrugged. The Alliance had finally gathered in the war room to pick apart the items that had been left on the cutting room floor while the more pressing matter of intergalactic mind control and tyranny was addressed. Glimmer was exhausted, but it could wait no longer.

"I never really fit in there anyway… All of the Alliance defenses are filtered through Bright Moon in the case of an attack… and it's too painful a place for most of my friends to be. I'll have better luck with Operation: Friendship Thunder in the Crimson Waste." Bow and Perfuma high-fived her in tandem. Glimmer was torn between amusement and exasperation, but it was hard to be negative in the aftermath of their victory.

"Scorpia, I accept your request to abdicate the territory formerly known as the Fright Zone. You are hereby appointed the new negotiating delegate to the free state of the Crimson Waste. Knock yourself out." Glimmer clapped. "Next!" As she scanned the Alliance members sitting across from her, she wondered if she would ever get used to her father sitting in his designated seat… with her own Commander seat left empty. "Are we in agreement regarding Bright Moon's jurisdiction over the Beast Island reclamation project?"

"That mess is all yours." Mermista deflected. To her credit, the rebuild efforts in Salineas were extensive and urgent. It was a

fight to even get her to these delegation meetings.

"I consider it my duty to contribute to healing wherever my gifts are of service, but… my primary responsibility remains Plumeria." Perfuma smiled weakly. Frosta also declined. Always prepared to stomp bots but, due to the wealth of artifacts and ancient data, Beast Island required a more delicate hand. It was for the best.

"No need to play it humble, Sparkles. That's a hot potato I think most people would be passing on." Glimmer had grown fond of the overly familiar nickname, though she'd never admit it. Catra tapped her nails rhythmically against the table. She found it difficult to sit through these long, crowded sessions, but she was trying her best. "After all, Micah is the most informed of the conditions." Scorpia noted that Catra still skirted discussing Entrapta's months on the island whenever possible.

"We'll consider that matter settled as well then. Entrapta, Micah, and I will discuss more actionable planning and present potential options at the next meeting. " Glimmer hated calling him that, he probably hated it too, but as queen she could hardly call him Dad in the war room. "I think it's time to move on to the most… unpleasant matters on the agenda." She looked at Adora, Catra, and Entrapta in turn. "We need to discuss the status of reparations from those once aligned with the horde… in this room and elsewhere." Bow let out a long held breath. It was a downer for sure, but as queen she had no choice.

"I think the percentage of the horde ground troops who defected after the portal event speaks to their willingness to align with Etherians in peace." Adora offered. "The ease with which Horde Prime was able to invade the minds of our allies speaks to the lack

of responsibility that should be placed on the clone refugees.” In agreement, Entrapta nodded enthusiastically.

“That concession won’t suddenly extend to Hordak, Geek Princess, calm down.” Mermista snapped; still struggling with flares of resentment, despite everything.

“Mermista!” Perfuma hissed. “You forget Wrong Hordak.” She had been surprised to find how quickly she had grown fond of the earnest orphan. Though, as she said it, Perfuma found herself wondering if it was even necessary. Entrapta hardly seemed distressed. Adora stifled the urge to contribute further; trying her best not to handle Catra. They had welcomed her as a delegate. This was Catra's chance to take responsibility and hold her own.

“We get it.” Catra’s tone was flat. “There’s a debt to be paid. I cop to manipulating Entrapta. When in full possession of the facts, she has always tried to make the good choice… give or take some act of chaos turned explosion.” She sighed. Her ears flicked back and forth; irritated, with herself probably. “Hell, she actively challenged Hordak and myself leading up to… as Adora put it, *the portal event.* The nutjob has no sense of self preservation whatsoever and somehow teaches machines to love. Come on, guys, I know she sometimes reads as selfish… but I know selfish and she’s not it.” Entrapta was very still throughout Catra’s entire speech, blinking every so often… taking mental snapshots for review later, no doubt. Bow suspected her recorder was on in her pocket. “I’m not going to go all wah-wah take me instead… but Entrapta has paid more dues and just… doesn’t have the same things to answer for.” Catra resisted the urge to rest her forehead against the cool tabletop. She was trying to put her best foot forward here but every word that fell out was clumsy and garbage.

“Based on what I’ve seen from Entrapta…I’m inclined to agree with Catra… no offense.” Micah fumbled.

“Hey, I said it first.” Catra crossed her arms. Folding in on herself. Her skin felt raw from acknowledgement, but she had to admit it; she didn’t hate Micah.

“We all know what Geek Princess does best. Sentence her to a thousand years of tech maintenance and be done with it: Etheria’s endless engineer.” Mermista conceded; clearly uncomfortable with Catra’s display of vulnerability. In spite of her often abrasive tone, she wasn’t trying to send either of them up the river. Bow felt Entrapta’s hair tendrils shift under the table. She was attempting to be respectful by hiding her glee at the prospect of *Etheria’s Endless Engineer*. She wasn’t hiding it well.

“Tell me what you want built and I’ll build it.” Entrapta blurted.

“ *We know.* ” The room declared unanimously before bursting into anxious laughter. Even Catra smirked a little.

“Alright. Entrapta will build us stuff, I guess.” Glimmer settled it with a dismissive hand wave. She was fading faster than she had expected and hated the prospect of getting snippy in the war room. “Let’s take ten.”

“Here here!” Adora launched herself up from her chair. She was still always trying so hard to be the She-Ra in every room. Bow worried at the inside of his cheek. A month ago, he likely would have followed her out into the hallway, but as she slipped down the corridor after Catra, he turned his attention back to Glimmer. She was nursing a headache. He could tell. He offered his arm to her in a comically exaggerated fashion as he approached.

“M’lady.” He grinned that ineffable grin of his. She rolled her eyes as he fluttered his eyelashes.

“That’s ‘Your Highness’ if you insist on being fancy about it.” She offered a little shove as she looped her arm in his. He held his breath for what would follow. A shower of twinkling light burst forth and suddenly they were falling. They landed in Glimmer's bed with a thwump.

“If I have to act with decorum for one more second I will scream!” She warned; and then promptly did so directly into a pillow before chucking it off the ledge; as if it retained the offloaded stress and needed to be disposed of.

“But pillow screaming wasn’t on the agenda until lunch!” He feigned offense as he rolled over, meeting her at the distance that always felt most natural; forehead to forehead. Glimmer’s eyes shuttered closed and the tension in her shoulders leached out. He sure loved this bit.

“I’m sorry.” She murmured. Even smiling at the precious seconds they had stolen for themselves, she couldn’t let go of the niggling

feeling that she was failing everyone; most of all Bow. Even in this, the upcoming discussion of Catra's penance... wasn't Glimmer only avoiding punishment by being Queen? In her heart, didn't she consider herself as guilty as Catra? But after all. Glimmer had paid her price. Her heart lurched. She opened her eyes to the beauty of Bow. Gorgeous, maddening Bow.

"You have nothing to be sorry for." Low and coming from deep in his chest; as if the only language he ever spoke was I Love You. She threaded her hands through his hair as they delved into as deep a kiss as they could afford to spend time on. After a number of these precious forever never sort of seconds, he pulled away.

"If you keep this up; Mermista is going to stage a coup." He chuckled.

"Me! You're the one who refuses to be anything but adorable." She bopped him on the head with a pillow. They sat up together. She blushed every time like it was the first time. He couldn't get enough of it. He reached, smoothing her royally mussed hair.

"I really am irresistible, aren't I?" He feigned confidence but was blushing just as furiously. Glimmer scoffed.

"Alright. Alright. One two three: Queen face." She slapped her cheeks. He did the same.

“Four five six: General face.” They locked eyes with mock severity before reaching out. Glitter burst forth and deposited them back in the war room cackling. Everyone beamed back with infuriatingly smug grins; barring Catra and Mermista who mimed gagging; and Frosta and Entrapta whose mouths were full of teensy snacks and paid them no mind.

“We really need to get ourselves some new friends.” Glimmer mumbled out of the corner of her mouth. Brushing herself off; this time, really donning her ‘Queen Face’. Bow could afford to keep his cheeky grin. *Lucky.* Oh well. His poker face was terrible anyway.

“Hijinx aside… It’s your turn, Catra.” Glimmer settled stiffly into her seat.

“Bring it on, Sparkles.” She seemed more settled than they had before the break. Glimmer was pacified in realizing that she wasn’t the only one who had needed it. “Go on. I can hack it.”

“Arguably… the consequences of your actions in the horde are still felt most strongly in Salineas and the Whispering Wood.” Glimmer dove right in. “Would you like the floor, Mermista?” The water princess pondered for a moment, offering Catra a wary glance. She shrugged her shoulders.

“Forcing her to aid in the rebuild of Salineas, sopping wet, sure sounds like a fun time, G, but it would probably be about as productive as getting this one to stop setting fire to boats.” she

jerked a thumb sharply to Seahawk. Wounded; he clutched his chest.

"There, there, buddy." Swift Wind rested a well-meaning hoof on his shoulder.

"I hate to admit it, but if we're talking about putting the effort where it's most needed… Catra's place is probably in the FFZ." The Former Fright Zone really was just too wordy. Bow pinned it mentally for further discussion. Catra bristled at the implication. Adora fought the urge to reach for Catra's hand under the table. Sometimes, it felt like she was dating a cactus. "She's the most knowledgeable about its conditions— arguably even more so than Hordak since apparently he was a shut-in or whatever. But–" Mermista pivoted. "Look, I don't think you're to be trusted in command." She challenged Catra directly. Catra bit back a hiss.

"I can respect your reasoning for that, Your Highness." Catra's response took on that falsely cloying tinge that had once only been reserved for antagonizing Adora. Bow winced at the tension. After all, not everyone in this room had spent weeks on a bonding space quest with this prickly new delegate of theirs. "With that in mind, what do you propose we do?" Catra expected Mermista not to have an answer; but she didn't back down.

"She-Ra is needed wherever and whenever." She offered. "But what Adora really needs is something to stop her from chucking herself headlong into danger at every possible opportunity."

Catra smirked. “In that, we’re in agreement.” Adora, affronted, now mirrored Seahawk’s expression. They commiserated silently across the table. Bow fought a chuckle. Glimmer was wrong. These were just the friends they needed.

“I think Adora should be your boss. Two fish; one net. You’ll hate it, and she won’t be throwing herself in harm’s way.” Adora’s stomach bottomed out at the suggestion. Mermista's ability to goad was unparalleled. Catra would never–

“You’re right. I will hate it. But I’m meant to be paying penance, aren’t I?” Catra shrugged. Shockingly aloof. Adora couldn’t read whether she was putting it on. “Adora gets everything she ever wanted.” The words still sent lightning through Adora, said so many times with a rumbling of revulsion threaded through them, but… was Catra trying to make a *joke* ? “After all, she’s *obsessed* with me.” Catra nudged her. Adora looked to her with incredulity.

“Uhh…Catra?” Adora had no idea how to respond.

“Look,” Catra switched gears. “The Fright Zone is a blight of nothingness. It’s just… damage, through and through.” She was firmly earnest now. “Who better to solve that, than us?” The room burst with affection at the remarkably tender declaration.

“Aaaaaw!” Adora flung her arms around Catra as Glimmer, Scorpia, and Bow yelled. Mermista and Frosta cackled at Catra’s cresting discomfort. Even Perfuma let out a soft chuckle. Though her reaction seemed more inspired by Scorpia's glee.

“My GOD, get off me! We’re in public!” Catra cried. “I take it back. I reject this proposal. Send me to Beast Island!” Entrapta looked up; startled at the noise. It had seemed that she had checked out of the conversation but she surprised everyone with a comment.

"Catra is pretty easily remembered as horde captain. Won't the Fright Zone be... kinda... really mad?" She had a point. Glimmer thought it over.

"There are going to be a lot of force captains reckoning with their role in the violence, this can also be a part of that assessment process, especially with Adora at the ready. It's probably going to take a long time for Catra to earn any sense of trust, but... It seems a lot more possible with her than it was with Hordak." Glimmer wondered if this might be a biased choice... but hey, in the end she was Queen. Someone had to make it. "Consider the matter settled. Meeting adjourned. Same time next week?"

The group dissolved into various clusters of chat as they dispersed. Micah hung back to watch Glimmer and Bow chat quietly at the table in their own little world. To think, this proud, capable woman was his fricken kid. Ten years lost weren't easily forgotten. As Bow threw his head back, laughing at something Glimmer had said, Micah wrestled with a different grief. It had been necessary during his time on the Island to believe any good thing he could grab at with both hands. With a child grown it was expected that he be able to share that pride with his partner... He turned away. He wouldn't muddle their happiness with his fretting. After all, their hope for peace in Etheria’s near future was starting to seem like a real possibility. A sudden burst of twinkling shook him as Bow and Glimmer appeared in front of him.

"Come on, Dad, let's grab lunch. We're starving!" Glimmer beamed up at him. Smirking, Micah locked eyes with Bow. A man knew when he was caught.

"Sounds good to me." He laughed softly as he swung his arms around the pair of them. "Sounds good to me."

A Horde Clone by Any Other Name

Chapter Summary

> With the help of Swift Wind and Perfuma, Wrong Hordak takes a necessary step in developing his sense of identity.

"I like totally get it, man. I mean, if it were up to Adora, my name would be Horsie? Come on." Swift Wind scoffed. Wrong Hordak and Swift Wind were chatting as they set up the snack table in the Erlandian ceremony hall for the latest session with the Horde clone refugees. Wrong Hordak had taken great pride in the knowledge he was gaining from Cinnabar, Bonnie, and Pip–Entrapta's kitchen team in Dryl.

"Yes! Exactly! I must shed the final shackles of Horde Prime and relinquish this name of convenience. I have chosen a name befitting my newfound personal identity!" He raised a fist in excitement.

"EXCELLENT." Swift Wind whinnied exuberantly. "So, go on! Tell us!"

"No–This momentous reveal must be shared with my brothers. I believe it to be an excellent opportunity for bonding." Wrong Hordak tented his fingers excitedly; his eyes sparkling. Perfuma, who was laying pillows down for their meditation circle, looked up with concern. She raised a tentative hand.

"Now, er– is it OK if I keep calling you Wrong Hordak until you've made your announcement?" She interrupted herself.

“Ah yes. It will do for now.” Wrong Hordak nodded. “Please continue, Perfuma.”

“It’s important to remember that each of you, your brothers, Hordak even… You are all on different personal journeys. Embrace your path, but let the others find their own way. OK?” Wrong Hordak had a tendency to occasionally run away with his horses… literally. Swift Wind had revealed himself to be a very motivating influence, to Perfuma’s occasional irritation.

“But shouldn’t it be the very first step in actualizing, Perfuma?” Wrong Hordak declared this as if he hadn’t been ‘actualizing’ for quite some time. She breathed deeply. Patience was key, and after all, it *was* getting pretty confusing as Scorpia successfully recruited more and more refugees to their sessions. Names would be good.

“Time will only tell. We’ll see how everyone is feeling first, OK?” She clapped. “They should be here any minute.”

–

“It’s a terrible name. I hate it.” One of the more aggressive clones spat. There was significant difference to the structure of his right hand. The fingers permanently curled inward as if attempting a fist. His criticism clearly crushed their newly named companion, Leaf.

“Now, now. We talked about this. Expressing your emotions is healthy, but it’s important to remember that the name Leaf has chosen isn’t also *your* name.” Perfuma placated. “You no longer have to… share.”

“Are you sure? Because it seems something that could be adapted to.” One of the more supplicant clones mumbled. He was still not at all comfortable speaking about his own feelings or existence. He rarely referred to himself at all.

“Does this mean we are no longer brothers?” Another nervous clone called out. Their hair was still slicked militantly back; as dictated previously by Horde Prime.

“No!” Leaf’s response was spirited. “I am sharing this beautiful ceremony with you all *because* we are brothers.” He put his fist to his chest. “We deserve this sense of identity that Horde Prime withheld from us!” Some clones gasped. Not everyone was ready to shed those final shackles just yet. Though, Leaf’s speech surprisingly resonated with some of the more bitterly grieving clones.

“I like the idea of taking back what’s ours.” Their aggressively outspoken companion admitted. Perfuma wasn’t sure how well all of this was going. She tried to move things in a more productive direction.

“Let’s take this moment to establish a sense of appreciation for this… freedom that Leaf is talking about.” She gestured to him encouragingly. “What inspired you to choose your new name?”

“Leaves!” He offered excitedly, if unhelpfully.

“We gathered that.” This clone could snark all he liked, but he was more engaged in the discussion than he had been in weeks. Perfuma hid a small smile with the back of her hand. She had to admit… this might have been a necessary step.

“When I first entered Erlandia, its stone enclosure settled my nerves.” Leaf tried again. “I felt once more connected to the Armada.” He looked down at his hands. “... but it struck me then, a new feeling, one of…” He looked to Perfuma for assistance. She shrugged; at a loss for the word he was searching for. “I realized that I had grown accustomed to the nature of planets.” Perfuma’s eyes brightened with recognition.

“You missed the plants; the leaves.” She smiled and turned to the rest of the group. “Allow that idea to inhabit your sense of harmony.” She encouraged. “Can anyone think of anything that they hold appreciation for?” Their chatty and bitter friend spoke up once more.

“The spyre was once a symbol of Prime’s chokehold.” He clutched his damaged hand. “It is now a symbol of his defeat and our freedom.”

“Excellent contribution!” Perfuma rewarded him with a smile. He did not like it.

“I shall be called Spyre now. Does that mean I can leave?” He implored flatly.

“No one is obligated to stay.” Perfuma said, not for the first time, but with a newfound confidence. After all, he kept coming back. “But we only serve snacks at the end.” Spyre slouched, crossing his arms and fidgeting on his meditation pillow. If he was only staying for the snacks, Perfuma was still going to call it a win: baby steps. It was then that one of the more timid clones raised their hand. Leaf reached out his arms encouragingly.

“The Velvet Glove, our prior home, was orderly and reliable.” They began. “We cannot go back… as it has been completely destroyed–” their tone wavered as they stifled a wave of emotion. “Prior. We appreciated what came before.”

“Thank you for your vulnerability, Prior.” Perfuma was touched. It wasn’t much, but it was the first time they had ever spoken in session. At Perfuma’s acknowledgement of this tentative moniker, they continued to look fairly aggrieved; but it was something. The remaining clones looked to each other anxiously. It was clear they weren’t quite ready yet for this exercise. Perfuma cast another glance to Pyre. Despite his backchat, his gaze scanned the reactions of his brothers. He was listening very actively.

“Let’s now take a moment to reflect and rebalance.” Perfuma directed. Spyre rolled his eyes at this. “...and then we can break for snacks.” She conceded. *Bright Moon wasn’t built in a day.*

The Nature of the Beast

Chapter Summary

> Hordak and Bow contend with Beast Island and setting up the research base.

It had turned out that their preparations to establish a base camp on Beast Island took considerably more time than Glimmer had hoped. It was weeks before they could be properly settled with supply lines organized and a rough map of the quadrants layed out. This made little difference to Hordak. He would go where he was led and do what he was told. It was not so unlike the life he had told himself for so many years to want. He could hardly be dissatisfied with it now, could he? Hordak grimaced at the wild humidity that affronted him as he disembarked from Darla. *Maybe he could.*

Spending so much of his time on this bewildering planet shut away in his sanctum in the Fright Zone… he had forgotten the distress that was weather. Bow followed close behind, directing former Rebellion volunteers as they offloaded the necessary supplies. He looked down to his trackpad, tapping away. After all of the time he spent wrangling Entrapta and Wrong Hordak in space, Bow felt oddly at ease with this rigid new companion.

"OK. First order of business, finishing securing the primary base. Then we'll attempt to get the comms up for your field reports. You will be reporting mostly to me, Adora, Perfuma, and of course Entrapta." He paused to answer a question from one of the other volunteers, but circled back quickly. "...you will meet with Perfuma sometime next week and every few weeks after that– yes, it's mandatory." Bow answered Hordak's expression. "Her work with

the other Horde Clones so far has revealed… that… well. You guys need a little TLC.”

“TLC?” Hordak didn’t recognize the initialism. Was it some sort of herbal treatment? He understood that Perfuma was the wielder of chlorokinesis.

“Nevermind.” Bow hedged. Hordak had a feeling he was not going to enjoy this “TLC”.

“I understand we are attempting to relocate as many of the artifacts as possible for study?” Hordak queried. Bow nodded.

“Based on the info we’ve gathered so far, the biomes respond well when we reduce the concentration of First One’s tech. It also gives us the opportunity to improve our historical archive of Etheria and benefit from what remains of the technology. Perfuma will also be reporting on the state of the greenery here and how it compares to other parts of Etheria. We’re hoping to map the entire biome.”

“Then the experiments on the tech… would need to take place offsite.” Hordak deflated slightly.

“Yes. Entrapta will be spearheading all of the tech breakdown at Dryl. She has the most intact equipment. Plus, it’s the most fortified and secluded location in case more corrupted discs are found.” Bow did not yet know how to reconcile Hordak looking…

pouty. “Buck up–” Bow faltered. He was going to say “buddy” but… nope. Not happening. “Er– look. Like I said. You’ll be making frequent reports. She’s going to be on the receiving end of most if not all of them. Let’s get to work!”

–

Entrapta’s improvements on his exosuit made the considerable labour of defining their base much easier than Hordak anticipated. There was warmth in this newfound strength. Confident? Was that how he was feeling? Bow began pitching rope tethers with his arrows to get them rigged out of reach of beasts and bots. His grace and agility discomfited Hordak. He shook his head and turned back to securing the retrofitted transport tank that they were going to use for perishable supplies. Micah had warned that something about the signal interference also made all things on the island unpredictable: beasts, bots, climate, even the perceived passage of time; but they were hoping establishing the comms system would help with that at least.

As Hordak shifted crates, something shiny poked out from the stirred dirt. He knelt to inspect it. A First One’s data crystal. It was significantly damaged… but it seemed a promising omen none the less.



This was the sort of thing he was meant to report. Bow would send scans of the data crystal to Entrapta. If he waited until the comms system was running then he could show her himself. Would that be such a terrible transgression? He sighed.

"Bow!" He called begrudgingly. Bow made his way over.

"Solid work breaking down the supply crates." Bow was impressed at how consistent Hordak's autonomous work was. Maybe he would earn 'Buddy' sooner than he thought.

"I found this." Hordak extended a hand. Bow examined the crystal carefully.

"I'll send a scan to Adora so she can check out the inscription, but of course, it'll be up to Entrapta to unpack the data."

“Ah. Yes. It makes reasonable sense for her to be able to read Eternian.” Hordak was clearly quite shocked despite his words. “Then this will be sent to Entrapta today?”

“No. On its own, especially damaged, it is a lot harder to extract data. Getting a bigger picture of what artifacts we find in each section will help Entrapta troubleshoot. We’re going to gather any significant items together sorted by section. Then, we’ll send them off in batches for her to make sense of.” Bow patted Hordak on the shoulder. This was regretted instantly as Hordak scowled deeply. “A-alright, I’m going to run the ship back for the final batch of equipment. We’ve designated another transport tank to sort and secure finds like this. But, good job, Hordak. Keep it up!” Baffled at his circumstances; Bow shook his head. He jogged back to the ship. Hordak was left feeling similarly disoriented, but at least he had work to do to keep his mind from... wandering.

Putting Down Roots

Chapter Summary

> Perfuma readies for her first trip to Beast Island as Scorpia struggles with change.

Scorpia tapped her claws together hesitantly. “So, this whole Beast Island with Hordak thing?” She puttered around Perfuma’s cozy yurt in Plumeria, nervous, as Perfuma packed.

“Bow has really put some effort into organizing. His dads would be proud. Since I’ll come and go with the supply runs. I’ll only be gone for a few days at a time.” Perfuma smiled brightly. “It won’t take too much away from my responsibilities in Plumeria or the work with the clone refugees in Elberon and Erlandia.”

“Right…” Scorpia struggled to hide her trepidation. Perfuma turned abruptly and placed her hands on Scorpia’s shoulders.

“Of course, it will be hard to be apart, but we still have the clone sessions and you have your work cut out for you in The Waste.”

“Don’t remind me.” Scorpia was torn between her flickering confidence and her affection for Perfuma.

“You are going to be fabulous. Huntara has said nothing but good things, I’m sure.”

“You think so?” Scorpia hung her head and looked to Perfuma through sheepish lashes. Perfuma pulled her into a firm hug.

“I know so!” She locked her fingers to hang off of Scorpia playfully. “And aren’t you so excited to work with Flint and Fletcher on tracing your family history through The Waste to the Fright Zone?” Scorpia brightened.

“Y’know… I really am!” Her infectious optimism burst forth with renewed vigor. Perfuma planted a firm kiss on her cheek. “You’re right, Perfuma. This is important. The first step to understanding my family!” Perfuma cheered in support. “Gosh. I hope they like me. It was so nice of George and Lance to reach out to them.”

“Who *wouldn’t* like you!” Perfuma patted Scorpia’s cheek. “It really is a blessing that two of Bow’s brothers specialize in Historical anthropology… then again, twelve historians… some of them had to.” She chuckled.

“Only eight historians, remember.” Scorpia laughed. “Man, am I glad I was not at that family dinner…”

“More than half! I’m sure George and Lance are perfectly content with such a talented and bountiful family.” Perfuma’s smile was small and coy, like a sealed envelope. She looked up to Scorpia brightly and pulled her in for a sudden kiss.

“What was that for?” Scorpia was delightfully flustered.

“Because, I love you of course.” She patted at Scorpia’s arm absently and resumed her packing; humming contentedly. Scorpia’s smile crested like dawn.

“My Heart-Blossom.” Scorpia scooped Perfuma into her arms. In her shock, Perfuma upturned her bag: all of her work undone.

“Scorpia!” Perfuma squealed playfully. Vines and roots threaded up from the earthen floor to nudge her items barely back into the bag. “That’ll just have to do!” She laughed, giving Scorpia a squeeze, “How about we head up the hill for a final meditation before bed? It’s nearly sunset.”

“Sounds perfect.” Scorpia exited the yurt with Perfuma still in her arms; laughing. Perfuma would so often happily fold into Scorpia’s whims. She didn’t fight her affection or demand to be put down. Scorpia’s heart swelled with gratitude for this gorgeous girl; her partner.

First Things First

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta, absorbed by her work in Dryl, gets a visit from a friend.

The rebuild work was slow and tedious, but of course Etherians were grateful for the comfortable monotony after so many years of strife and war. But none so much as Entrapta.

Whether it was a mission or a banishment or a forced relocation, Entrapta had scrabbled along with whatever belongings she could scoop while being dragged for a couple of years now. There was some relief in returning to the truly familiar and secluded Dryl. It's faint purple glow, the smooth metal walls, and the clinking and chittering of her machines.

Leaf hadn't taken to her interests as she had hoped. He wasn't hungry for science the way she was. But, he had taken an interest in baking in the wake of Catra's rescue and he had found new purpose in acclimating his brothers to Etheria– even if Hordak and he had a ways to go in their bonding journey.

Entrapta was relieved that Cinnabar, Bonnie, and Pip had not been harmed during their time with the rebellion… where more often than not they had faced off against her own machines. That was still very difficult for Entrapta to think about… but they had welcomed Leaf with open arms and went about their business as usual. Based on her collected observations, they seemed relieved that she was home too. Especially when they had discovered Bow had helped her record and remember their real names. She was learning more and more every day from Bow about discerning,

and acting on, what her friends needed. She hoped that teaching him more about tech was as exciting for him as he said that it was. She wanted to be fair now that she had a better idea of what that looked like.

The sparks inspired by her soldering iron showered her vision like falling stars. Bent nearly double over her latest experiment with only the soft glow from her illuminated face shield to guide her, her work was meticulous. It had to be. She had been working on boosting the comms signal for communications with the Beast Island team nearly non-stop. It was taking so much longer than they had anticipated; but science could not be rushed. Navigating the heavy levels of interference on Beast Island, as fascinating as the signal readings were, had begun to wear on Entrapta. After all, she had set up a plan. Hordak was counting on her, the team was counting on her. She was alarmed by how unsettled it was making her to have Hordak out of sight again. Every second in testing proved a second too long.

She wasn't sure how much time had passed when she was roused from her experiments by Bow. He held a parcel of machine parts in one hand and a tray of tiny snacks in the other. Entrapta whistled. Bow tried not to flinch as a small metallic creature descended from one of the air vents and landed on his shoulder. It emitted a series of beeps in greeting.

"Sophie, please thank Bonnie." Entrapta patted the bot on the head tenderly. Bow stifled a grin. Sophie chirped and scurried off to complete her mission. Entrapta's brow furrowed as she locked on to the items in Bow's hands once more. He could only blame her fatigue on her lack of animation. He made the decision for her as she began to reach for the "wrong" hand. He tucked the machine parts behind his back.

“Eat.” Bow brought the plate up to her face. She plucked a small cake from the tray and munched with tangible delight while the tendrils of her hair snaked behind his back and plucked the parcel from his fingers. He laughed as he threw his palms up in surrender. Battle ready, he may be, but even a fatigued Entrapta was a sharp Entrapta. Visiting was always a constant game of tag.

The strands of her hair, like nimble fingers, tore the wrapping from the parcel as she popped a tea sandwich into her mouth. She poured the contents onto her workbench. To the untrained ear, Entrapta's laughter mingled with the crackling stormy weather that frequented Dryl, echoed ominously down the hallway. But Bow was just happy to make his friend smile. He knew that her happiness did not always look like his happiness… but that didn’t mean that she was free of worry. Her movements were more chaotic in her anxiety. He could almost see her brain lag and her thoughts slip from her grasp as she attempted to task-switch. So many things to do and she was desperate to do them all at once. That’s where the hair came in.

For all of the jaw dropping power he was a ready witness to… speed and might and wind and ice… the quiet diligence of Entraptas precise tendrils might be the most impressive. After all, Dryl lacked a runestone. Her power was one of Etheria’s many mysteries. Bow’s working theory was that she willed her hair into existence because two hands just weren’t enough. He wouldn’t put it past her. He ducked as a chunk of metal flew past his head.

“Need a hand?” She spun around; startled. Evidently, she had altogether forgotten he was visiting.

“Oh, Bow! Excellent timing. Help me with this beautiful baby.” A fist of her hair clutching a wrench waved him over. The core of the comms system was gutted. Wires spilled from the uncapped casing like a tangle of electric spaghetti. “Blue, blue, red, green, blue. Got it?” she stuffed a soldering wand and a pair of pliers into his hands.

“Aye aye, Captain!” he hunkered down to work as she made her way across the room to a wide wall populated with the scrawlings of a madwoman. Indecipherable symbols and equations, some in the language of the First Ones, some in Etherian, and a few doodles of what looked to be potential future bots and her own exasperated expressions. She muttered into her recorder fervently. Bow only caught the occasional word. He knew the wall was a monument to her current obsession: stable mid-range teleportation. She had been inspired by the nearly world-ending portal technology of the First Ones and Horde Prime, along with Glimmer’s ever widening range of abilities as she combined her father’s sorcery with her now fully realized connection to the moonstone.

The technology had the potential to revolutionize trade and foreign policy across Etheria… but it relied on more time commitment than Glimmer could regularly afford to experiment with… and Entrapta had been unceremoniously ejected from Mysticore after one too many explosions. Though she hadn’t been officially banned… it had been strongly implied.

Bow didn’t doubt the experiment’s many practical applications… but he knew the root of Entrapta’s obsession was seeded elsewhere. The corrosive interference ever present on Beast Island amidst the heavily degraded First Ones artifacts and trapped, festering pockets of Etheria’s once viable magics was

making distance communications damn near impossible. Everyone was still processing the bond between Hordak and Entrapta, but if Scorpia was to be believed, they had spent nearly every waking moment together in the Fright Zone. If it was anything like how he felt when he was separated from Glimmer, getting comms working was going to have to get very possible right quick if Beast Island knew what was good for it.

A Riot of Flowers

Chapter Summary

> Perfuma struggles to bond with Beast Island's natural bounty. Hordak struggles with self care.

Perfuma hummed softly to herself in an attempt to self-soothe. Her rigid grin belied her exasperation. Harmonious work with Hordak was proving… a challenge. She knew the necessity of giving grace regarding his disordered eating. After all, it was a persistent issue documented for most of the horde clone refugees. But none of the other refugees were quite… so… rude… even the really angry ones like Spyre.

"I do not understand why I am expected to consume this." He stared mournfully into the cupful of broth. She sighed. This adult man was affronted by soup.

"It is your first step in recognizing the importance of balancing hydration and nourishment. This blend is designed based on your body's needs." He flinched at the word *needs* . He really was a tricky case. He was manifesting almost all of the difficulties across the different reactions the clones were having. Aggressive; self-loathing; seeking attention while still avoiding to be perceived… *How did this thorn in her side nearly conquer all of Etheria?*

"The ration bars I had designed achieved that balance. Give me those" He was obstinate. He was also very medically wrong.

“Your previous… meal plan… had you–and the entire horde for that matter– constantly struggling and undernourished, Hordak.” She tried to hold his gaze but he refused. “Your body deserves gratitude. You can’t keep using the exosuit as an excuse to neglect it.” She uncrossed her legs and rose to her feet. He may be mandated to attend her sessions, but she wasn’t mandated to keep putting up with his shit. “If you try it and hate it we can work on alternatives that offer… textural consistency like you’re accustomed to– but these next few months are about repairing the damage the horde has done. That damage includes your sense of self-neglect. Whether either of us like it or not.” She smoothed the folds of her skirt. “I am going to go attune with the aura of the Her-Ra microforest in sector A. Hopefully Entrapta’s and Bow’s distance signal scramble trial has made some difference.” The test had been active for a few days; but it was proving inconsistent. “The day we manage to permanently liberate Beast Island from the core signal can’t come soon enough.”

“That day would arrive vastly sooner if Entrapta could operate on-site.” Hordak grumbled petulantly into his soup. Perfuma’s indignation deflated slightly. Yet another similarity he shared with his brothers, this earnest loyal naivety. It wasn’t her cup of tea, but she felt she was beginning to understand the bond between him and Entrapta.

“Yes. Well. We’re all doing our best.” She forced another smile. “Entrapta was the one who put together all of the clone biodata, you know.“ Hordak seemed torn for a moment in how to respond. Dutifully, he took a sip of soup. Perfuma could barely believe it. She’d have to keep that trick in her back pocket for later.

“It is not completely unpleasant.” He assessed charitably. Perfuma rolled her eyes.

“Glad to hear it.” She made her leave with a halfhearted wave. Progress was progress after all.

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Her mood improved among the wild tangle as she picked her way across Beast Island. The atmosphere seemed to be shifting now that the Heart of Etheria Project was no longer siphoning off Etheria’s magic, but it was also proving to clash more readily with the degraded First One’s tech junked all around them. Maybe if there were some promising samples in the Her-Ra biome, Perfuma could bring one home for Scorpia as a surprise. Occasionally, it felt that the island was playing tricks on her, but she did eventually arrive unscathed.

The Her-Ra biome was isolated with a projection shield put in place by Glimmer. Micah wasn’t up to returning any time soon. They were attempting to gather information on the naturally occurring plants on the island. If Perfuma successfully classified them based on the other types of plants in Etheria, it would redouble their nature restoration efforts. She checked up on her babies one at a time; frowning more and more deeply as she went.

They were barely hanging on. It was as if they had been removed from a needed resource. Was it possible the plants had adapted to the existence of tech contaminants, or was the absence of the signal affecting their natural rhythm? It was too soon to be sure; but it was evident they were sick. She would gather another soil sample for Bow once she had given them all a bit of a pick me up.

She splayed out her fingers as she took in deep calming breaths and recited her mantra in her head. From her core, where she imagined her connection to Etheria blossomed, she reached with considerable difficulty. It was taking longer than she had anticipated. Before she knew it she was sweating. Still, it seemed like she was reaching out into a bottomless expanse.

Perfuma hadn't felt pulled in this many directions since the Heart Blossom had started to fade. These plants felt the same. If she could overcome cacti, she could overcome this. She huffed.

"Quit being so difficult!" She groaned. Throwing her hands up. If she couldn't get to the bottom of this, she would be useless to the terraforming effort. She lowered herself to the ground, attempting to center. Cross-legged in the dirt, she opened her consciousness to the needs of Beast Island. As far as she reached it seemed cold. Barren. The magic of Etheria still roiled beneath her and in the air… but it was as if the island itself did not exist. Cut out of the planet like the eye of a potato. It filled her with a deep sense of dread. She jumped up with a start; trying to shake off the feeling.

She struggled with whether this was worth bringing up to Bow. Was she just being sensitive? It had taken her years to reveal the secrets of Cacti… was it simply inexperience? They couldn't afford to take that long to find out. She would sleep on it and try again in the morning.

A Moment Alone

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta and Hordak run the latest test for long distance communications to Beast Island.

Hordak tried not to pace. Every inch of him was buzzing with a nervous energy he wanted to claw off. He was still working on the temper his anxiety fed. He settled for begrudging deep breathing and clenching his fists. The mandatory decree of something called meditation hosted by a nightmare of a woman named Perfuma was proving a herculean task. It had only been a couple of months, though the gains felt glacial… they were undeniable most of the time. The fizzing spiral of doubt that threatened to unfurl in his mind was sharply interrupted by a crackle of static and a single warbled note.

"-AK!" Her enthusiasm resulted in a poorly timed greeting and one eyeball was all he could see at first. He had primed the speakers too loud. A heart-attack in three different ways. All of them very welcome. For years he had told himself that seclusion was necessary, as he was allegiant only to Prime… he never thought the day would come where he would exalt in a lack of connection to the hive mind and yearn for a different kind of connection altogether.

"Entrapta." The audio synced straight to her earpiece as planned. His wary baritone felt like the hum of Darla's engine room across her skin; heady; soothing; and hers. The tendrils of her hair pulled taut, launching her as close to the screen as possible. There he was. Like Leaf but not really. There was something to the set of his jaw, how his hair was a little tousled. She could tell

he was stressed. The receiving visuals were still grainy… But she would fix that.

"I have plans for three additional tests to boost the scramble signal and amplify for video and the only thing stopping me is waiting on parts to arrive from Bow but Glimmer agreed to teleport him here as soon as he gets them so they should arrive very very fast if only faster was possible but the object transfer project based in Bright Moon's runestone and Glimmer's sorcery is still very temperamental–oh the POSSIBILITY, Hordak!" Each syllable peppered out like the fire of an automatic weapon, but to Hordak it may as well have been the peaceful thrum of rain on a roof.

He still struggles very much with staying in the present. The mapping of his neurons is irrevocably carved through the machinations of Horde Prime. Data deemed "important" seeking to ping off of every potential link and connection to reveal what is "valuable". The consequences of these patterns of thought are so very different now.

Her petite hands in ill fitting gloves clutching his arm. Her adamant lack of fear and burning curiosity illuminating the cultivated nocturne of the Fright Zone. Each moment a loose pebble in a path to the moment where he realizes he is long past trying to make her afraid. An errant quirk of an eyebrow as she demands to peculiarly persist. Launching herself upward to meet his eye– suspended by the tendrils of her hair. Ever odd yet never provoking… whispering, inaudible, that he can choose to be odd too. The shards of memory did this occasionally; sprinkling like snow. Though, not always such pleasant memories as this.

“...Is Gloria being supportive? Of course she is, she’s wonderful, but I can work on upgrade patches to fix her… enthusiasm issue… Tell me about your progress–hold on–where’s my recorder.” Something, he’s unsure what, launches him back to this imperfect present with her. Her swaths of hair obscure the screen as she shuffles about. Finally, she recentres and her face, her expression, comes into full view. Her gaze, often avoidant, is magnetic now.

"Yes. Er– Gloria is… performing much better in tandem with Emily." He surprised himself as he realized how true that was. He had started to discern when Entrapta was being pandered to and it pacified him to recognize that he was not. It was often like this. Her very presence taught him a language he had never been able to use– Gave him a voice with which to say the things he believed but struggled to convey. She cackled with voracious delight.

"My girls! They’re getting along. Isn’t it wonderful? I–" she cut herself off abruptly. Her expression froze for a moment like a delay in transmission. The sharp click of her visor wounded Hordak as it shuttered over her expression; shielding her from him. But he was no stranger to the impulse. It was his guess that she had halted herself from saying *I wish I was there.* In truth, they both knew that it was more complicated than that. He tried again to call upon the infernal teachings of Perfuma. *Make space; practice honesty* .

"I too am grateful for their support–" he faltered. "All of your contributions have been… wonderful." he borrowed her word. "The importance of your work cannot be discounted… even when done at a distance” The feeling in his chest reminded him of the frailty of his form in the time before her. Before her diligent and tender work on his life support mechanics. He touched his fingertips lightly to the bright purple shard of First One's tech

embedded in his chest plate. "It is truly beautiful… this commitment to advancement in Etheria…in science… rebuilding. I am grateful that we are lab partners." He coughed.

His clumsy efforts were rewarded. She lifted the visor again to reveal her eyes. Brimming, as she would say, with the infinite possibility of the ever expanding vastness of space. He marveled for no more than one precious second. It was then that the connection faltered. Static skittered across the screen. Chunks blinking out: the roar of white noise assaulted him as the feed was cut.

He clenched his fists in the darkness. But he would not damage their equipment, so necessary and fragile, with undue violence as he might have once done. Haggard, he breathed deeply once more. As he reached for his tools and opened up one of the side panels in the transport tank they were using to establish the comms system he reminded himself that there was always tomorrow. They would keep trying. As he extracted the parts that had shorted out, he repeated Entrapta's words to himself. "Failure is a vital part of all scientific endeavor."

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Entrapta was still in the silence that followed. Stuck in the echo of their conversation. It whirred in her head like a motorized cog. She could not, would not, sacrifice her current work in Dryl. She was going to buckle down and whip this comms system into shape. They would solve the signal problem. She would continue the valuable work of viable teleportation systems with Glimmer. It was all going to work out. It had to.

Redux

Chapter Summary

Catra buries the hatchet with Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle.

The blonde bouncy one. She is gone? Melog didn't speak, necessarily… it was more like a sequence of pictures and feelings.

"In a meeting with Bow and Entrapta." Catra answered aloud. "Something about needing She-Ra for an upcoming experiment on Beast Island. Eternian tech for her to read and activate and all that."

You are not pleased to do this alone. Melog was a little too quick on the uptake for Catra's liking sometimes.

"No. I'm not. But, it's gotta get done." She shrugged; there was no point in attempting to lie. Bright Moon had sent Scorpia ahead to announce her abdication and gauge the reaction of the public to Catra and Adora being appointed as delegates. Though she'd reported that everyone seemed 'A-OK' with the idea, Catra doubted the truthfulness of that. Scorpia's tendency to see silver clouds with gray lining made Catra wary of just how sunshiney this meeting was going to go.

Then it is good. That you are not alone. Melog's calming presence was palpable even as they faded from sight. Catra steeled herself at the entrance to the former Horde mess hall. With one final breath she swung the doors open.

It was more or less the same, though some tables had been converted into what looked like first aid stations. Some clusters looked like they were eating or taking a break. Others were entrenched in more serious discussion with papers strewn about. One such person was Lonnie. She stood only a few feet away, directing a cluster of other vets. She caught Catra's entrance from the corner of her eye.

"Look what the cat dragged in." Lonnie approached her with a tinge of smugness. This was going to be so goddamn awkward.

"Har-har. How I missed your razor wit." Catra deadpanned. "This might not mean much… but it's good to see you still kicking."

"I liked to pretend that you dying would have made me happy, when you were being especially… y'know. You." Lonnie shrugged. "But it wasn't true. Take it or leave it, you may be Catra, but you're still one of us." She leaned in conspiratorially. "Plus– Shadow Weaver was a straight up bitch." She elbowed. Catra cackled.

"Oh boy, I could hear that a few more times." She was visibly relieved; it surprised Lonnie. The last time they had seen each other… Catra had been so tense that the only emotion she was capable of showing was freak-out. Her time away from the FFZ had clearly done wonders.

“Catra!” Kyle called out gleefully as he jogged over from a nearby table. He had been distributing food. Real food. They had clearly made their first order of business getting rid of the ration bars. “You’re not dead!”

“Fancy that.” The sarcasm fell out before Catra could reign it in. She tried again. “--Sorry, Kyle. Old habits. Good to see you.” He looked like she had just given him a lifetime supply of chocolate. Suddenly, there was hugging. She hated the hugging. “Alright, alright. Are we going to get down to business? I’m sure you guys are dying to boss me around.” She tried to disengage from Kyle’s hug without being rude; it seemed somewhat successful. The look on Lonnie’s face had her wondering though.

“Oh, Lonnie. Looks like you have to admit it. No going back now.” Kyle teased. Catra noticed a tenderness between them that hadn’t been there– or at least– that *she* hadn’t noticed before.

“Traitor.” Lonnie grumbled “We’re trained for practical action more or less.” She gestured to the sea of horde defectors scattered across the mess hall tables. “We’ve done an OK job with triage, keeping everyone fed, the day to day soldier stuff.” She crossed her arms. “I’m happy to be the voice of the people and communicate their needs… but you are the lateral thinker. You exploited every bug in every bot test we ever had… the ones you showed up for anyway.” Catra smirked at the acknowledgement. “As much as I’d love to see you mop the floor or something, which we will probably still make you do, you were a damn fine captain. We want this place to be more than just a shell of someone else’s old war. We want to build an empire. You’re a damn fine resource for that.”

“But with no more conquering, of course.” Kyle interjected. Melog projected a feeling of warmth that mirrored Catra’s sense of hope.

“In that case,” Catra extended her hand. Lonnie shook it warily. “Time to get down to business and come up with a name for this dump.”

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“Ugh. I know this one was Octavia.” Lonnie groaned before declaring to the ceiling “We are not calling it Fright Zone 2: The Reckoning!” She crumpled another scrap of paper and chucked it behind her. “These suggestions are *terrible.* ” They were gathered in their old locker room to sift through the suggestion box they had passed around. Melog, now visible, dozed in the corner with Kyle who patted them softly. Their discovery had scared the pants off of Lonnie, but Kyle was besotted.

“It’s almost like soldiers are discouraged from critical thinking.” Catra offered dryly as she chucked the suggestion to rename the territory ‘Coolsville’. “If we want the kingdom to flourish, we need to give it a name that the other kingdoms will recognize. Something that honors the history without glorifying the war.”

“Shouldn’t it relate back to the Black Garnet a little?” Kyle suggested idly. “All the other Kingdom names have a certain kind of flavor.” An idea struck him. “How about Obsidian?”

“That’s not half bad!” Lonnie was excited. “It still has a bit of a formidable edge…”

“But a lot less outright murdery!” Kyle finished.

“I have to admit. It does not suck.” Catra conceded.

“Really!? We’re going with my suggestion?” Kyle beamed. Catra and Lonnie shrugged. It sure seemed like it. They’d wasted plenty of time on this already. “I have to tell Rogelio!” He ran off in search of their burly, reptilian friend.

“So we gonna pretend lots of people suggested Obsidian?” Lonnie whispered conspiratorially. “Make them think it was their idea?”

“Oh yeah. For sure.” Catra nodded. They were quiet for a moment. The silence made Catra nervous. “So about the mopping. No way I’m getting out of that, huh?”

“No way in hell.” Lonnie laughed, but it wasn’t enough. Catra couldn’t help herself. She had to pick at the scab.

“So… how did the announcement from Scorpia really go?”

Lonnie sighed. “I knew you weren’t going to be able to leave it alone.” Her tone took on a fresh edge, but it wasn’t anything Catra wasn’t used to. “Nothing about this place was good, OK? We were all just surviving. I get that.” She leaned against one of the lockers and looked Catra up and down.

“You were crap to us. All of us. Most of the time.” Her tone was flat. “But, we were all pretty crappy. Even Rogelio and I… some of the shit we put Kyle through…” She threw up her hands. “If we’re sending you up the river, there better be room on the boat. So, instead, we’re letting things slide. OK? Can you do that?” Catra knew she was going to have to.

“I can. I will.” She hoped she could.

“Promise?” Lonnie wasn’t any more convinced than Catra. “I’ve never known you to be someone who lets things go.”

“I can’t promise. I know I’m not there yet. But I promise that I’m really, really going to try. Will that be good enough for you?” A series of snarls startled them both. Kyle and Rogelio had returned. He had said *good enough for me.* More or less. It was Kyle’s turn to be smug.

“We’re totally simpatico, Catra.” He beamed. “I know about Crimson Waste Kyle.”

“Oh no.” Catra groaned.

“Mhmm– her name is Taula, by the way. She opted to return to the Waste, though, so you probably won’t run into her.” Lonnie patted Catra on the shoulder.

“This is the real reason you were so happy to meet with me. To watch me writhe in shame.” Catra hissed.

“Pretty much.” Lonnie teased, but soon enough they were all laughing. Finally, Lonnie waived it away. "Enough of this nostalgia crap. We have to talk demolition."

Diminishing Returns

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Glimmer puzzle over the hidden meaning of the data crystal Hordak found.

Adora was never sure where she sat when it came to Dryl. Every time she came to visit it seemed like something went horribly wrong. Entrapta was at her most chaotic here, but something about the sleek, metal everything made Adora slightly nostalgic for the FFZ. Trauma sure was weird.

"I haven't made much progress yet, unpacking the code… given the damage." Entrapta had retrieved the data crystal Hordak found from a nearby bin. Her curiosity sparking back since Adora brought it up. The prospect of waiting even longer made Adora antsy. She hadn't really needed to come with Glimmer to pick Entrapta up… but she needed to be doing something.

"So there's… nothing you can tell me right now?"

"Nope! Nothing you don't already know!" Entrapta chirped. Adora sighed.

"It's just… y'know… *return* . Kind of an ominous inscription… don'tcha think?" Entrapta didn't dignify her anxious musing with a response.

"I *have* been studying the chemical makeup of the material that stores the data in the shards…" Entrapta mused. "Those experiments are on the back burner, so to speak, but if you bring me the materials… I could be persuaded." Entrapta giggled, clearly needing no persuasion at all.

"Teleport testing going that well, huh?" Adora was sarcastic.

"Oh no. All of our teleport experiments have demonstrably failed. It's a disaster." Entrapta responded earnestly. "But we will find a way. There's always a way." Adora could see her attentions slipping back to her work. Entrapta wasn't the right candidate to assuage her unease. It would be harder and harder to get a word in edgewise from here. Adora had to coax her back to Bright Moon.

"Alright, Entrapta, give me the list of materials and I'll talk to Bow. We'll see what we can do." Entrapta clapped. Her fixation transferred at the mere thought.

"You're leaving now then?" She asked.

"We're here to pick you up, remember?" Adora laughed. "Glimmer's in the kitchen with Leaf." Entrapta held her gaze as if expecting more words. "Talking about the catering for Spinerella and Netossa's anniversary party?" The stare persisted.

“We should get some snacks together before we go then.” Entrapta finally switched gears. Before Adora had time to respond, she had already summoned Sophie. The messenger bot chirped cheerfully upon entry. She plonked unpleasantly onto Adora’s head from the ceiling. Adora was just able to catch her as she rolled off. Slightly bemused, Adora shook her head and smirked.

“Well… if you’re offering…” Leaf made a killer grilled cheese.

–

“I have to admit. Return sounds like return.” Glimmer shrugged. “I get why you’d be freaking out.” They were swimming in Glimmer’s pit of pillows. How she managed to sleep in this bowl of fluff, Adora would never understand.

“I mean… I’m not freaking out *exactly.* ” She mumbled, face down in the swaths of fabric.

“Only mostly.” Glimmer goaded with the bop of a throw pillow. Adora laughed.

“I mean, they were dimension hopping colonizers. I’m sure they had *plenty* of places to return to.” She hedged, flopping onto her back.

“Chances are those places would have names, though, right?” Glimmer made space for the worry. “Labeling the chip return… I just can’t see it being for anything else. Can you, really?”

“No, but I’m freaking out here, remember?” Adora flailed her arms toward the ceiling. Glimmer curled up onto her side to consider the options more seriously.

“Maybe it’s not coordinates at all… It could be some sort of reset button.” She reached for Kowl: her long suffering stuffed toy.

“Aw geez. We really don’t need another one of those.” Adora groaned. “Why can’t my ancestors just leave well enough alone.”

“You’re one to talk! The Apple doesn’t fall far from the tree, Ms. I-Can-Fix-It!” Glimmer teased in a silly voice. She danced Kowl around to make it seem like he was the one chiding Adora.

“That’s harsh, Kowl, even for you.” Adora grumbled.

“Gosh, yeah, Kowl. Lay off!” Glimmer laughed as she tossed him over the edge. She couldn’t follow through with it though. Instead, she teleported to catch him before he hit the ground. Adora smirked from the edge. Glimmer shrugged. “Hey, he was my first general, alright?”

Back to Nature

Chapter Summary

> Perfuma needs a hug. Entrapta needs a win. Bow needs a nap, probably.

Bow and Perfuma stood bereft in what remained of the Her-Ra test biome. They had pulled the shield down. There was no point in it. The plants were beyond redemption.

"How could they just… die?" Bow was beside himself. "I knew they were responding strangely, but…"

Nothing could un-crimp Perfuma's harmony today. "Bow, listen. This isn't like it used to be with cacti. I called on everything I had for these plants. It's like they… weren't ever alive." Bow turned to her, shocked.

"Zombie plants? As cool as that sounds, it's a bit of stretch, Perfuma."

"Even now, these plants feel like… *nothing* . They don't even carry the grief of the dead." Perfuma was frustrated. "It's like… they don't *belong* here. Not here-here–" She pointed at the dirt. "They don't belong in Etheria."

"So you think they're disconnected somehow? From the magic?" She threw up her hands in response. "But then what about the

island was keeping them going in the first place? What did we do wrong? Was it the magic barrier?" Bow puzzled with anxious persistence.

"This whole island is just-- the worst!" Perfuma stamped her foot before turning inward. She sighed; hugging herself. Bow embraced his suspicions of the gloom she was emanating.

"You have to be open about the effects, Perfuma. If the signal is getting to you, we'll have to come up with something else." Concerned, he put a hand on her shoulder.

"It all just feels so wrong…" Perfuma's anxiety crested. She started to tear up. "I'm sorry. I can pull myself together. This mission is important." Bow shook his head.

"Nothing is more important than your health." He pulled her in for a hug. "Come back with me to Bright Moon. We have to bring this up to Entrapta anyway. Let's slap a meeting together." Bow could sense Perfuma's hesitation. Stubborn and scattered, she took a few moments to respond.

"OK." Perfuma nodded finally, sniffling. "OK."

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“Is it possible that they could be Eternian in origin?” Bow wondered aloud. “Samples from a settler ship?” Having arrived in Bright Moon, they had briefly pulled Entrapta from Glimmer and Adora’s talks about planting a localized signal jammer on Beast Island.

“That would explain… a lot, really.” Entrapta mused. “The more tech we unpack, the more it seems that… there’s more than there ever should have been. I was thinking that it was some sort of dumping ground for scrap but, with so much of it intact, that hypothesis was shaky on a good day.”

“So do we think that Beast Island was where they first landed?” Bow pressed. “Some sort of base camp that got abandoned when things got messy?”

“Not quite…” Entrapta revised some of her scribbling on the data screen. “It’s *possible* that the Etherian species were wiped out by invasive Eternian samples… but I’m thinking that… maybe there weren’t any Etherian species on Beast Island at all… at least, not according to these soil samples.” She turned to Bow. “You haven’t made any attempts to lay foundation, right? All of the structures are surface level or suspended?”

“Yeah. That’s right.” He considered this. “You don’t think…”

“I do think.” Entrapta enlarged her revised schematics on the holo-projector. “Beast Island might be a ship.” She cackled. “A really big ship!”

Perfuma gasped. “But so much of the First One’s tech works *with* Etherian magic. How is it possible that these plants are handling it so differently?”

“Tech can be adjusted. Made to fit.” Entrapta emphasized. “Nature is much more… unwieldy.” The tendrils of her hair danced. “This may have been the inspiration for their need to make the tech meet the magic in the middle.” Entrapta was nearly vibrating with excitement. “...Fascinating.”

“So what can we learn from this?” Bow mused “Do we abandon the Beast Island project?”

“Like those halfhearted Eternians? I don’t think so.” Entrapta was adamant. “So we can’t grow plants. Big whoop. The data still left to gather is boundless. If we’re right, and I think we are, there must be sealed points of entry to explore.”

“We need She-Ra.” Perfuma whispered; a bit reverent; a bit disappointed.

“--Which is great since we were going to send her there anyway.” Entrapta shrugged. “She’s our last line of defense on disabling that pesky signal.” Entrapta seemed hesitant to admit this. “None of my previous experiments have yielded anything promising.” She huffed.

“So what does this mean for me?” Perfuma looked down at her hands. “More time in Plumeria and with the Horde Clones, I suppose.” She tried to sound optimistic, but she felt small.

“The work you’ve done with Hordak has been great, Perfuma. Don’t sell yourself short.” Bow was bolstering. “It’s not like you to get so down on yourself like this.”

“Maybe you’re right. Maybe it's for the best if I take a break from the island.” She hedged. “But if work with Hordak needs to continue…?” Which, it did. The guy was a hot mess. They turned to Entrapta. She was doing that thing she did where it seemed to them like she wasn’t listening, tapping away at her tracker pad, looking anywhere but them, but it really meant she was listening as hard as she could.

“Like Entrapta said.” Bow was careful. “The tech research on Beast Island must continue. But if exposure to the signal is negatively affecting you… We have to assume Hordak might need breaks too-- even if he isn’t from around these parts. Maybe we flip things around. Maybe Hordak comes to you.”

“Working with him in Plumeria might allow new opportunities to blossom…” She thought back to all of the times she had gotten short with Hordak. She had been beating herself up… but maybe Beast Island had been the problem after all. *She might even convince him to attend a clone meeting!*

“Let me run it by Glimmer, of course.” Bow realized they were getting ahead of themselves. “We’ll pull together for another

meeting and iron things out. Maybe after Adora's upcoming mission." Entrapta was clutching the tracker pad awfully hard, but said nothing. Bow smiled brightly at his friends. "I think what we all need right now is a break. Perfuma, you head home and go see that rad girlfriend of yours. Entrapta, check out these new arrows I've been working on!"

An Unlikely Pair

Chapter Summary

> In hope of putting an end to the signal for good, Adora and Hordak venture deep into the recesses of Beast Island.

"I have been told to ask which name you prefer." Being an object worthy of Hordak's consideration wasn't going to stop feeling weird any time soon.

"Oh, were you now?" Adora, in She-Ra form, crossed her arms and offered him a lilting smirk. They had met eye to eye a surprisingly small number of times…even less so since her awakening as She-Ra. The almighty Hordak, ousted dictator of the Fright Zone, stood a head shorter than her right now. She was going to milk this.

"Yes." Of course, his journey to reform had not yet reached his sense of humour.

"You don't have to call me anything. Come on, let's head to the core." She turned her attention to the unruly tangle before them. To her surprise, Hordak insisted.

"I know the importance of a name. I will not choose one for you." He brushed past her now, running from the vulnerability of the statement before it was even fully out of his mouth. Adora found herself thinking fondly of Catra.

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“I knew you wouldn’t be able to take a hero break. Not even for five seconds. I should have bet money.” Catra had sniped as Adora readied herself to board Darla.

“I can’t just quit being She-Ra, Catra.” Adora sighed. It was left unspoken that she wouldn’t want to even if she could. This was mutually understood. They were still working on this whole… thing. Catra, ever agile, sharply blocked Adora’s path. Regardless of combat training or She-Ra magic, she was always one step behind. Catra planted her palms on either side of Adora’s face and pressed their foreheads together. Her eyelids fluttered shut. Adora could sense her purr. She jutted her chin up, stealing a kiss. Work in progress though it was, this whole thing rocked.

“Be safe and come back or I’ll kick your butt.” Catra’s timbre dropped low in that crazy-making way of hers.

“Promise?” Adora teased. It was Catra’s turn to blush.

“Get out of here, square.” She wiped the grin from her face. “Hordak must not be kept waiting.” her tone was that same caricature of Shadow Weaver born from their shared childhood. It was getting easier, somehow, to bear this way. Adora snorted as she headed out the door.

“I love you.” She whispered; knowing Catra could still hear.

“Yeah, yeah– love you too.” Catra would always kick up a fuss; but ever since that first time...she never missed an opportunity to say it.

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“Adora then.” She caught up without trying and nudged Hordak with her elbow. He nodded once sharply. They walked in silence for a time. It was difficult for Adora to think of Hordak as a person rather than an abstract symbol of fear from her childhood. They had been trained to treat him gingerly… Like a grenade with a loose pin. She had seen very little of his aggression herself… but knew of his violent outbursts from Catra… understood them through their aftermath in the abuse handed down by Shadow Weaver. Agreeing to descend into the core of Beast Island with him still felt like a huge liability. The clone refugees were proven to be sensitive and deeply self-critical. Was it possible Hordak of the Fright Zone would be brought to his knees by The Signal?

But, who was she to talk? Even she knew some of the reason she had agreed to this was to try and withstand it this time around. This of course was foolishness. Entrapta’s imperfect attempts at signal jamming systems were active. Adora would never get to know if she was ‘strong enough’.

As they approached the bridge that led to the mouth of the core ruin, Adora stopped. Crossing the bridge was the beginning of the end during the original expedition to rescue Entrapta and Micah.

“I’m sure you’ve received data from Entrapta about the signal effects… but are you prepared for how it might affect you as we get closer?” She could hear Catra laughing in her head. She was using her She-Ra voice again. Something about what Hordak represented made her want to exert dominance. It felt safer in a way that she didn’t like. Was this a condescending question? After all, hadn’t he been on the island for months already?

“It is my understanding that it amplifies cognitive distortions… that these often relate to worth and safety… It compels the subject to submit.” It was an irritating non-answer as far as Adora was concerned.

“Look, Hordak. Are you gonna be good in there or not?” She challenged him sharply. He took a begrudging, steadying breath.

“In the aftermath of my interactions with Entrapta… and Catra… my brother–” He halted “--Prime’s lamentations over my sense of pride affected me differently. Overcoming his will, I also recognized the flaw of exerting mine over Etheria… in looking down on the people here. Catra was correct. She was a better leader than I could have ever been. I have proven myself short-tempered, avoidant and short-sighted.” Adora was impatient. For all she could tell, he was in the throes of the signal already. “In short… I am aware of my failings. Perfuma reminds me that awareness, though a step in the journey, does not guarantee resilience.”

“Is that a really long winded way of saying ‘No, Adora, I’m probably already a total wreck’? Because I am not liking the sounds of this, H-Man.” She was deflecting with humor out of

discomfort. He bristled at “wreck” and showed umbrage at “H-Man”.

“If I do not step forward despite my failings… I will become them.” Hordak didn’t back down. “Etheria is owed my labour. What technical skills I possess are needed in Entrapta’s absence.” He had long stopped pretending that he was smarter than her.

“Man. You are really gunning for us to bring her for a visit, huh?” She couldn’t believe his audacity… or frankly, the tenderness with which he spoke about Entrapta–nevermind what sounded like begrudging respect toward Catra.

He cleared his throat nervously and stepped gingerly out onto the bridge. Silence fell once more as they made their way across. The atmosphere was beginning to shift– and not in the best way, but neither commented on it. Tension seemed to build as they finally planted their feet on the other side. It was then that they heard leaves rustle to the left. A tremor ran through the ground. Adora braced, but Hordak was unphased. *It couldn’t be a trap?* The next tremor was more powerful. A giant form burst from the trees.

The creature landed on all fours and turned its bulbous head toward them. Slivers of light cut through the foliage and reflected off of its chrome surface. Adora groaned.

“Of course.”

“Hello, Gloria.” Hordak patted one of the robot’s imposing limbs. Adora put her hand to her face in exasperation. A sudden sharp series of beeps made her nearly jump out of her skin. A slightly smaller, but still huge, spherical bot peaked out from behind her.

“Good to see you, too, Emily.” Hordak chuckled.

“Well if the gang’s all here…” Adora waved them forward with sharp irritation.

“Entrapta suggested monitoring units that couldn’t be affected by the signal in case we are overcome.” Hordak explained. “They had to find another way over. The bridge isn’t stable enough.”

“All valuable information that you could have told me before the bridge.” Adora muttered to herself, but they paid her no mind. This was going to be a very long day.

–

“Did Perfuma and Bow explain their theory to you?” Their conversation was intermittent at best. Hordak’s voice was startling after so much silence. They had been walking for what felt like forever. Emily and Gloria could be heard thrashing through the foliage at a distance. The duo was managing to keep any wayward creatures at bay so far.

“Do you really think Entrapta could have kept from announcing ‘really big ship’?” Adora laughed as she thrashed through some brambles with her sword.

“No. I do not.” His tone was as flat as ever, but she could see his small smile. The tracker pad GPS was still a bit spotty, but it seemed to be holding up better since their last mission. It was currently telling Adora that they were getting close. They just had to unearth some sort of entry point. Adora was growing ever frustrated with the brain fog and the fatigue that settled into her shoulders. She was certainly fairing better than their last Beast Island excursion though. Entrapta’s attempts at signal disruption were doing something at least.

“It couldn’t really be salvageable, could it?” She wondered aloud. Hordak shrugged.

“It’s hard to say. A lot can be done with scrap… If the hypothesis is correct, I doubt they could get it to launch… but what remains of its working materials could be groundbreaking.” The prospect of this didn’t animate him the way she would have expected. Adora gave Hordak a sidelong glance.

“How you holding up?” The attention made him uncomfortable.

“Wallowing in my failure of Horde Prime.” His response was dry. Adora snorted.

“Hordak… did you just make a joke?” She gaped. “Now I’m really concerned.” She leaned in closer. “Come on, be honest, are you going to go wild on me?” He sidestepped her, but she circled around.

“No.” He wouldn’t play along, which only made her more insistent.

“What sweet nothings does this island whisper to you? I have to know–” Adora stopped kidding. “When we came for Entrapta… she spoke of being left behind?” A shadow fell across Hordak's expression. His shoulders tensed. Her stilted companion stopped abruptly as he raised an arm. She took a step back. Muscle memory was Adora's master in that moment. She flinched: a young girl expecting to be struck. She was staring down the barrel of the laser built-in to his new exosuit’s bracer.



There was a blinding flash of light. The acrid scent of singed hair filled her nostrils. She stumbled backward… she still could after all, because he hadn't been aiming at her. She turned to see the remnants of a slithering sort of creature that had been lurking from behind.

The air crackled with tension. Slowly, Hordak lowered his arm. His expression was still clouded; unreadable. He turned away– pointedly invested in searching the foliage for anything other than the vulnerability that sang from each of them.

To their mutual shock and relief, it wasn't long before Emily burst forth from the tangled jungle emitting a series of frantic beeps. "What is it, girl?" Hordak rested a palm on Emily's shell. Tension diffused, Adora stifled a laugh. "Have you discovered a vantage point?" It reminded her too much of Entrapta. Emily's chittering response seemed positive.

"No time to waste." Adora followed close behind as Hordak clambered through the foliage after Emily's retreating frame. It was clear that the GPS had been completely off track, as if the signal had been luring them to some unknown, unfortunate end. Adora shivered. This island sucked.

A Bitter Memory

Chapter Summary

Scorpia begins her quest to learn more about her family. Bow's brothers do their best to help.

"We *may* have gotten a little carried away–"

"--Only ever so slightly!"

"Contextually–"

"–it's all very relevant, we assure you."

There seemed to be a Bow brother coming at her from all sides. The twins in the archive were a maelstrom of knowledge. Before she knew it, a mountain of scrolls were piled on the table. Scorpia was sandwiched, and slightly stunned, between them.

"So, as you can see, your family's overt presence in the F–, I mean, Obsidian only goes back a few generations." Flint guided Scorpia's eye across the documents he had pulled from the archive. Of the two, he seemed to recognize better how overwhelming this all was.

Fletcher on the other hand, splashed a scroll across the desk with all the subtlety of a shanty by Seahawk. "There aren't a lot of

surviving records since the Horde's instatement. But, from what we can tell, your family *was* elected to power. Potentially because of your great-grandmother's connection with the Black Garnet." Her eyes fell upon an artistic rendition.



"Based on the style of the art and the materials used, that's how we gather this was probably your great-grandmother. Given the assumed time period." Flint tapped at the scroll.

“Chronologically speaking.” Fletcher finished.

“I still don’t get why any of this matters. The past is the past.” Huntara grumbled from a corner, unsure how or why she had gotten dragged into this. When Adora asked her to provide Scorpia with moral support, she had assumed she would have gotten to punch someone. But, *apparently* she was banned from punching anything in this whole dusty place.

“It’s more than the past, Huntara!” Scorpia was insistent. “What about connections to the mural in Horror Hall? Any luck there?” She turned back to Fletcher. “I don’t know where my real memories end and my fantasies begin.” Snatched fragments of the women who raised her flickered through her mind like the light of a dying candle… but she couldn’t recall anything at all about that elusive fifth portrait.



“Let’s start with what you think you do remember.” Flint’s tone was gentle.

“Even if it’s fantasy, your brain made it up for a reason and that makes the details important! Myth is an integral underpinning to the elusive truths of history!” Fletcher’s exuberance was surprisingly bolstering in contrast. “That spark of curiosity.” He gushed, getting sidetracked. “The hope of being right. The inevitable fall in being wrong. A historian’s work is never done!”

“So he’s the favourite, huh?” Scorpia joked to Flint.

“Big time.” He rolled his eyes. “Cool it, Fletch?”

“Sorry.” Fletcher shrunk. “Go on.” He encouraged Scorpia.

“Well, I mean, they wouldn’t be on the wall if they weren’t… family, right?” Scorpia was hesitant. “If those women were my parents… she would have to be— I mean, y’know?”

“Let’s use that as foundation then.” Flint pulled a scrap of working paper from the pile of documents and began to sketch a loose diagram. “Grandad, Mums… kids.” Scorpia stared. It meant so much more to see someone else pin it down. *Could this girl really be her sister?* Her anxiety crested.

“But, then, what happened to them? Any of them?”

“Why aren’t we asking that dolt on the island?” Huntara announced. “Shouldn’t he know *exactly* what happened to them?”

Scorpia sighed. “The Horde always said that in response to the deal with Grandfather they…left.”

“Sounds like hot bullshit to me.” Huntara mumbled.

“You think it’s a lie?” Scorpia was uneasy.

“This is Hordak we’re talking about.” Flint shrugged.

“Of the *Evil* Horde. In the *Fright* Zone.” Fletcher punctuated. “The self-elected adjectives are pretty damning.”

“I’m pretty sure my own family came up with ‘Horror Hall’ so…” Scorpia was downcast at the proposed correlation. “Even if that’s true, I can’t make him tell me anything.”

“I probably could.” Huntara threatened. Fletcher gestured toward her with an energy of conspiratorial encouragement. Flint shot him a look.

“Maybe I could talk to him properly about it when they’re back to Bright Moon with their report…” She thought to Catra. They were doing better now. Maybe she would help. “We were always told not to bother him… but that seems pretty silly now, huh?”

Scorpia's continued adherence to the rule clearly freshly embarrassed her.

She had been so hopeful when she first arrived at the archive. Flint locked eyes with Fletcher. Silently, but resolutely, it was decided. They *could not* end this hang sesh on a bummer note.

“In the meantime, let’s dive into your history anyway.” Fletcher yanked a number of scrolls from the pile.

“It looks like this woman, the one we think is your great-grandma?” Flint gave Scorpia a friendly shoulder squeeze.

“Her life was gloriously well documented.” Fletcher’s eyes sparkled.

“Talk about damning adjectives.” Huntara groaned.

The Descent

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Hordak inch closer to the culmination of their mission.

Chapter Notes

> So I realized as I was uploading today that I had accidentally submitted a draft chapter out of order. Sorry about that. Previously labeled "Chapter 17 - Visiting Hours" has been deleted. Sorry for the confusion. Lol.

The beeping. Adora was going to scream. They were losing what little light cut through the dense overgrowth of the island. She was certainly exhausted and grouchy by extension. Hordak, being Hordak, it was hard to tell… But now here they were, confronted with this hopeful, yet ominous, opening to what could possibly be the core… and Emily was stuck.

Previously obscured, Gloria and Emily had unearthed it by obliterating a fallen tree and some cracked boulders. The aftermath of some sort of beastly encounter, no doubt. It seemed to confirm Entrapta's suspicions. Slick metal siding glinted against the glow of She-Ra's sword. Clearly from this point on, Adora and Hordak were on their own.

"At least no beasts will follow us in with Emily blocking the opening behind us." Adora rubbed at her forehead. Resigned, she shrugged. Thankfully, Emily's offended beeps were less ear piercing than her *'I'm stuck!'* beeps. "We'll get you out, we promise! But for now, just… guard the entryway!" Adora called dismissively as she descended, paying Gloria even less heed.

“We’ll be back soon, girls.” Hordak gave Emily an earnest pat and followed after Adora. There was nothing for it. They needed to get this done. He turned his attention to their surroundings; raising his right bracer, setting the laser to non-offensive. It emitted a low-light to supplement the sword’s glow. For most of his life, Hordak had decried the craftsmanship of other planets with no self-examination. It was only now that he could properly engage with the established longevity of Eternian craft.

“So little damage.” He observed aloud.

“Pretty much indestructible unless their own defense systems go bonkers.” Adora scoffed knowingly. “And why is it always spiders?” She added, forgetting herself. It was the sort of thing that would make Bow and Glimmer cackle.

“Better spiders than snakes.” Hordak shuddered. “You would pray for spiders if you had ever faced a sand snake.” *Was that something like a smile?* The mutual glance was brief.

“Mmyep. Definitely not liking the sound of sand snakes.” Adora fumbled. Hordak nodded stiffly. Silence descended once more. To Adora, the hall seemed to go on forever. Hordak checked some of his status readings. Was his sense of time distorting further?

But eventually, they inevitably reached one of Adora’s favourite things: a towering, sealed entrance. Shaking off her fatigue; she grinned at Hordak, cracking her knuckles.

“Showtime.” She whispered to herself before placing a determined palm against the apparent access pad. They waited.

Nothing. Not even a glow. Chagrined, she raised her sword aloft to peer more closely at the door… seeking an inscription of some kind.

“She-Ra?” She tried. No response. Fair enough. It was a dubious password for a supposedly civilian ship. “Eternia?...Open?” She groaned as she dropped both her arms. “Man! It sure would be great to have not been kidnapped as a baby with no relevant memories right now!” She looked pointedly to Hordak. To his credit, and Adora’s astonishment, he was evidently sheepish.

“...Apologies.” He shrank back slightly. Adora crossed her arms and tapped her foot. There had to be a clue somewhere… Hordak’s gaze trailed the floor. Briefly, the light from his bracer caught something toward the lower half of the door. “Look, there.” *Possibly some sort of switch?* Adora kicked at it apathetically.

They flinched away from the blinding flash as the corridor panels and entrance were suddenly awash with that cool signature Eternian iridescence. Adora’s power surged defensively against the shock as the entrance shuddered open with discernable difficulty.

As Hordak’s eyes adjusted, he noted Adora’s warm, honeyed She-Ra glow; the contrast was stark. If there was any doubt as to the origins of her magic, it had been rightfully banished. What blossomed within her was wholly, furiously, chaotically Etherian;

and it was glorious. Adora grew uncomfortable with his scrutinizing gaze. She waved an impatient hand to his face.

"Ey, Hordak, you good?" He shook off his wonderment; replacing it with the stiff reticence Adora was used to. He brushed her off as they turned to the task ahead of them, and crossed the threshold into this curious unknown; hopeful that it would bring about a prompt end to this mission. But this was only the beginning.

Family Trees

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia fills Perfuma in on all she's discovered so far. Leading her to consider what comes next.

"Tell. me. *everything* ." Perfuma crossed her legs in rapt attention to the image of Scorpia on the trackpad in front of her, propped against a pillow on her bed.

"Heart Blossom, you will not believe!" She cried excitedly. "My great grandmother, Chnida? She was this super rad powerhouse of magic and she was cool and political and-and she saved the Scorpioni from uncertain death!" Perfuma smiled; happiness rolling off her in waves. Her radiance made the distance between them inch just slightly smaller. "She was betrothed. *Betrothed.* " Scorpia couldn't help delight in the melodrama of it all. "To this Lizard guy? Like Rogelio, y'know?--is that rude? Anyway– and so I guess that's the thing. Obsidian was the Lizard Kingdom. All this time, right?" Scorpia mugged a shocked expression. "So, now you're like, oh dang, that's why there are so many Lizardfolk in Obsidian. Duh!" Perfuma nodded encouragingly, stifling a soft chuckle.

"So, something was wrong in the Crimson Waste, details are sketchy… but the Scorpioni were getting really sick." Scorpia's exuberance dulled a little. "They thought if they migrated, it would fix things." Perfuma's expression turned somber. "So, she attended this ball for this guy–the Lizard guy–" Scorpia shuffled around for a moment, parsing through notes and papers. She came up empty. "OK, so we don't yet know the name of the Lizard guy. Rogelio is going to get back to me."

“This must be such empowering ancestral knowledge for him.” Perfuma acknowledged thoughtfully.

“Totally–” Scorpia barrelled on, “So, she shows up all *fwa whoosh.* ” She mimed what Perfuma could only assume was a sense of grace and really nice hair. “And then BAM! She resonates with the Black Garnet! In front of everyone apparently, and–” Scorpia held up the Chnida Garnet scroll too close to the screen for emphasis. “Come on, Who doesn’t just propose to all of that?!”

Perfuma let out a clipped burst of buoyant, guileless laughter. “I’m sure she couldn’t beat them off with a stick.” With pride, she touched the fingers of one hand to her cheek delicately. “So? *Were they in love?* ” You couldn’t tear Perfuma away from a good old fashioned romance. Scorpia’s expression turned grave.

“The night after their wedding–He was *murdered.* ”

“No!” Perfuma gasped and clutched at her heart; tears welling.

“Yes.” Scorpia nodded sadly. “But apparently, he was the last of the line– Like I said, digging to be done in that direction…” She pivoted back. “But that’s how the Scorpioni rose to power.”

“Oh that’s dreadful.” Perfuma was aghast.

“No wonder we weren’t very popular.” Scorpia slumped back, scratching at the back of her neck nervously. “Somehow, though, Great-Gran powered through and managed to keep the seat.” They shared a moment of quiet admiration.

“That can’t have been easy.” Perfuma agreed.

“That’s sort of where it all trails off though… then it’s just charts. Y’know. Some more re-marriages, along comes my grandfather… and then… poof.”

“Hordak.” Perfuma frowned as she sifted lightly through the mix of emotions that followed. She would need to sit with this. Life after war was... complicated.

“Yup.” Scorpia nodded eventually.

“Does that mean…” Perfuma hedged, unsure.

“Seems like it. Gonna have to… have a chat?” Scorpia was understandably reluctant. “He’s just so…” she made a grim face. “Y’know?” Even after months of work with the man, Perfuma couldn’t disagree.

“And the history… probably moreso.” They were quiet for a moment. Perfuma huffed. “Well!” she clapped softly. “That is certainly a lot of emotional exploration for one day. I’m so glad

Flint and Fletcher were able to help." Scorpia smirked somewhat ruefully.

"You can still take your time with this, you know." Perfuma admonished. "Everyone here knows you can take on Hordak any day of the week." She raised her eyebrows playfully. "After all, you're *the* Lynda D'Ream."

"Ah, stop it, you." Scorpia grinned.

"Never." Perfuma winked. "It's too much fun."

Impulse

Chapter Summary

Adora and Hordak get much more than they bargained for.

Chapter Notes

"there make be snakes" - Jenny Nicholson

A rhythmic dripping sound echoed softly as they picked their way across the debris. The ravage of time had not spared the chamber the way it had the corridor. Adora observed the many faces of their reflections in the metallic and crystalline surfaces surrounding them. So much splintered and lost.

Since her defection from the Horde… with the constant threat of destruction looming… Adora had– perhaps willfully– put an endless number of things to the back of her mind. But, here in this quiet moment; this monument to what might be the last remnants of her ancestors, it wasn't just one more pile of junk standing in the way of answers. It was a serious loss. She glimpsed the grief that simmered beneath and for one brief moment allowed it to swell within her– but only one before promptly stuffing it back down.

It was hard to determine what this room had once been. There was no discernable furniture. They stepped around a colossal, twisted shard. An interface panel came into view. *Maybe the flight deck?*

Unfortunately, the interface panel had also not been spared. A once floating element had come tumbling down, caving in the left

side. Adora's skills would be of no use unless Hordak could jig something together.

"Well, this can't be what we're looking for." Adora's tone carried a sharper edge than she'd intended. "I mean–" She tried to compose herself. "A panel this jacked up can't send signals… can it?" Knowing next to nothing about such things, her ultimate question was genuine. Hordak prevented himself from being glib about it.

"No. It can't be the source, but if this is some sort of navigational hub…." He observed the fractured clues before them. "Data, if salvaged, could give us everything we need and then some." Adora nodded reflectively. "It will be tedious, but compared to trekking further into this labyrinth... preferred?" He knew it was the ideal course of action, but this would be a test. Adora was the authority here. He waited expectantly for permission, but her mind was elsewhere. "Shall I?" He hedged. "Adora?"

Startled, she snapped back to the task at hand. "Oh– Oh yeah. For sure. We've spent enough time here already." Hordak did not enjoy this looming sense of uncertainty, but there was nothing for it. He began to set up a station for himself where the damage was least evident and set to work. Adora wandered aimlessly, kicking at loose hunks of debris every so often. it only seemed to bother Hordak a little bit. Perfuma would be proud.

But, as the buzzing of Hordak's tools crawled up Adora's arms. It tested the limits of her frayed patience. Hordak could sense her growing unease. It proved a terrible distraction. With great fatigue and trepidation, he endeavored to distract her with conversation.

“Bow spoke to you of the data crystal that was recovered from our current base camp?” There was something in his tone that Adora wasn’t able to place.

“Yeah. It will definitely be interesting to see what Entrapta’s able to dig up.” Her tone was similarly clipped for reasons Hordak couldn’t identify.

“Does the inscription provide any elucidation?” Again, that tone– not quite curiosity– was Hordak attempting to be *casual?* It perplexed her.

“What?”

“The text. Was it legible?”

“Oh! Yeah, luckily. Though there’s clearly that huge chunk missing.” Adora admitted. “It reads: Return.” Hordak gave a slight nod and the silence descended once more. Adora, being oblivious to the particulars of the tech nonsense, was stuck turning over freshly dislodged worries like these chunks of old debris. She wished she had something to clobber.

“Does it concern you?” Hordak surprised her again with his attentiveness; even if it was a really stupid question.

“Maybe a little, yeah?” Adora's sarcasm was fierce. Hordak winced. It was a bold topic for him to broach, kidnapper and all. “It could lead me to my people. My family? Who knows. Do I want to meet them? Yeah probably. Might they be dead? What if they’re dead? Do I need that in my life? I mean come on!” She flailed her sword wielding arm chaotically. “I have family here now. I’m not supposed to be searching for this anymore!” She called out, projecting her voice upward into the cavernous expanse. Hordak was unsure how to react to this exuberant display of frustration; though, it struck him that he understood it... so he tried anyway.

“With luck you will find the answers you seek… and the ones you don’t can remain buried.” He offered this companionably; discomfiting them both. He turned back to his work. Listless, Adora stepped closer to watch for a while. She nearly laughed. *Casually peeking over Hordak’s shoulder?* She wrestled with fresh confusion as she realized she had begun to feel at ease with him, relatively speaking.

Adora leaned back against the panel and slumped down to the floor. Awed by the light dancing across the data plates embedded there, she turned her gaze upward. The familiarity of these cool colours soothed her somewhat. The splintering that arced across the walls found its source here. A jagged hole marred the center of the ceiling. The depths of which were too dark to see.

–

“You are fluent, then… in Eternian?” Hordak broke the silence cautiously. Adora had nearly drifted off. She crossed her arms and cocked her head to the side.

"Yeah. I mean, it just sort of… makes sense to me. I can't quite explain how. It's like knowing it is a part of me."

"Given that– you could read… anything?" His tone arced in a way he found unpleasant. Regret and frustration surged. *Foolish. Self-indulgent. This wasn't relevant.* He nearly hoped that she wouldn't answer him.

"Sure." She shrugged. As she turned her attention to him, it dawned that this wasn't such a general sort of pondering. She grew suspicious as she observed his discomfort. "Anything in particular?"

His intensity was jarring as he pulled away from the interface panel and crouched to face her head on. "This." He pulled his arm inward. The gesture and fervor reminded her of Lief. Taken aback, her gaze eventually traced to the data crystal embedded in the chestplate of his exosuit. He bristled slightly as she leaned forward to peer at the inscription. Shock bloomed across her face; smacking her speechless. She blinked. He flinched.

"What is it?" His oblivious alarm was all the more hilarious to Adora. She threw her head back laughing and nearly cracked it against the panel. Adora sharply covered her smirk with the back of her hand, but it was fruitless. She cackled for what seemed like eternity to Hordak. He fought the urge to shake her by the shoulders.

"But what does it *say* ?" He really was beside himself. She tamped down her mirth; barely.

“Sorry.” She cleared her throat. “Look, I can’t speak to Entrapta’s Eternian skills here, OK? It could be nothing.” She waved one hand vaguely. He clenched his fists. His impatience gnawed at the rapport that they had begun to build… but this quietly illuminated for Adora that his anger no longer sent those childish signals to her brain… the ones that told her to run. She saw it for what it was: anxiety.

“ *This is so weird.* ” She groaned inwardly before taking a final deep breath. “It says ‘Loved’, man.”

Hordak froze; his expression opened with one slow blink. Normally tense features slackened; unreadable. Adora cringed. *Bad timing to break Hordak.* She chided herself. Sharply– he rose and turned back to his work on the panel; but not before Adora glimpsed the redness in his cheeks.

In truth, she was embarrassed for the both of them. It was not comfortable holding space for such intimate knowledge about Hordak. *About Hordak’s feelings?* She shook her head. His once meticulous work had become clunky. A familiar rigid energy settled into his shoulders. Adora couldn’t help it. She chuckled.

Hordak was deaf to this overly familiar amusement. Her mirth meant nothing to him as he emotionally began to unstitch. In the wake of her impertinence, each teasing syllable plucked at what he had not yet allowed to be true… and what that even meant.

Gratitude struck Hordak full in the face. Moreso now even than, by her hand, his release from Horde Prime. Oblivious, she stood and stretched; ever impatient. Adora wandered back to the center of the room. Hordak allowed the moment to pass.

A low rumble disrupted his stirring sentiment. The walls quaked as the rolling wave advanced upon them and the precarious fortitude of the ruin was sorely tested.

"That can't be good." Adora bore down in a defensive stance as she scanned for the most likely vantage point for what would follow. Rather than pulling away from the panel, Hordak set more urgently to work. He had to follow the plan. She-Ra was here for a reason. He was no hero.

Groaning metal. A spray of dirt rained down. Adora turned her attention to the ceiling. "Of course." She sighed as a slinking, hulking mass hurled toward the ground with a shriek. Adora strafed to the side and her shoulder glanced on a jagged chunk of debris. "MotherfaAH–" She cried out; exasperated. Luckily, this lured the behemoth's attention away from Hordak. Though somewhat shaken, he remained unscathed and steadfast in his duty. He doubled over the panel working as swiftly as he could.

It was a mass of teeth with scales the size of her head. It slithered forward; slashing its tail and haphazardly whipping up debris. The sound of its body dragging across the uneven ground was ghastly.

“Snakes.” Hordak muttered defeatedly from his station without looking up. It screeched.

“Snakes don’t screech!” Adora taunted pedantically as she swapped her sword for a whip. It manifested above her head confidently. She managed to snag the beast’s flailing tail and stifle it for a moment. This bought precious few seconds for planning.

She dove, this time narrowly dodging hunks of wreckage. The creature wove in a dizzying chase. Tumbling and vaulting she turned its nimble body against it. She beamed; suddenly triumphant. Adora had succeeded in tying it into a knot. With the rope no longer needed, her sword materialized for an impressive downward slash; the beast was vanquished. She was rewarded by a clear, unfettered mid-tone that emitted from the interface panel.

“Oh thank goodness.” She sighed. Her sword arm ached dully from banging it earlier and her muscles screamed with fatigue. She cursed herself for being so showboaty. Maybe a small part of her had wanted to impress Hordak? *Gross.*

She patted him on the back. “Nice work, H-Man.” He reacted as if doused in cold water.

“Now that the power is restored; I’m attempting to route the interface through the trackpad.”

“Kind of like a remote control?” Adora observed.

“Ideally.” he held up a fistful of wires threaded from the guts of the panel through to the trackpad. “Though not remote quite yet.” The reality of Hordak’s second joke of the day had her laughing harder than the joke itself. This crested into a brief hysteria only fatigue can bring. She wiped a tear from her eye.

“You’re pretty good at this.” She admitted.

“Yes.” He agreed artlessly. “Though, Entrapta is better.”

“Riiiiiight.” Adora’s concession was smug. “How about Bow?”

“Bow is technologically capable.”

Adora snorted. “I’m going to tell him you said that.” Hordak just shrugged. It finally seemed like he was making headway. A dull thrum echoed around them as distant segments of the ship groaned to life.

“Yes!” Hordak declared with an exultant swing of his fist. “Finally.” He leaned the screen toward Adora.

“Answers.” Adora whispered. Accepting the trackpad. She navigated the prompts deftly while mumbling to herself occasionally. “Status readings… logs… HA!” She stabbed sharply. “Beacons.” The screen exploded with angry red warning nodes. “Ah!” She yelped, scrambling, nearly dropping the pad. Adora translated as Hordak worked tirelessly. Before long, a satisfying chime brought their mission to an end. The signal was permanently disabled– as far as she could tell anyway.

“The core data, as suspected, is largely intact.” Hordak observed. “The degradation of the surface transmitters seems to have…” He struggled to word it. “As you said, ‘jacked up’ the signal.”

“Planetwide…evacuation required?” Adora breathed; reading aloud, barely registering Hordak’s words. “All units return… to Eternia?” She looked up to Hordak. Her gaze was seeking and hungry. “They really did leave– or tried to?” Adora trailed off on that quavering note and handed the trackpad back to Hordak. He clutched it nervously as he watched her. “All this time… I guess I don’t know what I thought. With Mara–They might really be out there.” She looked up again to the gaping maw carved in the ceiling. “But–” Adora grimaced. These were the people who programmed Light Hope to *destroy* Mara. Etheria. Her*. Did this really change anything at all?* Did it matter that they were no longer First Ones? *Ghosts?*

“I have archived as much data as possible onto the trackpad.” Hordak was hesitant to disrupt her reverie; for which he had no context. *Who or what was Mara?* “I– recommend–” He wavered. *Was he allowed to recommend?* “...harvesting as many crystals as possible.” He gestured to the debris. “Damaged or not.” Adora nodded somewhat absently.

“Yeah. Sure.” Somewhat mechanically, unsure of themselves and each other, they gathered up what they could and made their way back to the surface. Lost in an oubliette of opaque thought. In the long, silent trek Adora reverted from She-Ra form without really thinking about it. Night had fallen. The air seemed lighter; freer somehow. The breeze was grounding as it tousled her hair.

“Etheria.” Hordak acknowledged with a mild, wry reverence. Released from the signal, the island felt reclaimed. This hope sank as Hordak took in their surroundings. “Emily– Gloria?” He whistled; mimicking Entrapta while examining the entrance. “She scraped herself free…” There was a distant crashing in the brush and the distinct low reverb of a laser blast. Adora was slow to react. Hordak was not.

Gloria burst out, thrashing with a beast in a mighty tangle of limbs. Hordak dove, lurching toward Adora. He shoved roughly. She was just barely out of the way as a tree trunk was yanked up at its roots. It toppled, straight for where her head had been. Where Hordak now was. Flung into the brush, her back cracked against a rock. Stars bloomed in her vision. There had been a flash of light. *His laser?* It arced up to the sky, clearly missing any target… before everything went dark.

Origins and Anchors

Chapter Summary

Meanwhile, the Obsidian crew discuss next steps.

“Functional and admittedly stylish. You’ve outdone yourselves.” Catra appraised the newly erected Medi-Centre favorably.

“I am never going to get sick of compliments from Catra.” Lonnie declared.

“People get sick of compliments?” Kyle was perplexed.

“Seriously. Why am I even here? I could be napping.” Catra jokingly pondered. “Right. Right. The mopping. The groveling.” Lonnie shoved her jovially.

“We’re making serious headway on the foundations of this whole thing.” Lonnie leaned toward Rogelio. “Should we start talking bigger picture? What with the crash course Fletcher and Scorpia just gave us?”

Rogelio growled animatedly. Catra was less ashamed of never having learned his language than she had a right to be, but the sensory struggle of her feline hearing made languages a nightmare. She gave correct attention, however, to Rogelio’s expression, until it was Kyle’s turn to translate; laughing.

“Yes, yes, Lonnie would make an excellent warrior queen.” He placated Rogelio intimately. “There might be some refugees that headed for the waste… we’ll need to find out as much as we can… y’know, pre-war… but if what’s lost is lost, as long as there are LizardFolk voices being heard, He’s not scrambling for the chance to be king or something.”

“Warrior Queen was on the table? Damn.” Lonnie appraised Rogelio playfully.

Rogelio’s responding gutteral chatter eventually dampened to a throaty series of hisses in Lonnie’s direction. She and Kyle blushed. Catra rolled her eyes; suddenly much more grateful for her ineptitude for linguistics.

“Yes. Well. As Rogelio just said–” Lonnie attempted to pivot.

“--Among other things…” Kyle murmured cheekily. She swatted him.

“The Horde took away *all* of our history. Not just the Lizardfolk. So, I’m down to keep the focus on rebuilding for now. As we discover more, we’ll see where that takes us… hierarchically speaking.”

Catra nodded stiffly to herself as she smoothed at her slightly bristling fur. If the others noticed, they did a good job hiding it. She had never engaged very well with this… her… orphanness. Anyone like her were few and far between. Glimpsed only in bitter passing. She had never wanted to risk that they might know more– more than she did. She shook it off. This was not something for which she was even close to ready.

Thankfully, the abrupt singing of her trackpad gave her ample excuse.

"Catra! You need to get back here *now."* Glimmer was frantic.

"Woah, Sparkles, where's the fi–"

"It's Adora." Her audible distress rent through Catra. "I'd port you, but we lost connection and it had been hours– I had to… we had to get them out." Her fatigue was evident. Even without the need to charge up anymore, she had her limits. Every almost sung out from Catra's chest. *No. Not today.* She looked around frantically for Lonnie.

"Go." Kyle's uncharacteristic sternness cut through the dense flurry of fear that clouded her mind. He held his hand out for the trackpad. "We're covered. Just go." She nodded sharply and dashed for the transport tanks.

Hands Tied

Chapter Summary

> Catra is hesitant to confront her anxieties as Adora recuperates at Bright Moon

"So, where are we at? Am I allowed to be mad you almost got your head smashed?" Catra peaked into Adora's room. Adora sat up in bed with only a little bit of difficulty. She was relieved to see Catra; but nervous too. Adora let herself really watch her as she approached the bed. Those languid movements drove her crazy… but the look on Catra's face did not.

"Mmm yes. I think so." Adora laughed in that dry, tired way. Like gravity had increased just a bit. Catra sat on the foot end of the bed, she smoothed at the sheet so that her fingers inched closer to Adora. The rest of her was turned away. Adora tucked her legs beneath her in an attempt to shift closer. Catra didn't pull back. but she didn't close the gap either. Instead, she began to tap a rhythm with her fingers. Trying to shake an energy she wasn't sure what to do with yet.

"--And how about that you tried to hide it from me and you're just very unlucky that Entrapta has no filter?" Catra's tone was sharp; but sharper than she had intended. She snuck a glance at Adora from the corner of her eye. Adora looked similarly sheepish.

"Yeah. That is probably my bad– should have cut you off at the pass." Adora inched closer still and rested her chin on Catra's shoulder. She was purring, but it wasn't the good kind.

“Alright. Then I’m pretty mad.” Catra tried to be kidding more than she was. “Now I have something to be thankful to Hordak for? Come on. Worst souvenir ever, Adora.”

“Right, because I'm spoiled for options on what to bring you back from Beast Island, Catra.” Adora ribbed, lifting one arm up to drape over Catra’s shoulder as she did. “Next time I have to go on a mission you definitely hate… I promise to bring you back something cool.” Her tone was light, but she had that look in her eyes that made Catra feel both furious and fond at the same time. Moments like this… having Adora back in her bubble… It felt so natural that it didn’t always feel fair. She worried about how Adora always made her feel like she was falling into something; tripping.

“...Something really cool.” Catra played along. Unsure how to make clear what she was feeling; and resistant to try any harder than she already was to figure it out. Adora sensed the shift. She pulled back slightly, opting instead to put a palm to Catra’s cheek. Gently, she turned Catra’s face to hers.

“We know that… I’m as much She-Ra as much as I’m… Not.” She smirked. Magic was messy. “I couldn’t stop being She-Ra for you… or anyone– ” Catra tensed. “But, I guess what I want to say is… I’m being more careful than you know… and…” Adora blushed. “I’m thinking about you pretty much all of the time, OK?” *Why was it only easy to be vulnerable with Catra by accident?*

“Of course you are. I’m amazing.” Catra deflected and looked off to the side instead of meeting Adora’s gaze.

“You’re better than amazing. You’re… Catra.” It startled even Adora as her tone shifted, dropping low. She inched her fingers up to hook just behind Catra’s ear. There it was, the good kind of purr.

“Unfair.” Catra mumbled, but she was looking at Adora now.

“I could stop.” Adora found herself grinning, but it wasn’t teasing. It just caught her sometimes… how much safer their closeness felt now. Even in all their fumbling uncertainty. She had let down her guard. Catra pounced, but not without cradling Adora as they fell to the bed. “Ey! Injured party over here.” Adora laughed as she deflected Catra’s playful swatting. It was delicate; tender.

“You’re just tired.” Catra’s tone was fragile; insistent. Her close cropped hair was growing out. The bangs slipped loose from behind her ear and fell forward softly as she gazed down at Adora. She was asking Adora to tell her the truth-- whether she was really ok.

“...Not that tired…” Adora murmured as she pulled her closer.

Crystal Clear

Chapter Summary

Hordak presses Entrapta for answers in Bright Moon.

The transition from sleeping to waking was never an easy one for Hordak. This was no exception. Groggy, disoriented, and blinking at a completely foreign ceiling, his anxiety spiked. Lost to any emotional tools Perfuma would have suggested, he bolted upright too quickly.

Dizzying, he faltered as he was swathed in the soft, but persistent push of those familiar tendrils. Gently, Hordak was lured back to bed. His agitation bled away, soaked up by the cot beneath. "Entrapta." *Embarrassed.* "Of course." Would she ever catch him doing something… becoming?

"Oh, Hordak." She smiled over him with a rare and delicate reticence; short lived though it was. "Tell. me. EVERYTHING." She bounced onto the cot beside him. Hordak chuckled softly and pressed his hand to his chest.

The minor ritual of searching for the data crystal had developed to a near compulsive tic in the time spent away from her. It was then that he realized that he was undressed. Bandaged thoroughly, his exosuit had been dismantled and set away to the side. This wasn't the first and certainly wouldn't be the last time that she would be needed in this way. He no longer recoiled at Entrapta's assistance. However, in this moment, Hordak found that he was bothered. *Was bothered the right word?*

She was markedly patient while he flitted from one ill-conceived emotion to another. He expected her usual pressing chatter in the wake of his silence, but she was quiet today. Hordak searched her placid expression for clarity when suddenly– a thought from before the accident stood out stark in his mind.

“Can you read Eternian, Entrapta?” She blinked back surprise.

“Did you find more data crystals?” Her eyes shone. “I’ve pieced together a rough working syllabary– It might be a little off. I should really ask Adora to look it over but, Y’know,” Entrapta shook out her hands spiritedly as she whispered with feigned wonder. “She-Ra!” Surprisingly, she wasn't wearing her gloves. “Adora’s pretty busy.”

Entrapta reached into a cargo pocket for her trackpad. She nestled into him as she did so; always so artless and unthinking in her intimacy. Instinctively, his arm extended to cradle her back; though he knew she wouldn’t fall. *Where to begin?* It was a struggle to press further. His tone was clipped as her presence, her nearness, engulfed him.

“The crystals you– curated… for the exosuit–”

“Oh! None of them were damaged. It held up wonderfully despite practical trials!” Entrapta laughed and reached across herself to pat his forearm; the arm that braced against her back. “I only broke it down because… I needed to make sure that you did too!” She let the hand rest there. Everything about her was so loose; free. Heat rose to Hordak’s face as his memory called upon that day… that she sat unceremoniously on the arm of his throne in the old lab, nearly in his lap. There was nothing nearly about this.

“What is inscribed on the crystals used in the exosuit?” It might have been the first moment where he had her bested in curiosity. Coaxingly steadfast in all of her guileless reassurance, there was a roaring in his ears as she responded with little ceremony:

“Chest plate: Loved, it stabilizes during your pain flares… Bracers: Flexibility, they monitor your stress markers and the suit responds accordingly. Core plate: Trust. It monitors markers of nutrient absorption.” She tucked toward Hordak, guiding his arm almost absently, so that his fingers traced across her stomach. Entrapta used her whisps of hair to brace the trackpad as she swiped through the blueprints with her free hand. Hordak barely glanced

at it. “My research reflects that the inscriptions are historically interpersonal notes and shorthand with little to no bearing on the data functions of the crystals so… I had a bit of fun.” She shrugged. “I hope you don’t mind–”

“Why?”

“Huh? Why would you mind? Oh, I don’t know. I’m supposed to ask.” She shrugged again. “The retooled functions are based on the physical we performed after She-Ra, y’know–” Entrapta mimicked an explosion. “Prime. That and data from the armada, what could be salvaged…” She frowned. Clearly irked that some of that knowledge remained out of her reach. “I really should have given you the rundown on what this baby can really do–” She tilted her head and looked up and away. “Never enough hours in the day!”

“No– Why those words?” Impatient; Hordak’s free hand sought after hers. Hesitance transitioned the sharp impulse into a soft caress. Entrapta offered no resistance as he examined her delicate fingers. She was everywhere he could think of. Nonplussed, she cast the trackpad aside.

“Well. Trust is what makes us partners…” Entrapta offered pensively. Her hair gestured in lieu of her occupied hands. Hordak marveled at the absence of the word ‘lab’. “Flexibility is necessary in friendship… according to Bow, anyway.” She paused, finally seeking eye contact. *Etherians… so very emotional.*

The memory struck Hordak; white hot. Though Horde Prime was certainly gone… the fragments of his influence slipped through the cracks when they were most unbidden. Her fingers slipped from his. Gingerly, Hordak reached for the hair that framed Entrapta’s face. In contrast to how Horde Prime had so callously snatched at it. Entrapta leaned in to his touch and pressed her palm to his bandaged chest. Still, so earnestly… unburdened by the memory so arresting to him now. Hordak’s breath hitched.

Closing what little distance there was between them felt easier than he could have prepared himself for. His lips brushed against hers; impractical, fleeting, and no doubt clumsy. Even still, he could only pray that the tenderness whispered through her the way it did him.

Hordak pulled away ever so slightly. Her eyelids fluttered open. Unsure how to handle anything that could come next, his fingers still threaded through her hair.

"Hm." Entrapta offered this small indecipherable noise. Hordak's heart was in his throat as her touch threaded up his body, both hands inching gently to cradle his face. One finger stroked teasingly along the line of his cheekbone. "You are so, so beautiful." Hushed, yet celebratory, each syllable shot through– electric.

So many memories exploded inside of him. He gathered up all of her borrowed words, straining to meld them together into a response– beautiful wasn't enough. Wonderful wasn't enough. Before he could gather himself, Entrapta firmly planted her lips on his once more. A roiling blend of feeling brewed in Hordak's chest. There was certainly fear, which he was never without, happiness, something he had thought he had known before her, but that was in question now… and undoubtedly, maddeningly… quenchingly–

He allowed himself permission to cradle this feeling as she held his face in her hands; this ever unreachable thing. Unworthy as he was, of Prime, of Etheria's forgiveness, of everything she had ever given him.

"I love you." His throaty whisper was incredulous; questioning– though it never could be in question. The veracity of it was intoxicating. She laughed, soft, but it bloomed in the room like a thunderclap. She pressed her forehead to his.

"Well, isn't that wonderful?" She murmured. And It was. It really was.

These Walls Have Eyes

Chapter Summary

> The queen and tech master discuss matters of National Security.

Bow was fretting. Fidgeting, he pressed his palm to his mouth. He had stumbled into Glimmer's office with so much intention, but faltered at the last second.

"You know you're going to have to tell me." Glimmer sang with a smug smirk. He made an anxious noise and sharply shook his head. "Is this a matter of national security?" She tried. He considered this for a moment, seemingly unsure… but ultimately shook his head again. "Gossip?" Her delight was evident. Fervently, Bow nodded. Glimmer let out a low whistle.

"Well, as queen, sensitive information really is *my duty* to be privy to. Ear to the ground. Eyes of the people, y'know?" Glimmer approached with a slight hip check. He was blushing harder than she'd ever seen.

"Did you catch Adora and Catra in the armory again? Weirdos." Glimmer admonished. But no, he was much too worked up. She walked around him, inspecting. "Something salacious…" Bow rocked on his heels. "...and yet so shocking you're hesitant to tell even me." Puzzled, she placed a hand to her face. Seconds ticked by. She could wait him out. Finally, Bow couldn't take it anymore.

“Entrapta and Hordak are making out!” He gasped. Glimmer staggered back.

“Gross!!!” She covered her face with one hand. “I never needed to know that. EVER.” Her other arm flailed outward.

“I’m heading to his room, y’know, checking in with supplies– recuperating banter– oh god I think all of the bandages are still on the floor in the hallway! Someone could trip.” He was rambling now.

“Hush.” Glimmer placated. “It’s ok. You’ve just seen something genuinely horrifying. Here. Sit.” If Bow’s thousand yard stare was any indication, she was only slightly exaggerating. They burst into nervous laughter.

“How am I supposed to look him in the face?” He wheezed, clutching his sides. “I mean.” Bow gesticulated awkwardly. “It was– They were– It was a lot.” Glimmer snorted.

“I have no idea.” Glimmer sighed. The laughter trailed off. She crossed her arms. “I feel kind of bad now.” She tapped her foot. “It’s not as if we didn’t know they were… something? But I guess… maybe exile was hard on them?” She shuddered and threw up her hands.

“Hard on them?! I say, as if he wasn’t a baby snatching; dad disappearing warlord!” She groaned. “Being queen is the worst!”

Bow rose from the seat she had coddled him into and pulled her close.

"You know I support your decision no matter what. Like you said. He's got so much to answer for… but, if I'm being honest?" Bow turned her face up to his. "He's been a decent help– and you heard Adora. He really came through for her, for everyone, down in the core." Glimmer pouted.

"And we already vetoed just… throwing him a pit? Shipping him out to sea?" She joked.

"Leave him to Mermista? Oh god. Mermista." Their stomachs dropped at the thought.

"She can *never* know." Glimmer's whisper was pitched dangerously high. "She'd never stop throwing up. Just waste away and die." It always made Bow cackle how Glimmer could flit like this. Teasing melodically one minute; deadpan and bricklike the next.

"But really, though." Bow pressed her to consider the real problem before them.

"I know, I'm queen, I know… but I really think it's still going to be up to Dad." It made her feel small; thinking of his time alone on the island. Everything he not only missed, but everything he had, had to endure.

“Do you want me to talk to him about it?” Bow offered.

“Would you?” Glimmer pushed up on her tiptoes pleadingly. Their noses pressed together.

“I am Tech Master.” He shrugged; teasing and self-satisfied. “Like you said, duties must be done.” She squeezed him tight before whispering softly in his ear.

“Just promise to never tell me what her hair was doing.”

“CANNOT UNSEE.” Bow blanched and wailed. Glimmer cackled as she slapped him on the back.

Old Habits

Chapter Summary

> Hordak receives an unexpected visitor. Healing and growth proves nonlinear.

Hordak slumped down into the bed with a groan. He was the very picture of fatigue. Healing magic, astounding though it was, had its limits. Entrapta had returned to her duties. This fresh absence amplified his feelings of fragility and incompetence. He grimaced thinking back to Perfuma's check-in earlier that day. If he had to hear the word gratitude one more time-- but she would be right. He was wallowing unnecessarily. Never before had he held discernment for so many people at once. It was, of course, good; beautiful. But in that same way it was imperfect; exhausting. Stressful.

"I'd be lying if I said this wasn't still a little fun for me." Hordak launched himself up in shock at the sound of Catra's teasing drawl. She leaned against the doorframe with characteristic nonchalance.

"I hate to do this when you're…well…" She flicked a dismissive wrist. "Recuperating." Her tone was the farthest thing from earnest. Hordak looked away with a sigh.

Sauntering lithly forward, she settled into a stolid stance of defiance at the foot of his bed.



“Catra.” Hordak acknowledged her flatly. His tone was gruff.

“Unfortunately for everyone, Scorpia needs your help. I’m here to ensure that you provide your full cooperation.” Glib, her tone was insufferable. He set his jaw against her condescending ultimatum. “You are going to comb that self-involved skull of yours for anything even close to interesting, regardless of how uncomfortable it makes you.”

“In this infernal place with so few doors, I don’t see how I could refuse.” They stared each other down for a stubborn eternity. Hordak broke first. Reticent though he was to try again. To be better. To do better.

“If anything useful comes to mind. I assure you, I will not withhold it. But that is all I can swear to.” Catra glared. It was clear that she still didn’t trust him. He wrestled with this. Any pacification of Catra’s resentment would be decidedly hard won if saving Adora hadn’t even made a dent.

“I guess I’m questioning what you consider useful.” Her response was snide, but there was something beneath it. Hordak struggled with the nuance of such things, but that intangible something made him very, very angry. Rattled, a streak of venomous words burst out unbidden.

“Do you delight in this, Catra? Playing pretend in the history of our mutual failure?” He spat. “I can hardly play your games when I know nothing of your rules.” Icy shock washed the smugness from Catra’s face. *But he was right, wasn’t he?* She tripped into this old coat that no longer fit every time she dealt with him. Digesting this realization with revulsion; she could think of nothing more to say.

Emotion roiled, spilling over Catra’s tense shoulders in bitter waves. Hordak was powerless to endure or escape it. Leaden silence pressed upon them. Finally, Catra dropped her arms. For now, it seemed, the battle was over. She stalked toward the doorway with fists clenched.

“Catra–” Hordak bid in diffidence at the last moment, but Catra merely kissed her teeth. That would be his only acknowledgement. She slipped down the hallway and out of sight.

Too Few Hands

Chapter Summary

> Micah confronts Hordak in the hope of making a well-informed choice.

Micah paced the hallway. He had been mulling for a few days now. Not proud of how he had responded to Bow– he would apologize later. But he could put this off no longer. He could think of only one more thing to do before making his choice. Micah squared his shoulders before knocking sharply on the archway. Hordak looked up with a start. He was dressed and sitting at the edge of the bed, skimming through data on a trackpad. Neither party seemed to know what sort of greeting made sense here. Hordak set the trackpad down and plainly directed full attention to Micah.

"Adora made it a point to say… that your actions in the core were decisive, if impulsive." Micah's stern expression was unlikely to shift, though his words carried no aggression. "When your first impulse is to save a person that my daughter cares about, I can hardly keep demonizing you, can I?" If anything, his tone was wry.

"Well, you could certainly try." Hordak turned up his palm thinking of Catra.

"Aw geez. Well now don't I owe Adora a slice of cake. She said you were making jokes. Should've believed her." Micah had been wrong. He wasn't ready for this at all. *Shooting the breeze with Hordak?* He turned to depart. "Well, that's it. That's all I needed to

say.” But he steeled himself against his cowardice as Hordak rose from the bed; it pressed Micah to hold ground.

“I can’t be certain that this information will hold value–” Hordak’s frustration was clear as the words he imparted peppered out in short bursts. “... I can do nothing to repair your anguish in exile.” Micah quirked an eyebrow. “But Perfuma encourages me to… take emotional risks.” He managed to grumble. There was a loaded pause.

“Alright. I’ll bite.” Micah folded his arms across his chest; braced for what might follow.

“I decreed to Shadow Weaver that you be put to death.”

Micah was rattled by this admission. “Is that a threat?”

“No. Certainly not.” Hordak lifted his palms once more; a gesture of penitence. “I believe she ensured your survival. For what reason, I cannot say.” As Micah’s expression darkened, Hordak became less and less confident in his choice to speak. “It seemed important that you know… that I was not an instrument, however small, in the reunion you have had… with your daughter.”

“Well it’s not as if I was harboring any sort of gratitude.” Micah scoffed. “But I appreciate you telling me something that… really couldn’t possibly serve you.” A glimpse of his past regality, a shadow of his noble discernment, crossed Micah’s face. He shook

his head quizzically, banishing it instead with a wistful smirk. “Unfortunately, or fortunately… that is likely to be something else that sets you apart from Shadow Weaver. Whatever reasons she may have had not to kill me… I guarantee they were only in service to herself.” Hordak nodded solemnly. He could offer nothing else to this man.

“I understand now that it was not of value to share. Risk… taken.” Hordak declared dryly as he broke eye contact with Micah.

“Maybe. Maybe not.” Micah was pensive. As he took his leave, he thought aloud to himself with the barest sense of a potentially shifting regard. “Certainly. impulsive.”

Visiting Hours

Chapter Summary

Hordak attempts to seek privacy and finds Scorpia instead.

Restless in the end stages of his recuperation, Hordak had finally endeavored to leave his quarters. They were hardly private after all. Visitor after visitor. It was dizzying. But, he would not allow himself to yearn for the solace of his old lab– with numbness mistaken for peace and desperation disguised as purpose. He marched into the garden, intent to intimate himself better with Etheria's natural mysteries now that he had the patience for them. He pulled out his trackpad to compare readings on the plants. It was then that Scorpia crept up from behind.

"Hey! Well, look at you!" Scorpia boomed. "Adora told me how great you did out there, H-Man." Hordak grimaced.

"I will *not* be answering to that." He warned. Scorpia tapped her claws together tentatively.

"I don't know if Catra… might have mentioned…?" *Ever bashful, this towering specimen of potential destruction.* Hordak thought uncharitably in his fatigue.

"--She alluded." He headed Scorpia off. "I have faced Catra's ire before. I don't intend to repeat the experience." He waved her closer. "What do you require of me?" Scorpia was touched. She had asked for help, but Catra had seemed distracted. She hadn't expected her to follow through.

“I’m here to ask about my family.” Dread rose up in Scorpia. Could there possibly be an answer to her questions that wasn’t steeped in tragedy?

“Ah.” Hordak’s eyes brightened with recognition. “It was folly for me not to have anticipated this.” He nodded slowly. “You may not believe me… but I did not harm them. Not directly.” It struck him, then, that he was no longer so satisfied with what his sense of harm actually was. Scorpia tensed. *Could it be true?*

“–I would have.” Hordak was curt. “At the time. But it did not prove necessary.” He shrugged. Such a callous declaration… Scorpia supposed it *had* to be true. “Scorpius’ first priority being his lineage… an agreement was swiftly settled. The threat I posed was… sufficient.”

Scorpia considered this. “So you don’t know anything else about them? *Nothing?”* Flustered, she didn’t relish the thought of choking up in front of Hordak. He turned away from her imploring gaze.

“What I know seems… irrelevant.”

“Well it has to be better than knowing nothing at all!” The intensity of Scorpia’s frustration startled them both. Hordak forced himself to look at her. His brow furrowed with consternation.

“In your historical research… what do you know of Chiton Blight?” He spoke of the incurable sickness that lead to the Scorpioni exodus from the waste. The inciting incident that forced Chnida to form the political alliance with the Lizardfolk.

“Only that there seemed to be no answer for it… that it resulted in unprecedented death.”

“There were also observed hereditary consequences. According to the talks held with your grandfather, the comparatively few children that followed was… correlated.” He clenched his fists. “I did not physically harm your family. I did, however, viciously exploit them in their time of weakness. Survival was all that they could afford to consider.”

“So, they did leave the Fright Zone.” A shadow fell across Scorpia’s face. “They left *me* .” She could feel Hordak scanning her expression.

“Now that your connection to the Black Garnet has been restored, you understand Shadowweaver’s intent in ensuring that you did not leave the Fright Zone?” He asked. Scorpia nodded slowly.

“An experiment at best and her backup plan at worst.” Scorpia laughed mirthlessly. “What an honour.”

“I do not know what she said to them or how she manipulated the flow of magic from the Black Garnet. I did not care for the

particulars.” Hordak’s expression was one of disgust. “She promised me power. Power that stood a chance against the chaotic maelstrom of this planet’s bewildering magic.” His fists clenched. *What a fitting conversation for his foray into the garden.* “Magic was the only thing I was willing to admit I couldn’t contend with.” Such false bravado curdled in his stomach now. “She was evidently a more adept orator than she was a sorceress.” Scorpia felt like she was seeing him for the first time. *Just like Wildcat.* She thought. Hordak shook his head, an attempt to free himself from the clutches of a steadfast memory.

“My ignorance regarding your family was willful.” He looked pointedly at Scorpia. “From what I can tell, I can offer you little else.” She considered this. He hoped it would be enough, but it wasn’t.

“You know my grandfather’s name.” Scorpia acknowledged. “His was the only one I was sure of. Did you meet… *any* of the others?” Hordak’s eyes brightened with recognition.

“Head of the war council… Telsa.” He clawed back in his mind. “Tall. Dark hair.” His recollection was paltry. Scorpia reached into her pocket for her long-cherished photograph. She pointed to the woman on the left cradling plump, young Scorpia. Hordak nodded encouragingly.

“Is she… is she my mother?” Scorpia pressed.

“No… I don’t think so… but related… yes.” He was hesitant to provide accidentally fabricated details. “This one here.” He tapped

a finger to the smaller woman's face. "I believe it was her." Hordak sighed in frustration. "Though, her name was not relevant to me." Scorpia struggled to process this.

"The mural in Horror Hall." She couldn't stop herself, no matter how dissatisfying his answers were. Again, Hordak nodded with trepidation. "There was one that looked like me and one other person. Another girl."

"Your mirror, yes." Hordak thought back to nights when his pain flares inhibited him from sleeping. For lack of better distraction, in the early days of occupation, he often found himself there. He had nearly forgotten.... Let it, like so many things, just crumble. "I can't speak to how they captured the likeness, you being so young then... but the other girl-- She was not so young." He tried. "I believe I saw her once… just before—-" *Before they left me behind.* Scorpia deflated visibly. "I can only guess, but it seemed a sort of ritualistic tribute." Scorpia touched at her tuft of hair. She'd be lying if she tried to discern what came first... the mural's likeness to her, or her imitation of it.

"The Blight…" He pivoted. "They had reason to believe it was exacerbated by climate. I heard talk of the desert." He was reaching now. "Perhaps the waste?"

"But they *left* the waste." Scorpia howled in exasperation. Hordak considered this.

"All the more reason to return. Weather is often unpredictable. Perhaps there was a time when it was different there? Less arid?" With great difficulty, he decided to add. "I sought for something

that could give me a sense of stability, of familiarity for a long time… perhaps it was their same hope… even if there were risks." Tension raked through every muscle. This conversation was bitterly uncomfortable. He prayed desperately for that to be the end of it. Indecisive as ever. Scorpia waffled beside him.

"Is there anything else?" He pushed. Hordak's agitation made Scorpia jump. He regretted it immediately. He would have apologized, but Scorpia spoke over him.

"I've taken up enough of your time," She stepped backward. "Thanks...H-Man."

He chose to let it slide just this once.

Irony

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer talk dead moms.

Catra slouched over the basin in the greenhouse with one arm dangling lazily. It had been empty for some time. No one around to brew potions or 'tea', apparently. Catra suspected wine, in truth, to have been much more likely. Since her return from Obsidian, and Adora's accident, she had started coming here. *Why* ? It was humid and overcast. Catra expected rain. It always made her sleepy like this.

"You too, huh?" Glimmer's acknowledgement was soft and a little shy. She leaned against the entrance. Catra rose to full height. A reflex. Glimmer ported closer. Catra waved the shower of sparkles away. "I really don't know what to do with it all most of the time." Glimmer mused; looking upward.

"The plants?" Catra wasn't following. Glimmer shook her head.

"Nope. The feelings." She clasped her hands behind her back. Catra scoffed.

"You princesses." She muttered dismissively.

" *Us princesses* ." Glimmer mimicked with a smirk. "She may have been the absolute worst…" she alluded. "But she was something–"

“She was something alright.” Catra snapped.

“Something like a mom… even if she wasn’t a very good one.” Glimmer wasn’t going to let it go. Bitterly, Catra put in the effort. She wouldn’t let this conversation degrade into a squabble she would cringe over later. This girl with the dead mom was trying to make Catra feel better. She wouldn’t make Glimmer feel worse. Not on purpose. Not anymore.

“I can’t tell any of them apart.” Catra flicked at a dangling vine.

“The plants?” Glimmer asked. Catra rolled her head back in an expression of annoyance.

“No. *The feelings.”* She rolled her eyes toward Glimmer. The mocking tone won her a chuckle. “--and don’t you dare say that sounds like a job for Perfuma.” Catra anticipated. Glimmer cackled.

“Oh no. Not my style either, personally.” She swung her arm over and landed a light, glancing punch to Catra’s shoulder. “She tried a bit… after.” They both knew what after meant. “I don’t think I have the patience.” Catra nodded along. “‘Hypervigilance is a sign of trauma.’ She’d say. ‘You’re a hyper pain in my butt.’ I’d say.”

“Real classy, Sparkles.”

“The very picture of royal diplomacy.” Glimmer posed with her tone dripping in sarcasm. Catra laughed.

“An excellent warrior queen.” Catra recalled, thinking of Lonnie.

“I like the sound of that!” Glimmer manifested her sorcery staff and flung it around a bit before tucking it back away. “... but maybe it’s a bit nicer most of the time being a boring, civic duties sort of queen.” She sighed, reluctant. “My mom tried to warn me about that.” Catra hated watching people be wistful. Stiffly, she pulled Glimmer toward her in a half-baked, one-armed sort of hug.

“Aw! Catra!” Glimmer crushingly reciprocated, nearly lifting Catra off the ground.

“Regretting. It.” She hissed. Glimmer obligingly released her.

“I wonder sometimes if she’s really completely gone?” Glimmer whispered after a moment. “It’s harder when… there isn’t anything left behind… to mourn.” She looked to Catra. Catra bristled; but held her gaze.

“Shadowweaver always seemed to pop back up when no one ever wanted her to.” Catra protracted and retracted the claws on one

hand as she thought. “Such a classic Shadowweaver move… staying gone. This time.”

“I couldn’t be more grateful that Dad is back in my life, y’know…” Glimmer trailed off. Hesitant to speak the feeling into existence.

“But it doesn’t help with that sort of… wishful thinking?” Catra finished. Glimmer nodded. They were quiet for a while. A soft patter began to fall against the roof. *There was the rain.*

“Yep.” Glimmer’s tone was noncommittal.

“Yep.” Catra echoed back.

Crossroads

Chapter Summary

At Bright Moon's discretion, Hordak is relocated. Again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hordak was glad to see the back end of Bright Moon. But, relocating again… He admitted that it made him uncomfortable. *Nervous?* It was still a struggle identifying complex emotions. It took effort not to slip into memories; habits. Dusk was creeping in as he arrived.

Hordak braced against the corridor wall. The burnished metal felt pleasantly familiar against his palm. He could feel a low hum beneath: the whisper of machines hard at work. He shifted his weight, adjusting the crate of data crystals he had received from Bow to unload. There was a sense that he was being watched; but he was probably imagining it. He trudged forward.

They had decided to pivot. Glimmer had said. Bright Moon’s priority was learning all that they could from what had been salvaged from the core. With Beast Island neutralized, it was a waste of resources for him to remain stationed there. Simply a pragmatic decision; it only made sense for Etheria’s most technically minded to be working together. Bow, having varied duties, was simply not available frequently enough to be a valuable asset to Entrapta’s research.

Hordak would go where he was directed. He was bound by those terms. To be given this opportunity felt like a trap. There was nothing stopping them from sending him somewhere else, anywhere else, “where need proved greatest.” Whenever they chose. This fear crept up like moss. It sapped from him any happiness that it made more sense to feel. His stomach lurched. In a bitter, raw moment he realized that he wanted to speak to Perfuma.

They had agreed to proceed with discussions by trackpad “while he got settled”; though it was distinctly not Perfuma’s preference. He wouldn’t quite admit that it wasn’t his preference either. She had become a 'grounding presence'. Hordak shuddered at the realization.

“Entrapta?” He stopped and called out with trepidation. His voice echoed back at him. He had been warned that Dryl could be confusing at first. There was a sudden sound to the left: the hiss of a hermetic entrance. A slight, smartly dressed person with bronze skin and a bright tuft of teal hair looked to Hordak with dissatisfaction.

“This way.” They waved Hordak along brusquely. *How would he greet her? They had barely had a moment since…* He followed his guide dutifully; unsure whether they were resentful of their task or his presence. As they passed what seemed to be the same picture frame for the third time, Hordak deduced that either possibility would be reasonable. They came to an abrupt stop.

“Here.” His guide gestured to a doorway. “--I think. Probably.” They scrutinized their watch. It looked to be of Entrapta's design.

“Thank you?” Hordak was not convinced.

“Oh no. Not there.” Entrapta manifested somehow. They jumped. She shooed Hordak toward a different door instead. “That’s Lab C. Not yet.” Her smile was coy. “We’ll get to it. Thanks, Pip!” Pip bowed out of sight. Entrapta paused. “Oh!” Her hair snatched up Hordak’s crate. A fervent giggle bubbled up as she stared hungrily at the crystals. “ *These gorgeous girls* belong in Lab C.” She swept away for a moment. There was some vague clattering. Hordak took a deep breath. *What was behind this door if not the lab?*

She was suddenly behind him, Her hair lifted her to his eye line. A tendril snaked out to punch in the keycode as she rested her chin on his tense shoulder. Hordak swallowed as she nudged him through the doorway. Soft lavender lights blinked to life with a faint buzz. The room was massive. The room was also completely empty. Hordak looked around quizzically.

“It’s a sanctum!” She threw up her hands. “For whatever you want!” Seconds ticked by as Hordak tried to make sense of this. “You can pretty much do whatever you want wherever you want at Dryl anyway– I do, but… that’s beside the point.” She waited patiently just over his shoulder. He turned slightly.

"If I recall, you were constantly sneaking into my sanctum." His tone was dry.

"That's because your sanctum was also a lab. I have labs!" She grinned

“Thank you.” He studied her cheeky expression, willing himself to be present. She draped her arms over his shoulders. Startled at first, Hordak placed his unsure arms around her waist. They stood that way, as if about to dance, for a precious moment. Entrapta drew her arms back abruptly as a fresh thought struck her. Hordak surprised himself as he held fast; keeping his hands settled at her hips.

“You’re going to need this!” Her hair pulled out a replica of the watch that Pip wore from a pocket in her pants. It dropped into Entrapta's upturned palms. “It pings with your trackpad for navigation.” She grinned. “Bow made me invent them after he accidentally got locked in a storage closet.” Hordak thought back to that infernal painting and chuckled softly with relief. She ran a hand down his arm. Begrudgingly, he lifted his wrist so that she could fasten the band. Buoyant, she cupped her hands firmly around his.

“So, what next?” Hordak asked, staring at his hand in hers. She pulled him along and chattered as she went.

“There’s the labs of course, we can save those for last, I guess you don't care about the kitchen– Sophie can bring you whatever you need…. I promise Lief visits only sometimes. Mostly he’s in Erlandia in the rooming house we had built for the clones…” Hordak frowned. Lief was so *irritating* . This distracted him for a moment and he missed some of what Entrapta said. She was looking at him expectantly.

“What?”

“Where do you want to sleep?” The question stirred up so many anxieties: his pain flares; his insomnia; the nightmares. Fitful dozing mid-task in a lab felt like the safest rest he knew how to have. He thought back to a time, forever ago now, where he had roused with such a rare sense of peace. He had nodded off at the work bench. Entrapta leaned against his shoulder, having done the very same.

“Where do you sleep?” It wasn’t quite an answer, but she seemed untroubled by the question.

“The lab mostly…” She admitted. “But here, my room’s just down this way.”

Hordak noted how the materials shifted depending on which corridor they turned down. Dryl seemed to branch out hungrily, picking up space as it was needed. He was certain that this wing was older than all of the others.

The flooring was no longer metal. Sleek marble guided them forward. The walls transitioned to stone. He realized, like most of Etheria, he knew nothing about Dryl’s history but was reluctant to ask. It had not taken him long to realize that the most common answer to the question “What happened here?” was inevitably “The Horde.” At this thought– without warning– his body betrayed him. Hordak’s breath began to stutter and hitch. Soon, he could

only force short, frantic bursts. He dropped to his knees as lightning raked up his back. A stinging sensation settled at the crown of his head. Entrapta turned back to him with alarm.

"Hordak?!" Her reaction was swift. His stomach had bottomed out against a spiking pain, like an arrow to the heart. Entrapta knelt down to meet him. She held a hand to his chest as she pulled up his vitals on her trackpad. Time stretched out for Hordak as his field of vision narrowed.

"Hey now, hey now." Hordak distantly registered the clatter of the trackpad as Entrapta cast it aside. She lifted her hand from his chestplate. Pulling her gloves off, she placed one hand just above the collar of the exosuit. She used her other hand to lift his head, to pull his gaze toward her. "Come on. Breathe with me."

He struggled to focus at first. But, before long, with her fingers at the nape of his neck and threaded through his hair– the pain receded; adrenaline siphoned off; his breathing began to steady. She pulled him in. He buried his face in her neck with desperate hands clutching at her back. She stroked at his hair. He never wanted to let go– never wanted her to let go, but eventually she did.

"There we go. All ok here." Her hair shot behind her and returned the trackpad to her eye line. She nodded as she flicked through the updated readings. "Mmm yep. That was a real doozy." She helped him steady to his feet. "I think we'll both need at least a nap after all that." She smiled warmly as she gave his hand a little squeeze. Her hair stuffed the cast off gloves into her back pocket. Hordak was still feeling unsettled. Did a new sort of flare mean that–

“I’m not so good with this…” She hedged. She had dropped her pace so that she was no longer pulling him along. She settled at his side. “You should know that your readings are within range. Don’t worry about any of that. It– it wasn’t a flare.” It took her a while to process what she planned to say. “You’ll want to tell Perfuma about this, I think.” Finally, Entrapta lead him into a dark room. She dropped his hand to clap. Lamps bloomed to life. There wasn’t much to it: a plush carpet, low light, and a surprisingly large bed wedged in the corner with the covers flung off to the side: clearly shucked off impatiently as Entrapta began her day.

“Tadaa~” She whispered with a laugh as she plonked herself down on the bed. Hordak stood in the middle of the room; somewhat dazed and unsure. He almost hoped that Entrapta would drag him along with her hair as she often did. Instead, she carefully unthreaded her pigtails. Rigidly, he approached the bed and sat down beside her. She leaned to the left a little to close the gap between them. She gathered up her swathes of hair into a single bunch at the base of her neck.

“I don’t think we’ve ever spent this much time not talking tech.” Entrapta thought aloud as her hair braided itself into a low side ponytail. She was probably right. “We might have to start.” She laughed. “-- *not* talking tech. I mean. We’ll definitely talk tech. I have such big plans…” She trailed off. Gears turning. Hordak nodded slowly. His shoulders were still tight, but from different sorts of feelings. He thought again about what had happened in the hallway.

“You have been here a very long time.” He acknowledged.

“Longer than you. I think.” Entrapta affirmed.

“It’s painful that… there are many ways in which we could have never come to know each other.” His expression was grave. “That I had possibly– certainly– put you in danger without understanding what… a horrible thing that could have been.” His chest grew tight again, but with Entrapta leaning into him, he found it easier to manage. “I was callous and indifferent to the value of life for so many years.”

“You did come from clones.” Entrapta snorted. “It didn’t make sense to you. How could it?” She shrugged. “But then when it did… it did.” Surprised, Hordak laughed at this.

“I suppose that’s a measured, if charitable hypothesis.”

Entrapta nudged him again “Sleeping must be more difficult in that.” He looked down at the exosuit. Though svelte in its design, it wouldn’t be a practical decision. “I’m sorry for not considering it before.” She frowned. “I’ll draft some variant schematics in the morning.” She rose from the bed, coaxing him up.

She broke down the suit as she usually did. Though, slower this time, relying more on her hands with her hair more limited in this style. All of the usual necessary tools– of course– still jangling about in her pockets. In the low light, after such a long day, with her deft hands feathering across his body… It struck Hordak very differently.

At last, she turned away and crouched down to organize the suit parts in the far corner of the room. Absorbed already in future plans, she mumbled notes into her recorder. Hordak stepped backward, nearer again to the bed. His undergarments had been designed optimally to complement the suit's functions and reduce chafing. They were perfectly comfortable– when he wasn't standing alone in a room with Entrapta. He blushed as he cast an arm across his bare midriff. Entrapta jumped up abruptly. She dusted her hands together.

"That will have to do for now." She declared cheerily. Hordak fixated on the small of her back as she pulled off her boots. Without preamble, she shimmied casually out of her overalls and spun to face him. Taken aback, he dropped to the bed. She smiled mischievously. Hordak was stricken. She launched herself onto the bed laughing.

"I've never hosted a slumber party before." Entrapta mused, before tipping slowly backwards. She had all the room to fan out with still room left for Hordak– though he hadn't moved from his rigidly occupied corner edge.

"This bed is comically large." Hordak observed.

"Yeah. It's a princess thing." Entrapta shrugged; staring at the ceiling. In the wake of her unparalleled ease, Hordak gathered his courage. He dropped his arm and inched closer. Her gaze, heavy-lidded and curious, followed him. Stiffly, He lay down beside her. It was only now that he realized that the walls were not, in fact, adorned with some sort of pattern or filigree, but equations– scribbled by a young Entrapta, he had to assume. This discovery warmed and bolstered him. He turned his body to face her. She

reached her arms up to clap softly. They were plunged into blackness.

He reached ardently for her nearness in the dark. He felt her arm pull up and across, swathing the blanket over them. She draped her hand again at the base of his neck. He pulled her in close. She curled up against his chest.

“Goodnight, Hordak.” She murmured low.

“Sleep well, Entrapta.” He breathed.

Chapter End Notes

It took all of the strength of my soul not to use "it hit different." in a Hordak centric narrative, guys. I'm still laughing.

Also, the word box quickly became crate in edits when the phrase "Entrapta's hair snatched up Hordak's box" had me nearly in tears XD

Little Shop

Chapter Summary

Scorpia sets out in search of her family.

"Ready, Big Gal?" Huntara elbowed Scorpia expectantly.

"Ready!" Scorpia's excitement was feigned. She couldn't be excited yet. There was only room for nerves. They expected the trek to take about two hours if the sandstorms weren't too bad. Huntara wasn't exactly chatty. Scorpia did what she could to keep her thoughts inside thoughts.

It gave Scorpia time to think back on the last few months. She had done her best to juggle her genealogy research and her duties as ambassador. This would be their first real lead toward finding her family. There were rumors of a Scorpioni apothecary to the northwest of the settlement with which they had just concluded introductory talks.

The more time Scorpia spent in the Waste, the prettier it was. It had meant something important when she had first come here with Catra, sure, but that wasn't about the Waste… anywhere that wasn't the Fright Zone would have felt that way.

She loved the way the warmth baked her carapace and how she slept so deeply during the piercing cold nights. She and Perfuma had even begun talking about a seasonal home. Scorpia tried not to run away with a daydream of spending winters in the Waste reunited with her entire family.

“Too soon.” She mumbled to herself. Huntara made no acknowledgement. Time passed steadily. Finally, Scorpia stood in front of a ramshackle cottage. A fierce wind cut across her face; abrasive with kicked up sand.

“Are you sure you won’t come in?” She half-pleaded with Huntara.

“Touchy feely reunions just ain’t my style, Big Gal.” Huntara slapped Scorpia on the back. “From here, you’re on your own. Y’all can meet me back at the bar when all the baggage is unpacked.” Scorpia wished Perfuma could have been there.

–

The shop was poorly lit and a little dusty. Stuffed to the brim with chaotic curios… it was unlikely hospitality was a necessary strong suit. It seemed the sort of place where all the last things ended up. If you found yourself there… it was the only place left to look.

Scorpia thought it was empty at first. She was hesitant to venture further into the stacks where her hulking frame posed great risk to the many glass bottles of mysterious liquid and bowls full of loose ingredients. But before Scorpia really knew what she was looking at… there she was.

The woman was willowy… bordering on reedy, really. All knees and elbows. Her skin was pallid. Her rich dark hair spilled over her shoulders in waves. It was the most lively thing about her; like she was the root and her hair was the shrub. She bent over a drafting table. An aura of fervency and something like frustration radiated from her scribbling. Consumed as she was, Scorpia may as well have been a lamp.

"...Hey there." Scorpia winced at the sound of her own voice. She brought her pincers together timidly. It felt like she was going to scare away the dustmotes. Waning light spilt from the lone window. The woman's shoulders tensed in shock. "I'm here to see a girl about a Scorpioni?" Scorpia laughed a little. The woman's head snapped toward her. They locked eyes; big, dark eyes. Possibly the only feature they shared-- Besides the pincers and whatnot. Her work materials clattered to the floor as she rose.

"No." Her voice was a little raspy, dry at the edges like fallen leaves. She tugged at a fistful of her bottlebrush hair. "Oh no. No way." She stumbled forward, scrabbling at the side of the desk to snatch up a cane. Leaning on it, she was able to approach more smoothly. "Scorpia!?" The woman's tail knocked something off a shelf with a clatter.

"That's me?" Scorpia held up her pincers and waved them awkwardly. "I'm sorry… I think I'm supposed know you, but I don't?" She fumbled. "I came looking for anyone really, but I wasn't sure who I would find…" The woman's smile was slight and sad.

"Hadra." She gestured toward herself. "We're cousins."

“Hadra…” Scorpia nodded to herself. “Pretty name.”

“Thanks.” Hadra chuckled. She looked off to the side. “We– I… was certain you were dead.” She stepped closer, scanning Scorpia as if still unconvinced. She reached out a pincer but drew it back at the last second.

“Why?” Scorpia knew the answer could be simple: the war. But it seemed like it wasn’t going to be.

“Come, let’s have a seat in the back. How do you feel about tea?” Scorpia thought about the bitter, hot leaf water that Perfuma brewed every morning. It really wasn’t Scorpia’s thing.

“Oh boy, I sure would love some.” She said instead. As she followed Hadra into the back, Scorpia realized that it was built for her. For Scorpioni. All of the furniture and tools took into account things like pincers and tails. Scorpia’s heart fluttered in her chest. She sat at the kitchen table hopefully. Hadra dithered about; somewhat scattered.

“There was this… woman.” She finally said as she retrieved an icy pitcher and two glasses. “She was tall and… spooky?” Hadra struggled. “I was nine. The word I’m going with is spooky.”

“Shadowweaver.” Scorpia’s stomach dropped. As Hadra set the glasses down, Scorpia noted the iced tea smelled pleasantly sweet. Maybe she would like it after all.

“You had been feverish, our mums were always whispering about it. They were clearly scared.” Hadra poured for them both and sat down with a sigh. Scorpia took a hesitant sip and was rewarded with a full-bodied, honeyed sort of taste.

“The woman had told us that you had CB. It wouldn’t be safe to take you. That there was nothing to be done.”

“She told you I had Chiton Blight?” Scorpia nearly spat out her tea. Hadra nodded with her brows furrowed. “Shadowweaver faked my death?!” Scorpia threw her head back. “Jeez, there is no end to that bitch.” This made Hadra let out a wheezing laugh.

“Well… at least there’s a cure now.” Hadra’s smile was pained. Scorpia scrambled nervously.

“Oh no. Shadowweaver definitely lied about me having Chiton Blight. I wasn’t miraculously healed or anything… at least… I don’t think…?” It was hard to be sure about anything now. Hadra laughed again, but it was mirthless.

“No! No– I cured it. It was me.” She hiked up her skirt to reveal heavy scarring up one leg. “It took time.” She bit her lip. “Too

little; too late.” Hadra brushed her skirt back down. “I’m so sorry, Scorpia.” She bowed her head.

“Oh.” It was a soft, sad sound. Again, Hadra nodded. Scorpia frowned. “Hadra– listen.” Scorpia’s tone was firm. Hadra sniffled before looking up. “I’m so sorry you had to go through all that alone…When?” Scorpia swallowed.

"Six years ago." She blinked back tears. “After all this time-- you come here looking for hope… and all you get… is me.” Scorpia reached out her pincer to Hadra’s.

“You have to understand, Hadra, that finding you is better than I ever could have hoped for. You are more than enough.”

Hadra drew in a shaky breath that devolved into shuddering sobs of relief. Scorpia nearly knocked over her chair as she rose to gather up Hadra into a hug.

“I missed you so much…” Hadra whispered.

“I wish I remembered more.” Scorpia mumbled. Hadra pulled back.

“I will gladly tell you everything I know– everything I can.” She smiled.

“Sounds like we’re going to need some more tea!”

–

“They’ve been calling it *Horror* Hall? Ugh!” Hadra scowled; muttering, “it’s like saying RSVP, please--but worse.” She rubbed at her temples. “It’s called a Harrehr. It means ‘meeting place’”

“Ha! I knew we weren’t bad guys!” Scorpia announced triumphantly. “Wait– you *know* Scorpioni?”

“That might be too generous.” Hadra shrugged. “The language is actually Hhksa – But, it’s easy to get rusty when there’s no one left.” Her laugh was sardonic. Scorpia was hesitant to ask for more from Hadra. She sensed Scorpia’s trepidation. “I told you– *everything* I know. I would be delighted to be the worst teacher you’ve ever had.” She snickered.

“I’ve had worse teachers. Trust me.” Scorpia thought of Octavia’s combat drills. She grew somber.

“Tell me about mum.”

“Aunt Ceph?” Hadra’s eyes misted over. “She was *so* graceful… and kind… and her voice–”

“She could sing?” Scorpia was hungry for an anchor that could bond her to this ghost.

“Could she ever.” Hadra shook her head ruefully. “...She never stopped thinking about you.” This made Scorpia tear up.

“Oh– Oh no.” She failed to compose herself. Hadra reached across the table and tapped her pincer rhythmically against Scorpia’s. The shock of it stifled Scorpia’s blubbering. She tapped back, surprised that she knew how it went. Hadra was delighted.

“You still remember a little Tehk!” She beamed. Scorpia blinked.

“Tehk?”

“It’s a bit like whispering?” Hadra tried. “It’s for… delicate, sensitive things. Secrets.” She blushed a little. “We– used to use it a lot… to talk before bed.”

“What does this mean?” Scorpia struggled to tap the rhythm again, intentionally this time. Hadra cackled.

“Well, that meant ‘make me a sandwich’, but what you’re remembering, what you’re trying to say… is ‘I’ve got you.’” Hadra modeled it more slowly this time. Scorpia tried again. Hadra clapped.

“I can’t wait to tell Perfuma.” Scorpia felt like her heart would burst.

“Who’s Perfuma?” Hadra was eager. Scorpia squealed.

“That’s it. Family cottage here we come!”

Bonus Content:

A rough draft of what Hadra looks like. I'd like to find time eventually to render it properly and insert it into the chapter.



Best Laid Plans

Chapter Summary

Entrapta shares an exciting discovery with Hordak

Entrapta had been hard at work in Lab C, the lab designated for the Beast Island research. Hordak had been given permission by Glimmer to contribute in Lab B for the mid-range, small-scale teleportation project.

"Just don't mess with space-time." She had warned. Due to this, Hordak and Entrapta still made ready and frequent use of the comms system built into the exosuit.

"Come in, Gorgeous, do you copy?" Entrapta put on a voice. She chuckled as Hordak made a startled noise from the other end.

"Entrapta." His tone was reedy with embarrassment.

"This is big. Get your beautiful butt over here."

"Quit referring to my butt on the comms." Hordak shoved off from his work station, muttering. "Emily will hear you."

"She loves it." Entrapta teased. There was hysterical chirping in the background. Hordak hustled down the corridor. He no longer struggled to find his way around-– most of the time.

“Have you eaten?” He paused at the kitchen door.

"*Have you*?" Entrapta retorted. "Sophie’s already delivered. There’s plenty for both of us.”

“Roger that…” Hordak hesitated. “*...Wonder woman.* ” He whispered, pitching his voice low like she liked.

“Hordak! We are at work!” Entrapta feigned disapproval. He scoffed and rolled his eyes; coming up on Lab C. The door hissed open ahead of his approach. Entrapta launched herself at him. “Get in here!” She shoved him up to the widescreen. He began skimming the information. His eyes widened with shock.

“You unpacked the data from the Return crystal? *And* restored most of the corrupted data? Incredible.” Hordak breathed. Ever in awe of her. Lifted by her hair, she was smug. He kissed her cheek.

“This is actually old news if I’m being honest, but I had to iron out some theories first.” She looked off to the side; sheepish. Hordak leaned in closer to the screen. “Coordinates path sequencing… as expected… but–- that's not Eternia.” He thought of Adora with regret.

“Correct!” Entrapta dropped down to sit on the edge of her worktable. She leaned toward Hordak conspiratorially. “It’s

Despondos!” She threw her head back, cackling triumphantly. “We couldn’t be more lucky!” Hordak was taken aback.

“What purpose does it serve to access Despondos now? There’s nothing there… and nothing to run from.” He thought back to the initial portal event with a pang. “The consequences of phase shifting the planet would doubtlessly mean death to us all.” Anyone else would be frantic at Entrapta’s glee in the face of this news. None more than Adora… but Hordak had learned to trust this woman with his life. With everything. He waited for her to elucidate.

“Nothing, but *not no one.* ” Her grin was electric. “Sometimes it pays to be an Angelic being… statistically speaking.” She keyed up some biometrics values. “The chances are high. High *enough* .”

Hordak’s incredulity gave way to determination as he skimmed her data. She had been working on this for months.

“If we can harness just enough power for a more controlled portal…” He murmured, connecting the dots. Entrapta took this opportunity to navigate the screen to her revised hypothetical calculations.

“We can help Glimmer--” She launched herself forward at this, throwing her arms around Hordak. She buried her face in his neck. He clung tight to her. Her breathing grew shallow; half-laughing, half-crying. “ *I can fix it.* ” She mumbled into his neck with crushing finality. “We can take it back.”

He took the hand with which he was stroking her hair and guided her by the cheek to meet his gaze. “Brilliant.” He whispered with a slight head shake. “Where do we start?”

Entrapta giggled as Hordak wiped a tear from her eye. “Strap in, Beautiful. We have to run *so* many tests.”

“Time to make mistakes.” His response was firm and his smile was bright.

“Time to get messy.” Entrapta squealed.

A Kind of Spark

Chapter Summary

Bow calls a top secret meeting.

Chapter Notes

Note this chapter references "Legend of the Fire Princess (She-Ra Graphic Novel #1)"

Bow had called an unexpected meeting. Catra and Adora were running behind. They skated into the war room to find Entrapta and Bow already seated. Sheepish, Adora shuffled to her seat.

"Finally!" Entrapta waved them in while tapping away at her trackpad. A series of diagrams were displayed on the table projector. "So, I've been thinking…"

"...Never a good sign." Catra mumbled warily as she slouched, putting her hands behind her head, and kicked her feet up onto the table.

"Thanks to the data we have gathered from Beast Island about how Eternian tech interacts with Etheria's magic, I have been revisiting calculations from the Spirit Ember mission."

"But we trashed the Spirit Ember on that mission. What could we possibly learn now?" Adora asked.

“It's clear that Etheria’s magic is much more adaptive to Eternian tech than we first realized.” Entrapta’s eyes sparkled at Adora’s engagement. “We hypothesized that the Ember was manufactured, leading to its ultimate malfunction. I'm not questioning that. I'm proposing that the *why* is more important. It looks like the Spirit Ember was cultivated in response to a separate failed experiment.”

“... They may have destroyed a runestone. A real one.” Bow clarified.

“--One that they needed! Er–or thought that they did… for the Heart of Etheria Project.” Entrapta lay her trackpad down on the table.

“Up until now, we haven’t been able to figure out just how much of the Heart of the Etheria project was a manipulation of Etheria’s natural resources… and how much of it was an invasion of Eternian tech.” Bow contemplated. “This theory operates on the idea that the Spirit Ember was entirely artificial… and therefore that the runestones we know of, and their core magic, existed long before the Eternian’s got here.”

“Exactly!” Entrapta’s hair spiked outward. “If the stones, and how they interact with and gather magic is in fact a wholly organic process…”

“--Harnessing it isn’t the problem.” Adora finished. “It’s about how it’s done.” Entrapta tapped furiously. The holograms refreshed to reveal diagrams of the Black Garnet.

“The Black Garnet has been our ideal focal point of research regarding this line of hypothesis.” Entrapta barreled on. “Shadow Weaver’s manipulation of its magic played a role, but the Horde experiments to amplify it were in process for years--” As she followed along, Adora grew uneasy.

“Shouldn’t we be waiting for Glimmer? This all seems… really important.” She turned to Bow. He was stone faced. Micah wasn’t there either. Alarmed, it dawned on her. “Wait— aren't they supposed to be in Mystacore today?”

“Entrapta and I have a theory. We can’t let Glimmer know until we've tested it–- Micah can’t know either.” Bow was insistent.

“I really don’t like this.” Adora fretted.

“It’s been a while since I’ve seen a good old fashioned mutiny. I’m impressed, Bow.” Catra mocked. “But, seriously, dude, what’s the real deal here. You wouldn’t be hiding this from Sparkles on a regular day.”

Bow held his face in his hands and made an anxious noise. “We think… it *might* be possible-– key word being might--” He looked imploringly at Entrapta. She steamrolled on cue.

“Theoretically, a much more localized portal reaction could allow us to access Despondos without threat to Etheria as a whole!” She announced exuberantly.

Adora and Catra blinked.

“...Tiny laser shoot mini portal for small things.” Entrapta articulated slowly. “People. Not planets.”

“Why would we–” Catra sat up in bewilderment.

“...Angella…” Adora whispered softly.

"What the hell? Since when was Despondos even back on the table?!” Catra slammed a fist down.

"Whoops. Circling back--" Entrapta laughed awkwardly. "The 'Return' crystal as we've been calling it... that's what it's for." This hit Adora like a slap in the face.

"Oh." It was a flat, indignant noise.

"Sorry, Adora..." Bow was contrite. “But-- Now you see why Glimmer and Micah *cannot* know. At least not until we’re sure.”

“This sounds dangerous as hell.” Catra raised a hand. “Veteran portal activator chiming in here."

“But, that was when you *weren’t* listening to me.” Entrapta pressed. “This time you are.” She grinned at first, but faltered slightly. “You are, right?” Catra rolled her eyes.

What happened to blah blah blah, someone has to stay behind yadda yadda?” Catra countered.

"Because the portal isn't planet sized, we're not stuck with planet sized consequences. Theoretically." Entrapta hedged. "Remote control on and off of the portal will remain finite and accessible on Etheria." She pointed two thumbs to her chest with a grin.

"Oh, theoretically, everyone's favourite word." Catra spat.

“So, what are you really suggesting?” Adora cut in. “What is it we actually have to *do* to make it happen?”

“I’m so glad you asked.” Entrapta squealed. She skipped through the diagrams again to reveal a static image that Adora recognized. Entrapta made a point to magnify it.

“Is that… the runestone shard from George and Lance’s archive?” Adora recalled vaguely. "Man. I totally forgot about that!"

“Exactly!” Entrapta clapped. “If we can investigate its core, and re-establish its natural connection point…”

“It won’t be bonded to a princess.” Adora realized. “Accessing its magic won’t do anyone any harm.”

“But if it was this easy, why wouldn’t the Eternian’s have tried fixing the runestone instead of creating the Spirit Ember?” Catra wasn’t convinced.

“This is where things get interesting! We believe that damage to the runestones is caused by siphoning too much power. We aren’t attempting a world shifting galactic super death laser.” Entrapta cackled. “So it should be fine!”

“Should!?” Adora implored Bow with alarm.

“This experiment is finite.” Bow clarified. “The goal is to only draw a natural flow of power through the stone. If it isn’t enough, then it isn’t. Then we’re done.” He turned up his palms.

“You think the Eternian’s were doomed by their own greed.” Catra mulled this over. “They didn’t like that the first runestone experiment failed… that it couldn’t draw the power they wanted it

to. They tried to do nature one better.” She tapped her claws on the table. “That still doesn’t explain how we’re meant to fix the broken stone.” She gestured to the diagram. “What are we meant to do with a shard the size of a ration bar?”

“This is why you are looking into Candila again.” It finally clicked for Adora. “You think that it’s the origin point of the runestone that was damaged… that’s why it would have been chosen as the bonding point for the Spirit Ember.”

Bow nodded. “If our--*my*-– calculations are correct, it should be possible to seed regrowth of the runestone from the connection point. Like how continuous power is pulled by the princesses.” He scratched at the back of his neck. Entrapta’s hair wiggled, emphasizing flow. Catra narrowed her eyes.

“*Your calculations…?*” She was severely skeptical.

“Ouch!” He was affronted at first, but eventually sighed with defeat. “Ok. Ok...”

“You let HORDAK near the portal plans!?” Catra rose from her seat to slam her palms on the tabletop. “Are you *kidding* me?!”

“Hordak doesn’t have any personal use for the portal.” Entrapta scoffed, as if it couldn’t be easier to understand. “If it wasn’t for you, he wouldn’t have even activated it the first time. You were the one who-–”

“If you’re so sure—-” Catra hissed. “Then why were you trying to hide it?”

“Because I knew you guys were going to be super weird about it. Just like Bow was at first.” Entrapta flailed in his direction and rolled her eyes. “This is important. It won’t work without Hordak’s understanding of portal systems-- he's been working on mid-range teleportation with Glimmer for MONTHS.” She crossed her arms.

"That's different!" Catra shouted.

"Scientifically, IT ISN'T!" Entrapta wailed. She began counting off on her fingers. “Hordak was the one who made the connections in the first place. Bow asked for a plan. We made a plan. Now it’s time… *To use. The plan. ”* She articulated the final sentence with painstaking emphasis.

“Bow, will you please reign in your nerd?” Catra implored; exasperated.

“This is why I called you here.” Bow admitted. “I’m too close to this. If you guys really think it’s not worth doing… That’s it. We chuck the whole plan in the bin.”

“Too close to this!?” Adora snapped. “You don’t think I’m not? I’m the one who—-” She cut herself off and stared forlornly at her reflection in the tabletop. Catra laid a pacifying hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“I didn’t know Angella.” Catra admitted. “But if we’re casting blame, it’s mine.” She was firm. “My perspective is also the most objective.” She winced. “Or at least... I have a strong sense of when shit is about to hit the fan.” Bow shrugged. That had been pretty close to his line of thinking.

“First, we have to check on Candila, right?” She looked to Entrapta for confirmation. Entrapta nodded exuberantly. “If it’s healthy since the destruction of the Spirit Ember, then it’s runestone test time. Both of those ‘projects’ are in line with ‘cultivating the natural wonders of Etheria’” She offered air quotes. “Those you can tell Glimmer about. If those plans go well… then we reconvene about this… whole other ridiculous scheme.” She gestured dismissively. “One I will admit I really, *really* don’t like.” Even as she said it, looking at Bow and Adora’s goofy, hope-stricken faces, she knew they were going through with the experiment; even then. “Bow, selectively fill in your girlfriend. Keep Entrapta from spilling the beans. Adora, I guess it’s time to plan for a day trip.”

Wavelengths

Chapter Summary

Catra and Entrapta find common ground.

Catra had waved off Adora's immediate calls to action. She lingered in the war room as Entrapta scrubbed any trace of her findings from the Bright Moon computers-- just in case. She didn't seem to notice, or care, that Catra remained to watch her do it.

"I have to admit. I really didn't think you cared all that much about what happened." Catra said, almost to herself. Unsure if it even mattered that Entrapta heard her. "I was thinking it must have been Bow that asked for your help… but he couldn't have asked if you weren't looking for something to find. So. Why?" She wasn't trying to goad Entrapta, if anything, she trusted Entrapta to be immune when she came looking for a fight. What Entrapta would be, was unflinchingly honest whether that was what Catra had been looking for or not– and it usually was.

Did that count as friendship? Catra thought. It was never easy to tell with Entrapta. It's not as if the portal incident changed things between them exactly. Catra had spent so long thinking that… there wasn't anything between them at all. She had lied to Entrapta and used her. Entrapta existed around her anger. The more she thought about it, the less Catra was convinced. Entrapta often talked of friendship, but it almost seemed like she thought everyone was her friend… whether it was earned or not? *Did friendship have to be earned?* Catra knew she was brooding. But that's what happened when people left her hanging. After all, Entrapta still hadn't answered her.

Catra did her best to fight the immediate assumption: that she had been ignored. She considered asking the question again, but it turned out that she wouldn't have to.

"I didn't know what parents were." Entrapta didn't let this train of thought disrupt her work at the computer. "I had people who kept me alive… I thought that was close to the same thing at first." She could have been talking to herself. She still hadn't even looked at Catra. "When I realized it wasn't… and turned my attention to tech--"

"I know that most people don't see bots the way I do." Her hair had begun to pack up her tech to take back to Dryl. "Before the Princess Alliance, it wasn't just that they were all I had. They were all I knew how to have. I understood them and they understood me because… I was there for them from the beginning." Catra didn't like where she was going with this. She wasn't going to sit through a monologue about the wonders of bot-motherhood.

"So, I thought, eureka! That's how people bond. I didn't get to them early enough. There wouldn't be any point." Entrapta continued. Catra could relate to this. She didn't want to, though. "But, then I met Bow."

"Bow was interested. Bow had questions. Bow waited until I finished a sentence before leaving the room." Catra bit back a laugh. It wasn't the time. Entrapta powered down the computer system; done for the moment, but not done talking.

"I learned that there were at least two different ways for this thing…" She knitted her fingers together "To happen." She turned up her palms. Catra's stomach bottomed out. Adrenaline hiked up her back.

She thought back to how, at first, without Adora, she didn't know who she was–- thinking instead, that what she was, was nothing. How she didn't know that other people were *allowed* to matter when Adora mattered so much.

"Then there were more… and they got… more difficult. It wasn't always feeling like all of the pieces fit… But everyone else's pieces fit." Finally, Entrapta looked up. The shock of it doused Catra. "It had to be me."

"Instead I did whatever I wanted. Because I didn't know how to do what other people wanted." She looked down again. "I understand why that was wrong, now." The pull of this moment was magnetic to Catra. How could they have felt so similarly all this time… and not know?

"So not only could relationships form under a ton of different circumstances… but that the circumstances *made* them different. There weren't problems in some relationships and not others because I wasn't doing it right… it was because they were just different." Entrapta rose from her seat.

"Nothing can replace a relationship. Glimmer only has one mom in the same way I don't have one. The way that you don't have one." *Blunt as ever.* Catra couldn't believe a sentence like that

could make her smile. “But Angella is immortal.” Entrapta threw up her hands. “Nothing is stopping us, scientifically.”

There it was. Catra thought. The Entrapta of it. They weren’t perfect mirrors. But she would admit that Entrapta wasn’t wrong… and that they were more alike than she had allowed herself to realize.

“That makes sense.” She offered. Entrapta blinked.

“To *you?”* Her incredulity was so easy to read as condescension, but now, Catra felt like certain things were finally coming together.

“Yeah.” Catra affirmed. Entrapta cackled.

“Oh good. I’m going to mark it down as a success then.” She reached for her trackpad.

“What?” Catra laughed; out of processing power for the day.

“Hordak made me realize recently that I experiment less with people than machines.” Entrapta faltered. “Emotionally, I mean?” It still didn’t sound great but Catra got the gist. “I can’t give up when things don’t work. I have to practice. This was great practice, Catra.” She beamed.

“It might have been good practice for me too.” Catra confessed with a shrug.

New Horizons

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra reminisce in Candila. Scorpia finally gets her picnic.

Chapter Notes

> Juggling school and work is a pain in the butt, y'all. But we shall perservere!

Candila’s return to form was more than they could have imagined. Rolling fields of orange grasses sprawled into the horizon. Insistent vines crept hungrily up every tree. The ruins had been devoured. Catra whistled softly.

“I guess sometimes us blowing shit up was a good thing?” She nudged at Adora, somewhat abashed, as she stuffed her hands into the pockets of her jacket.

“Sometimes.” Adora nudged her back. This delicate moment was shattered by Scorpia. She swept them up into a crushing embrace.

“Finally. I said we’d do it, Wildcat. Today’s the freakin’ day!” She gushed.

Perfuma cheered. Carrying the food in a basket, she held her pace to match Hadra’s. She was taking it slow with her cane on the uneven ground and making note of the unfamiliar plants.

Perfuma’s heart could nearly burst from it all. Not only was Hadra pleasant and earnest about helping Scorpia connect with her roots… but she was a fellow healer! and a plant lover to boot. “We couldn’t be luckier.” She smiled to herself.

Scorpia dropped Adora and Catra and ran back to her guests to talk picnic spots. Adora looped her arm through Catra’s.

“It was real sweet of you to invite them, y’know.” She murmured.

“I owed it to Scorpia. Kind of.” Catra shrugged, though Adora’s praise warmed her.

“We should really do this more often, though.” Adora mused.

“Covert intelligence missions disguised as day trips?” Catra laughed. “...Goofing off while we should be working?” Adora laughed with her.

“We should just do more fun trips-- Especially ones with plenty of snacks.”

“Adora taking a vacation. A likely story.” Catra’s teasing was low. In the spur of the moment, she kissed Adora’s cheek. Adora’s heart fluttered as she pulled out their list of tasks as written by Bow.



"Dork." Catra rolled her eyes.

"Let him have his fun!" Adora laughed. "Well… Etherian magic… check." Adora scanned the horizon. It was easy for her to sense that subtle thrum of life in the air.

"But, despite the grass… I'm not getting a real fiery vibe. How about you?" Catra kicked a rock.

“Maybe the original runestone wasn’t fire based? Could have been the Eternians messing with things they shouldn’t– *again* .” Adora sighed, stuffing the checklist back in her bag. “At least dirt is easy.”

“I guess we should try getting as close as we can…” Catra waved Adora on.

“We’ll be back in a bit!” Adora called back to the rest. Perfuma waved them off with a giggle. “They totally think we’re going to go makeout.” Adora muttered.

“Aren’t we?” Catra winked. Adora shoved her up the slope, blushing furiously.

“I don’t know what we’re looking for, but Entrapta gave me like… ten jars.” She offloaded some of the empty canisters to Catra. “So…” Adora crouched low and stuffed a clump of soil and grass into one.

“A study in dirt.” Catra mused.

“Entrapta said any changes should be noticeable. Etherian magic isn’t exactly subtle.” Adora gestured vaguely with one hand.

“Point taken.” As they neared the ruins, the sprawling vines overtook the blades of grass. It thinned out as they neared the wreckage. “Bad sign?” Catra scooped up another sample of dirt.

“...Maybe.” Adora couldn’t be sure. She mumbled under her breath as she wandered about. “Noticeable… noticeable…” Catra grabbed her shoulder from behind, forcing Adora to turn sharply. “Oh yeah. That’s noticeable.”

Catra pointed around the bend to a burst of flush foliage. It looked dewey at first, but with the sun cresting high, that was unlikely. Wary, Catra crept closer. The stark pearlescence became unmistakable.

“Of course.” Catra laughed as she dropped to the ground. “Of course it glitters.” She almost felt guilty as she carved deep beneath a patch to dig into the loam. The soil spilled between her fingers and into the awaiting vessel. “This feels kind of good.”

Adora knelt beside Catra to lay a flat palm against the earth. Her eyes fluttered shut as she took in a steady, deliberate breath. Liminal flashes of feeling and pulses of memory bloomed in her mind. Fleeting glimpses of which she struggled to understand. *A sharp shove. A broken promise. Fire and fear and shame. A limerent hunger. Betrayal.* It all mingled in Adora’s mind.

“...Adora?” Catra’s tone was hushed. She hadn’t moved in what felt like several minutes. It was subtle, but Catra noted the shimmer in her hair. Slowly, as if waking from a dream, Adora

turned her head to Catra. Her luminous gaze was distant. For the first time in a long time… Adora thought of Razz.

Startled, she blinked away the creeping edges of the She-Ra form and yanked her hand from the earth. Catra reached for it. “What’s wrong?”

“One thing is for sure… That’s some magic dirt.” She rose. Catra followed suit–still clutching her hand. “I can’t explain it.” Adora gently pried her fingers from Catra’s grasp to fold her arms against her chest. “She-Ra powers should make me better with words.” She grumbled. This made Catra laugh.

“When you’re eight feet tall and carrying me in your arms, I mean–- who needs words.” She fanned herself. It did the trick. It brought Adora all the way back from wherever that reverie had taken her.

“Hilarious.” Adora’s tone was flat, but she was fighting a grin. “A mission… is no time for flirting.” She could barely get the words out.

“Since when?” Catra wheezed. Adora cackled.

“Since I learned that, all of that was flirting!”

"Idiot!"

Regaining their composure was difficult, but they got there in the end. "...Light. We are terrible." Adora sighed as her gaze trailed over the distant valley. "But, I think you were right. I think things are going to be OK here." She finally faced Catra properly.

"There's a lot of pain." Adora kicked at the dirt. "I think that's the best way that I know how to say it."

"The dirt… hurts?" Catra raised one foot gingerly; deeply unsettled by this revelation.

"No-– it remembers?" Adora tried before shuddering. "Oh nope. That's worse."

"So much worse." Catra cringed. Adora shook her head.

"But, my point is that, it's like… It knows that it's over. It's like Candila was frozen in time and now it knows what the past is." Adora groaned as she raked her fingers through her hair. She wrestled her ponytail loose. "Nevermind. Magic stuff." Catra wondered if the She-Ra itch was still under Adora's skin.

"Honestly… I can relate?" Catra shrugged.

As Adora frowned with suspicion, Catra took the rare opportunity to thread her fingers through the loose strands of Adora's hair. "I'm serious." She thought back to her conversations with Glimmer and Entrapta over the past few months. "If you can commune with dirt; I can empathize with dirt." Adora smirked. *Hard to argue there.* She sighed and pressed her forehead to Catra's. They locked eyes and shared a sedate, measured blink.

Catra tipped her chin up and stole a kiss. It was tender and insistent upon itself. Adora folded into it easily. Their breath threaded with the light breeze as the world melted away. Catra's claws tugged at Adora's hair as her own fingertips played at the downy fur at Catra's temples and behind her ears. Adora's breath caught as Catra's lips trailed a sultry path down to her collarbone. She pulled Adora closer still, nuzzling at her neck.

"And you thought we wouldn't make-out. Amateur." Catra growled softly in her ear. Adora's laugh was breathy and girlish. She loved how much she hated it.

"Catra… always one step ahead." Thinking quickly, Adora allowed the magic of Etheria to flow through her once more. Catra pulled back in shock. Adora, now She-Ra, swept Catra up as she had previously, *regrettably* suggested. Adora revelled at the flush creeping up Catra's cheeks.

"Ahem." A dainty cough alerted them from behind. Adora whirled Catra around to face a hesitant, but smug Perfuma. "Lunch, anyone?"

With nowhere to run, Catra buried her face in Adora's chest. It shook with Adora's suppressed laughter. "We'll be right there!" Her tone was reedy.

"Okay~" Perfuma sang cheekily. "But next call will be Scorpia!"

Catra groaned at the thought. Adora's raucous laughter burst forth. "Don't drop me!" Catra squealed.

Pay Dirt

Chapter Summary

> Bow, Catra, and Entrapta meet with Bow's sister in the archive to seek answers. They get more than they bargained for.

"Tsurune! TSU RU NE!" Bow hollered. They were supposed to meet in the archive with Bow's sister, but he and Entrapta had been wandering in the stacks for a while now. "She always does this." Bow grumbled. Catra had flopped onto the couch to nap pretty much the minute they arrived.

"Geekery is your department." She yawned— *even firing off a finger gun like a jerk when she did it.* Adora had been whisked away by Lance and George for on-site translation in the ruins. *Why was no one taking this seriously?*

"It's like herding cats." Bow sighed.

"Watch it, Crop Top." Catra objected without opening her eyes. Bow groaned as he realized that Entrapta had also wandered off.

"Perfect!" He threw up his hands. It was then that Tsurune finally made her appearance.

"Sup, bruh!" She strolled, unhurried, in from the upper level. Bow glared as she made her way down the steps. With hair pulled up

casually in a silk headscarf, she sported a jauntily cropped t-shirt and sweats that sat low on her hips. Catra opened one eye. *This family and their damn midriffs.*

"Sup!?" He parroted back at her mockingly. "You're late. That's what sup!" He seethed. The pajamas really added insult to injury.

"Sorry, man. I was up all night reading the latest Mermystery." Mirth threaded through her rasping voice; still thick with sleep. Despite her relaxed stance, she towered over him.

"You agreed to help because of your minor in edaphology! Finding the seed point of this runestone shard is important!" Like Bow, Tsurune was fit, but the tone of her muscles was more lithe. It matched her languid demeanor and sat in stark contrast to Bow's current, near tantrum, levels of hysteria.

"Eda-what?" Catra chose magnanimously to defuse the tension with the art of distraction.

"SHE STUDIES DIRT, CATRA." Bow yelled. *Or not.* Catra thought. She rolled off of the couch and stretched.

"Keeping this secret from Sparkles is really eating away at you, huh?" She took a turn around Bow. He deflated before her eyes and nodded in lament. "You heard the man, dirt woman." She rested an elbow on Bow's shoulder. "Do the thing."

“You’ve got the soil samples?” Tsurune crossed her arms with a teasing smirk on her open, handsome face.

“ *Of course we have the soil samples.* ” Bow derided her question as he fished them out of his satchel. He presented a vial for each confirmed Runestone seed point, the ones from Candila, and one from Dryl as a control.

“Did you grab the runestone from the case?”

“No. Dad rearranged the sections again. Do you know where he’s put it, I–” Entrapta’s trademark fizzing giggle bubbled up from the depths of the archive. *Not a great sign* .

“She better not have activated another ancient defense.” Bow wailed.

“Or corrupted all the tech…” Catra mused.

“Not. Funny.” Bow’s tone was clipped. Entrapta skidded into the room balancing a glass encasement above her head secured by her hair. Tsurune barked a laugh.

“She seems fun.”

“Thanks!” Entrapta made no other introduction as she plonked the encased shard onto a nearby table and whipped out her dosimeter and trackpad. Tsurune set down the soil samples and yanked open a nearby drawer. As Tsurune carefully laid out necessary tools one by one, Catra suspected that his sister had prepared more diligently for this than she had allowed Bow to realize. Unaware, he sunk into the distressed cushions of the couch. Normally, he would be elbow to elbow with Entrapta, but the anxiety was clearly too much. Though he had stolen her spot, Catra decided to let him have this one.

The hair on the back of Catra’s neck stood up as Tsurune delicately extracted the shard from its case. The tension in the air was electric. Entrapta eagerly re-scanned the artifact. Her vivid expression belied valuable results. The easy flow that developed between them was strangely musical. Before long, they were comparing findings and contrasting Entrapta’s energy readings with Tsurune’s knowledge of the regional soil.

“Bullseye.” Something peaked Tsurune’s interest. Entrapta’s usual scientific abandon allowed her to also abandon her understanding of personal space. She lunged closer, gripping at Tsurune’s shoulders fervidly. Tsurune was too intrigued to be bothered. Catra reached to tap Bow on the shoulder. She hissed as static shock snapped at her fingertips.

“Fascinating…” Entrapta whispered. Bow perked up and closed the distance readily as her hair gestured for him to approach.

Tsurune had prepared and reviewed slides of each soil sample, and poured a second helping of each into an open petri dish. Entrapta carefully cradled the shard in one gloved hand. She presented it, like a sword striking down, to the first dish. Specks glittered in the soil. A dim, but rosy iridescence bloomed. The sample was surely reacting, however faintly. Bow turned to Tsurune for confirmation.

"That's the sample from the Heart Blossom." She relished in his confusion. "Keep watching." Entrapta's eyes sparkled as she migrated the shard to the next dish of pale sand. Cool, argent light just barely shimmered.

"The Pearl." Bow breathed. There was hope here. This shard was more than an empty artifact. One by one, the samples came to life… until one didn't. Bow's heart lurched– fearing the worst– but realized his error quickly.

"The control from Dryl. Of course." He laughed to himself a little.

"Nope." Tsurune corrected. "That's Candila." Her eyes danced as Entrapta swished the shard across the three Candila samples to no avail.

"That's not a *good* sign, Tsurune." Bow snapped.

"Good and bad being relative…" Entrapta pulled the shard back toward herself. "I suppose that's true, though not in a strictly

scientific sense.” Entrapta turned the artifact over between her gloved fingers. “But take a look at this.” She prodded the final sample with the shard. Catra shivered as the lights flickered overhead. Mineral fragments in the ashy soil flushed with lavender radiance. Crackling, they burst. Specks expanded to craggly blossoms of–

“Quartz?” Bow guessed.

“Kimberlite, actually.” Tsurune corrected plainly. “Which is pretty wild, but largely irrelevant. I won’t bore you with the lecture.”

“Well, shit.” Catra gawked from her perch on the arm of the couch, craning her neck to see. Entrapta laughed triumphantly.

“Perfect! There’s our plan.” She promptly tucked the shard back into its case and dusted off her hands. “Convenient, really. Hordak and I won’t have to commute.” She beamed at Bow.

“...Entrapta…” His tone pitched up with alarm. “Doesn’t this change things a little bit?”

“I don’t really see how.” She shrugged.

“This means you’re–” Flustered, he flailed to Catra desperately.

“What did you call them…?” She wracked her brain. “This means you’re an elemental princess.” Catra paled at the thought. It finally put into perspective what they were doing. The power they had been willingly considering to give… *to Hordak.* Entrapta crossed her arms in front of her like an X and made an abrupt and jarring noise.

“Wrong.” She waggled her gloved fingers. “Thanks to the scientific process. We haven’t made me anything.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “You’re joking.” Entrapta blinked. “You’re going to just ignore this?”

“What use do I have for magic? I make my own!” Entrapta cackled. She struggled to reign in her excitement as her friends were just… not matching her energy. *Could it be possible?* They had asked the question. Dutifully, as always, the science had whispered back that it could be *… if only they were willing to try* . Entrapta hoped so desperately that they would be willing to try.

“The exact thing we asked for is *in our hands* –” She picked up the artifact case pointedly. Her need for them to understand crested to a lightning like frustration. “I *can’t* walk away.” She implored. “There’s too much potential.” Bow and Catra were stone-faced. They needed more time… But Entrapta just couldn’t waste it.

“I’m going to leave you guys to…” A hair tendril twirled in their general direction. “Emily will signal when I’m back at the lab.” She

stuffed her gear in her pockets and began toward the door. “Oh, you–” She pointed to Tsurune.

“Me?” Tsurune pointed to her own chest.

“You’re welcome in Dryl anytime.” Entrapta beamed, bright and fast, like the click of a camera shutter. Tsurune nodded, dazed.

“Uh..huh. Sure.” She turned to Bow. His face was unreadable. Catra looked like she wanted to punch something. Entrapta slipped quietly out.

Catra wrestled violently with herself. Flares of fear and distrust and a need for everything to just slow down for just one minute crashed against each other, blowing her composure to bits. She was supposed to trust Entrapta. That’s why they were here. They had resolved to this– Agreed to this.

“I’m going to take a walk.” She bit back a torrent of less helpful things to say. “Tsurune, make sure this idiot eats something.” She threw up her hands and stomped off in the opposite direction.

“Come on, big guy.” Tsurune rose from her seat and clapped Bow on the shoulder. “Let’s get you a sandwich. It’s been a long day.”

Permission Granted

Chapter Summary

Hordak seeks guidance from Perfuma

Hordak sat irritably in the dim and empty chamber that he had yet to decorate. He stared down at the trackpad in his lap, tapping his fingers against the sides. He frowned at the blank screen. After a few more tense minutes, it blinked on.

"Thank you for your patience, Hordak; it's been a little hectic today!" Perfuma offered a slight wave and a breathy sort of laugh. He grimaced. She wondered rarely if it could be taken for a smile, but she struggled to ever be sure. "Are you still taking our appointments in that glorified broom closet?" She chided.

As his anxiety over the current project had grown, it had become necessary to inform Perfuma. He had been wary of the decision initially; certain that it was a secret that she would fail to keep. Yet, he had risked it.

Perfuma still wasn't sure as to why. She was sure, however, that he had not asked for approval. Though it would probably give the others pause for concern; Perfuma considered it progress, in this context, anyway.

"Where else am I meant to take them?" He was gruff. *No smiles today then.* Perfuma nodded sympathetically. "I understand the importance of privacy, Hordak, but… are you ever going to do anything with this room?" She fretted about the ease with which

Dryl offered Hordak permission to neglect himself. “Maybe a nice ficus? Entrapta gave it to you for a reason.” Ever the magic word to give him pause when he was being difficult. Hordak looked away guiltily.

“We have sustenance and shelter and our research.” he held up one palm. “What else is there?”

Perfuma hesitated for a moment to mull over whether Hordak was ready for this conversation. She decided he could be. “Hordak, I understand that you are both committed to one another–” As usual, he bristled at any acknowledgement of this, but he would have to bear it. “You arrived in Entrapta’s kingdom to live in her castle, use her kitchens and her labs… you moved directly into her room–”

“Is that not customary?” He barked. “You also share your life–with Scorpia.” Perfuma bookmarked her urge to squeal at his romantic acknowledgement at a later time. Though she had her criticisms… she was rooting for whatever this curiosity of theirs had become.

“I share a home with Scorpia that we have created together with intent.” She threaded her fingers together. “With lives that we have interwoven. Like a happy little basket.” Knitted fingers clasped down. “You went from living for your broth–”

“--serving Horde Prime.” He corrected. Perfuma winced at the mistake. For some clones, familial language had proved helpful in

their healing and assimilation journey. This was *not* the case for Hordak.

"I'm sorry. Yes. You went from serving Horde Prime… to… well–" She chuckled dryly. "To serving Entrapta . " Hordak motioned to object, but Perfuma raised her hands. "Hear me out." She held silent for a beat. Hordak took a forced, steadying breath. She smiled encouragingly. "When you first found the Return Crystal, what were you feeling?" Hordak considered for a moment which emotion word was most accurate.

"Grateful; that there was something to report to Entrapta." He decided. Perfuma nodded along.

"When you received permission from Bright Moon to help with the teleport prototypes– since Entrapta had pivoted to unpacking the crystal, how about then?"

Hordak frowned. "I believe the term is prideful."

"You were rightfully proud to be acknowledged for your efforts, Hordak. That is different from pridefulness." She worried how clarifying that nuance might be a challenge, considering everything Horde Prime put him through. Hordak made a face. *Perhaps she had been a smidge condescending.* He turned his head to the side. Shadow blocked out his expression. "Hordak–" Perfuma attempted; but, it was Hordak's turn to hold up his hand.

His shoulders had stiffened. Hordak's breathing became shallow and irregular. She sat back, willing patience, and waited. Eventually, he coughed sharply and brought his raised palm to rub at his face before slowly turning back to the screen.

"Thank you." His tone was flat and the admission was labored. He fought the cresting urge to avoid her gaze. Perfuma's heart lurched as his eyes glistened, but she knew she couldn't dare acknowledge it. She struggled to find a way forward as she beat her own feelings down. Never in all of their time together did she ever think he would let her–even partially– see him cry. In expected, avoidant fashion, he continued without waiting for her response.

"You have said that 'to live a life in service of others' is something that you 'take pride in.'" He spoke slowly, patching together the things that she had said in passing. She really hadn't thought he was listening to her when she talked like that. "I fail to understand the difference."

Perfuma's response was careful. "Tell me again why you called this appointment today, Hordak." She thought back to his urgent voice recording. Something had come up in their research. Something that he believed posed risk.

"We have determined the runestone origin point. Based on the observed patterns, we believe it will be powerful enough to test soon. It has seeded." *That was a shock* . "In Dryl."

Perfuma nearly knocked over her tea. "W-wait–" She tried to orient to this new information respectfully. "Entrapta…?"

"She says she has no intention of activating her connection to the runestone… This makes scientific sense for the purpose of this experiment– drawing power is safest when there is no one to bear its effects, however–" Hordak faltered.

Perfuma was a little ashamed of this quiet gratitude that resulted from Entrapta's indifference. It's not that Perfuma truly thought that it would be bad… *but was a little peace for all of them just too much to ask for?* She tried to snap back to the matter at hand. The question was: how did this affect Hordak?

"--But what about after." He forced the words out.

"After…" Perfuma nodded slowly; beginning to understand. "After the experiment there isn't anything stopping her from considering the choice to welcome magic." Hordak didn't respond to this other than to take in a long, shaky breath. "What do you think that would mean for her, Hordak?" Perfuma pressed. "What do you think that would mean for you?"

"Magic…" He struggled to voice these ideas aloud. "I don't understand it. I don't understand how she doesn't want it." This brought to mind Adora's struggles on the battlefield when she lost access to She-Ra. Perfuma could understand Hordak's confusion when she framed it for herself. *Who would she be without the Heart Blossom?*

“You think she isn’t telling the truth?” Perfuma tried. The shock that splashed across his face was indignant.

“No. Entrapta wouldn’t.” Hordak was resolute. Perfuma didn’t question his resolve for a second. “If the magic takes hold, however…”

“It wouldn’t be a choice to give it back. I see.” Not even She-Ra had been given that choice, ultimately. Magic was eternal. Perfuma prodded further. “What then?”

“Magic is easy. Magic is… warm.” He struggled to use these light, quiet words. His eyes were searching. *Everything I’m not.* It remained unspoken, but there it was. Perfuma frowned; furiously working to stitch together a defense against this brackish, ugly, feeling inside of him.

“I’m listening.” She affirmed, refusing to give the feeling more power by calling it out.

“I would be of no use.” It was a shuddering, urgent hiss.

“You are not a tool to be used, Hordak.” Perfuma protested sharply. He flinched. “What use were you to any of us when Entrapta looked for you?” It was a brutal question, but this was a war. “You were asked to work hard here to heal our home

because you had done harm; not as a condition for your existence." Perfuma continued. "Do you have any idea how hard Entrapta has been fighting for you?" She stifled her own brimming tears now as her mind whirred. "She challenged Horde Prime for your life; but she fought Glimmer for what your future could look like." This was news to Hordak, it dawned.

The revelation struck Perfuma light lightning. No one had ever tried to tell him; not properly. After all, even she still occasionally avoided 'unnecessary' shows of emotion– of earnestness, to Hordak. "You are not in Dryl because it is convenient. You are in Dryl because Entrapta *asked.* " Perfuma had followed the thread to its true conclusion. "I was unclear before." She apologized softly. "I didn't mean to say that Dryl is not your home. I meant to ask you why you didn't act like it was– because it is. If you want it to be."

Hordak's expression crumpled into one of stark disgust. His breathing hitched once more. Hot tears spilled forth as he struggled and gasped through this searing feeling. The screen flicked to black. Perfuma feared they had lost connection; but as a muffled, shuddering sob escaped, she realized that Hordak had merely obscured the camera. Silent tears streamed down Perfuma's stricken face as the telltale crackling of a smothered mic blended with what escaped of his anguish.

Her first impulse was to scrub her own tears away for fear of Hordak's reaction– but she wouldn't. Not this time. With Hordak's growth came fresh challenges. It meant that she had to change too. He still struggled to make sense of the things that he was feeling… but he no longer blamed her, or anyone else, for *making* him feel. He had finally granted himself permission.

“I’m here when you’re ready, Hordak.” Perfuma pledged this earnestly, with the sort of wealth of feeling she would offer any of her dear friends, as he fervently wept.

“Thank you.” Hordak coughed out through the sobs even as the storm raged on. Perfuma took a grounding breath. It would pass. It would break. She would be ready.

Witching Hour

Chapter Summary

Insomnia plagues Bright Moon

Adora pressed her cheek to the floor. It had been years, but in times of stress the downy comfort of Bright Moon still gnawed at her. Catra, however, had taken to it readily. She could truly sleep anywhere. She purred loudly from their shared bed a few feet away.

Adora launched herself up from the ground. It would be no use. She decided it was time for a walk.

The breeze whispered through the corridor as she padded softly down a familiar route. She was lured to an empty guest room. The balcony door stood ajar. Micah leaned over the railing in the moonlight.

“Sir.” Adora announced herself stiffly upon approach; she pitched her voice low and gruff with a salute. He returned the gesture with a laugh before tousling her hair. It was still loose from the usual ponytail in her attempt to sleep. This was a bit of a joke with them.

She slouched forward, crossed arms against the railing, and leaned her head against Micah’s arm. In the beginning, it had almost felt like a betrayal to Glimmer… this unexpected closeness; but with all that they had in common, it really hadn’t been something either one of them could afford to lose.

“The nightmares or the arm lightning?” She asked. They had developed their own sort of lexicon for the many ways in which sleep eluded them.

“Neither. Stomach.” He laughed a little. *Oh boy* , Adora could relate.

She nodded sympathetically with a wincing smirk. “That’s rough, buddy.” Micah popped his eyebrows up with a look that suggested ‘ *and you?* ’ Adora hedged with a shrug. She knew it wasn’t time yet to tell him. Though she yearned to, it would only be a few more days. Micah didn’t press.

That was probably the real beauty of the thing. There was so much peace in this. In the same way that Micah never made Angie’s loss about Adora; these early hour moments wouldn’t be compromised by this confidential project that the team had been working toward for so long.

“I have a secret.” Micah declared suddenly. Shock bolted through Adora. *He couldn’t know, could he?* With her shoulders set stiffly, she waited for more. “You have to swear–” His mirth felt boyish. This covert knowledge had to be unrelated. Adora held up a palm.

“I swear on… something important probably.” Adora joked. Micah narrowed his eyes with feigned scrutiny, but he couldn’t hold it in any longer.

“Bow is going to propose!”

“Light above us. You’re joking!” Adora was floored– and a little miffed. *Such secrets between the best friend’s squad!?* Micah shook his head fervently.

“I don’t know when. I don’t know how. But it’s going to happen and I am *dying.* ” Micah dragged at his cheeks with tense fingers.

“How weird does it feel in a dad way?” Adora asked.

“I mean it’s not as if I don’t approve– Bow is beautiful– and heck, he’s been around longer than I have!” Micah’s laugh was sardonic. “And she’s going to say yes.” His shoulders sagged slightly. “The idea of my little girl… and– without Angie I just–” As he spoke, they leaned in toward one another, into that cherished, awkward sort of side-hug. It wasn’t something to be spoken; merely felt.

“Congratulations.” Adora whispered. Her stomach knotted further as he chuckled. She knew the risks; what was at stake, but this was all the worse. They couldn’t afford to lose anyone else. It had to go perfectly– *and when had anything gone perfectly?*

That night, Micah and Adora continued to wrestle with their demons, alone together, until the sun peeked over the horizon.

The Best, Worst Plan

Chapter Summary

It's finally time to choose who will go and who will stay.

Entrapta and Hordak had opted out of the ultimate meeting. Entrapta knew that she couldn't resist arguing if the ultimate decision was a no. In the end, it was a family matter that came down to Bright Moon and Bright Moon alone.

Bow couldn't tear his attention away from Glimmer. Throughout the entire presentation, she had been stone silent. She looked off into the middle-distance now. Micah's expression was similarly wooden; unreadable.

"Please don't be angry, Glimmer." Bow pleaded. "I couldn't tell you… not before we were sure." He clutched at her shoulder earnestly. "But we *are.* " He breathed, "We're sure."

Glimmer blinked rapidly; startled and reticent, she looked about the room. Adora looked seasick; Catra looked like she was going to jump out of her skin. Glimmer settled on Micah to seek commiseration in her disbelief.

"Angie…" He choked out a harried whisper. Glimmer, shakily, tried to muster her queen voice.

“What danger does it pose?” Her heart wasn’t in it. Desperation clung to the edges.

“It’s only dangerous to those who go in.” Catra’s declaration clapped back at their fragile shock. “Leave it to us.” She squeezed at Adora’s shoulder. “I go where she goes and She-Ra goes where the crazy, dumb plans go.” Glimmer shook her head furiously; still feeling steps behind. Frustration surged; she had to beat it back.

“No. No. That’s not– Dad?” She shoved off from Bow, but snatched at his shirt in the same moment. Then reached for Micah. “Shut up. *Everyone shut up.* Just– give us a minute.” The three of them disappeared in a shimmering shower of starlight. Adora slumped forward and mumbled against the table.

“Well that went greaaat.” Her stomach curdled.

–

“I am NOT sending Adora back in there just to undo everything Mom did!” Glimmer was shrill. “If anything goes wrong, we lose Adora, and what Mom did was for *nothing* .” She flung out her arms. “Absolutely not. *No way* . ”

“I should go.” Micah’s tone was flat and resolute. Glimmer groaned.

“NO! Don’t any of you get it? None of us *should* go!” She beckoned to the side aggressively. Bow was staring at his shoes.

“But, you want to.” His response was grave.

“Of course I want to!” Glimmer wailed. “But I can’t. I’m queen. You can’t because you’re you–” She stabbed a pointed finger sharply toward Micah. “I won’t *let* you.” She turned her attention vehemently toward Bow. “And neither can you! Don’t even think about it.”

“You don’t let me do anything, young lady.” Micah challenged sternly . Glimmer bristled at the implication.

“That’s the funny thing about being queen, Dad. Actually? Actually I do.” She crossed her arms, seething. Bow held up his hands.

“Guys, Glimmer, just slow down.” He took a deep breath. He had spent months truly considering this. It was time to pitch what he knew in his heart to be the best, worst plan. “You *have* to go. Both of you.” Micah and Glimmer looked to him with fresh shock, but he pushed on, ignoring their frustrated reactions. “It’s both of you or neither of you, and you’re not going alone.”

“So we just ship all three of us off– the whole de facto royal family, the entire leading delegation of Bright Moon and chuck them into uncertain doom? Jeez, Bow, it’s a good thing I have the final word here.” Glimmer condescended.

“No. Not me.” He pointed to Micah. “Just you.” Glimmer. “You.” and out the door. “Catra. Adora.” He crossed his arms. “Any less, and resentment will eat us all alive unless the plan goes perfectly. Bright Moon can’t afford that.”

“But, it can afford this?” Glimmer wasn’t wrong. It was still a wild and risky plan because there was no tame or safe one to be had.

“Maybe not, but you’re more than Queen, Glimmer.” It was Bow’s turn to be angry. “Sometimes you get to be Glimmer. *Commander* Glimmer, daughter of Angella.” His tone grew chiding. “We’re not under threat. We’re not under siege.”

“For once!” Glimmer spat back.

“Exactly. Bright Moon can bear it. I can bear it– Because I know it’s what you need to do.” Silence descended on the room. Micah was clearly fuming, but with a twisting undercurrent of hungry hope. Glimmer wrestled with everything Bow had been right about… which was truthfully, actually everything.

He waited; with muscles taut and jaw clenched. He wouldn’t let it go; wouldn’t let them down like that. Slowly, the crackling tension bled away. Micah and Glimmer looked hopefully to one another. Their shoulders sagged; tired of fighting it. Bow knew that he had won.

“I guess that makes you…” Glimmer gestured toward him loosely. “King Regent?” Bow blanched at the thought. It was worse now that it was real. Micah stepped forward and placed a hand on Bow’s shoulder.

“I trust that Bright Moon is safe with you no matter what happens.” Bow swelled with pride. Glimmer’s expression was still mixed.

“Is it really OK?” She whispered softly, looking up to Bow with pleading eyes. Bow didn’t trust himself to speak. He nodded firmly instead. Glimmer threw herself into his arms. He breathed her in and stroked her hair. Micah looked pointedly away. They broke apart.

“OK.” Glimmer held out a hand.

“OK.” Bow placed his on top.

“OK.” Micah followed last. “Time to get this show on the road.”

Unto the Breach

Chapter Summary

> It's finally time. The team faces off against their fears and the gaping maw of Despondos

Down the hall from Lab C there was a room that had been prepared. Adora wasn't sure by whom. It wasn't quite Entrapta's style. There was science gack all over one wall. No room in Dryl could be safe from that, of course, but the center of the room was occupied by chairs surrounding a long rectangular table. It was here that she sat; this quiet, contemplative place. *Was that a ficus?*

It felt familiar in ways she didn't understand, but it didn't make Adora itch the way Bright Moon sometimes did. On a night like tonight, she was grateful to have it. The low lavender light swelled as a hermetic entrance opened to her left. She turned her head to see Hordak standing in the doorway.

"Is it time?" She answered brightly; in hope that it would mask her fear. Hordak shook his head.

"No." He… *winced?* "I wish to speak with you for a moment." He inched clumsily to a chair not quite nearby her, made as if to sit, but at the last minute moved closer. She studied him curiously.

"About the mission?" Though she was no longer distrustful of Hordak, that didn't mean she was comfortable with him. To sit like he had invited her over for tea– nope. Not quite there yet.

“I wish to thank you.” Hordak attempted with a small cough. “Properly.” Adora blinked.

“On the day… of the Heart–” He tried again. “You do not realize, I think, what you did for me. Because what you did wasn’t done for me at all.” Hordak rested his hands on the table before them. “I have been thinking of something I once said to you.” Hordak paused. “I once said that I could not have lied to you because I had never cared– that you were… inconsequential.” Adora bristled. She crossed her arms expectantly. Hordak clenched his eyes shut briefly; willing himself to focus.

“In contrast, in a moment of great consequence to me…” He blinked away the foggy fragments of what remained of Horde Prime’s memories. “You– saved me. Quite by accident.”

He wasn’t wrong. In moments like that, the lifeblood of Etheria coursed through her: this conduit to She-Ra’s legacy. She could admit that her actions weren’t always wholly her own. Sometimes they felt a little like a dream. She didn’t set out to banish Horde Prime from Hordak’s mind. She only knew that she needed to heal Etheria with everything she had.

“Horde Prime was a sickness.” She affirmed. “You’re right… I– wasn’t thinking about you, *Hordak,* at all when I did it.” She relaxed her shoulders a little. Hordak nodded to himself; bolstered somewhat.

"Considering this gives me perspective." He wrung at his clasped hands. "I have performed many acts with sole intent which ultimately generated a magnitude of consequence that I still do not fully understand." He thought again to the myriad of empty rooms here in Dryl– and of the scribbled machinations of a small, lonely Entrapta that haunted so many of its walls.

"I thank you for your intent… to protect Etheria from Horde Prime– and from me." Another measured breath. "... and for your choices that ultimately brought me here." He looked around the room with quiet astonishment as if he was seeing it for the first time. "In response, I hope that you can come to understand both my intent and my choices tonight." Adora fought a nervous chuckle. *This was a lot.*

In all of this time, neither Entrapta or Hordak had found the right words to evoke their contrition for the portal event. As the full weight of it bore down on them now, Hordak felt it was his duty to try. "I started on this mission for Entrapta." half-laugh; half-sigh. "She is no longer my only consideration. My intent is to do my best– for all of us."

Adora's stomach twisted at his use of the word *us* . She thought of Angella's regret; of Shadowweaver's neglect, manipulation, and ultimate sacrifice. She thought of a rolling green meadow and a soft spring breeze. She nodded mechanically; her body catching slowly up to her brain.

"Your best is enough, Hordak." She finally said. "That's all any of us can do."

–

"As long as a wormhole has a greater mass than any black hole it encounters, it should remain stable." Entrapta gestured toward the primary display where the diagram floated ominously. "This time, we aren't relying on the creation of a wormhole. We are relying on a smaller, stabilized black hole." She tapped furiously at the keypad to reorient the diagrams.

As Entrapta hurled science at them, Adora was keenly aware of the Bow-Shaped-Space in the room. She snuck a glance at Glimmer: she was clutching fiercely at Micah's hand. "Our black hole is like a trapdoor. You pop in, snag Angella, and run. *Fast* . As long as we're on this side of the line keeping the black hole stable, the wormhole shouldn't collapse while you're looking. Probably." Entrapta clapped her hands together. Adora rubbed at her cheeks in irritation. *This was why she hated science.*

"But once you extract her from the fractal she is entombed within, you disrupt the mass and it will begin to destabilize. You will have only minutes." Hordak insisted.

Catra stared down the barrel of the portal machine; thinking of her past, her failures, and Melog– currently sleeping peacefully with Kyle in Obsidian. They were both under the impression that Catra would be back in just a couple of days. She had to hope that, that hadn't been a lie. "What can we expect when it destabilizes?" She growled anxiously.

“Similar anomalous experiences to the original portal.” Hordak answered. “Distortion of your sense of time, your memory, and your interpretation of reality.”

“And we’re sure there’s no way to prepare for that before it happens?” Glimmer knew the answer, but prayed it had changed.

“Nope!” Entrapta’s nervous laughter set them all on edge.

“During the original portal event, I seemed more aware of it in the beginning…” Adora mused. “If we really focus going in, maybe it helps us hold on?” Catra nodded, she gripped one arm tightly with claws pinching at her skin.

“I think passing through deliberately is going to give us the edge.” She fought through the flare of guilt and shame. “It seemed to make a difference with me.” Micah looked off into the middle distance with a crease forming in his brow. Adora wondered if it called to his memory the fugue-like experience on Beast Island.

“The destabilization does offer one thing in your favor.” Hordak hedged. “Your freedom of movement increases. Distance from the exit black hole will fail to matter.”

“Like how we plunged straight from Bright Moon to Dryl.” Adora considered; thinking back. “What happens if we pass through

either end of the wormhole by accident?" Hordak and Entrapta merely grimaced.

"OK! Scratch that question." Glimmer gulped.

"No matter what happens– Etheria will not be compromised." Hordak vowed. Glimmer looked down; thinking of Bow. Micah gave her hand a reassuring squeeze.

"Together or not at all." He affirmed.

"Together or not at all." The crew declared together.

"You'll want to leave as much as possible behind." Hordak stressed. "For everything that goes in, it's more matter and mass to bend and distort and destabilize."

"No weapons. No trackpads. Honestly, it might just be best for everyone to go naked." Entrapta shrugged.

"Per our calculations, we don't believe that to be *strictly* necessary." Hordak chimed back in again.

"I'm just saying." Entrapta muttered before turning back to the control panel.

“Last time, I couldn’t transform because the sword was the key. Now that the sword is just…” Adora paused and motioned vaguely with her hands. “… is it safe?”

Entrapta swiveled back to face them. “We ran tests for each possible variable for portal entry including Adora and She-Ra separately.” She cued up the results. A perky She-Ra doodle slashed her sword down before offering a thumbs up. Entrapta drew her legs up and rocked back in her chair. “Magic holds no mass. Go nuts!” A chipper ping signaled as the Entrapta seal of approval blinked on the screen.

“Is that everything? Are we good to go?” Entrapta’s drive to begin the experiment steamrolled her sense of social tact. Glimmer took a deep breath. She looked to her companions expectantly.

With a whoosh, Adora welcomed the sense of safety that swelled whenever she tapped into She-Ra. She felt strong. She felt safe. *They were going to do this. They were going to get it right.* Catra gave Hordak a thumbs up. He rose to the panel. With a final nod of confirmation, he yanked at a weighty lever.

With a *cathunk,* an immense sense of pressure bore down on the room. The reverberation of the expounding energy swelled and snapped back like an elastic band. Adora’s ears popped as a pulse of blinding light blossomed from the containment arch. Catra raised an arm to blot it out. Wind whipped through Micah’s hair.

“Get a move on!” Entrapta yelled over the din. It shook them loose from their sense of shock. Arms locked together, partners and family all in step, they plunged into the gleaming vortex. Hordak shifted his whole weight into wrenching the lever into its next position. The portal shrank and the feedback watered down. Hordak slowly lifted his grip from the lever as he and Entrapta stared into the eye of this fragile pulsing quasar.

She let out a long held breath. “I sure hope this works.”

A Watched Pot

Chapter Summary

> A long, restless night sprawls out before Bow, Hordak, and Perfuma.

Bow wandered the halls of Bright Moon like a listless specter. It had been bustling throughout the day, overrun by this impromptu family reunion. But eventually, even George retired to bed. Knowing what Bow would be battling, he did his best to convince him to follow, but Bow knew that sleep was asking too much.

Surprisingly, he didn't find his thoughts sticking on where they were now; what they were doing; if they were safe. Instead, his thoughts whispered of the futures he had warmly imagined to tide him over through the Horde War. He hadn't done this in quite some time. Bow envisioned a stoic, queenly Frosta in the kingdom of snows... Raucous parties sparked to life in his head hosted by Perfuma and Scorpia. These futures felt the safest to explore right now.

Before long, he had wandered down the hall toward the throne room. He looked up at the classic mural dedicated to Angella and Micah with weighted reverence. There was a fresh portrait to follow it now. The mature figure of Glimmer's noble effigy sent a sharp pang through his chest. This clumsy, humorous girl he had called a friend had evolved before his eyes into a sparkling powerhouse of a woman.

"I love you so freaking much." he choked. "If you don't come back, I'm going to kill you."

–

" *Entrapta* ." Hordak's baritone burned with urgency. It was not the first time he had attempted to lure her away from the beguiling glow of the monitors. He prayed upon her weakness for his vocal register, but it had been of no use so far. "We've done all that can be done." He brushed the back of one hand down the line of her jaw; delicately coaxing her to look at him instead. Though her head turned readily, she struggled to tear her gaze away from the screens. "We can only wait for when we are needed." His rasp tugged at her weary heart. "If we mean to be ready, you must rest." Finally, her critical expression fixed stubbornly on his face. *This had to be penance for his recalcitrant treatment of Perfuma.* He thought with a watery, but relieved smile. This warmth seemed to draw her in. Her hair relaxed and she slowly lowered herself to the floor.

"Alright." Entrapta clutched at his arm. "But I'm not leaving this room." She leaned heavily into him. Though she was always affectionate, it was a rare and hard won thing for her to lean on him like this. In an act of fond impulsivity, he bent, sweeping her into his arms. The weight of her fatigue blanketed them both. They clung to each other hungrily. He would be hard pressed to put her down if his constitution didn't demand it. Hordak longed to support her in every possible way, but he had to be mindful of his limitations without the exosuit which he had tucked away some hours ago.

He sunk gratefully into the nearby chair. With his armor cast aside and their intimacy made whole, Hordak drew Entrapta into him tighter still. As Hordak's nerves sparked alight with every

connection, he could think of no other possible way to survive this.

To think how barren, wasted, and biting his world had once been. Hordak pressed his lips firmly to the top of Entrapta's head. As she slipped into unconsciousness, her grip fell slack from his neck. Careful not to disturb her, he wheeled closer; eyes anxiously scanning the monitors.

–

Perfuma was roused by the soft chime of her trackpad. She crawled out from bed with a groan. She tapped at it impatiently to stop the noise. A wide view of an exhausted Hordak appeared on the screen. Entrapta was curled in his lap. Perfuma gaped at the sight of his bare arms. It was just jarring enough to rouse her fully.

"Hordak–?"

"It's tonight– it's happening." His expression was haggard and just slightly apologetic. She barely bit back her irritation for not being told sooner.

"Who made the call?" Perfuma pinched at the bridge of her nose.

"Glimmer, Bow, Adora, and Catra." Hordak admitted.

Such an impulsive combination. "And Micah?"

"He was present for the discussion also."

"Who– When?" Perfuma struggled to keep her questions straight.

"Glimmer, Micah, Catra, Adora." He sighed. "It's been hours. Six, I think? We have been working for much longer."

"Heart Blossom send me." Perfuma murmured. "Who is looking after Bow?"

"He is in Bright Moon—Just in case. I understand his family is with him."

At least there was that. Perfuma let out a breath she didn't realize she was holding. She looked forlornly at the bundled lump still in bed. Scorpia dozed obliviously. It had been complete agony these few weeks not to tell her. Perfuma turned her attention back to the trackpad as she pushed herself up from the floor.

"What do you need from me, Hordak?" She probed gently. A stricken look splashed across his face.

“I– I don’t know.” He drew his arms more tightly around Entrapta. She burrowed close instinctively. Perfuma considered what would follow in the morning.

“I can stay with you for a while. If you like.” She wrapped a shawl around her shoulders and stepped tentatively out of the yurt. Her gaze was drawn to the twilight sky. “Is tonight the night we meditate?” She tested the waters for joking.

“No.” Hordak barked a gruff laugh. Perfuma made a soft, smug sort of sound as she padded softly up the hill; barefoot in the dewey grass.

“I’ll get you one day.”

“I would rather take second siege of Obsidian.” He rebuffed.

“Oh– oh no.” Perfuma would *not* laugh. “Way too soon, mister!” She chided as she reached the crest of the hill.

“Forgive me, Perfuma.” His tone lingered, but the subject of its derision changed. “I’m sorry.” He growled. She waved it away. Hordak didn’t apologize lightly.

“I could get you in terrible trouble.” She mimed locking up her mouth with a key. “But, you’re lucky.”

“Very.” Hordak offered with a gravelly chuckle. Perfuma sunk down and nestled her back against her favourite tree. Intent to watch the second moonrise in solidarity. She yawned daintily just as a cacophonous series of sounds erupted from the trackpad. The feed cut. *Of course Hordak wouldn’t waste precious seconds on a goodbye.* As Perfuma’s heart rattled in her chest, she clutched at the trackpad like a life raft. A rosy glow was just beginning to breach the horizon.

No Time Like the Present

Chapter Summary

> The fragile temporality of the Despondos wormhole tests everyone's sanity and bestows shocking gifts.

Chapter Notes

> and it is today that I learn I have been spelling Mystacor wrong for 39k words. So, y'know, that's fun lol

They were engulfed in vacuous silence. Catra felt Adora's presence slip away. Reaching out to meet empty air, she pitched forward. Stumbling, she opened her eyes to the Fright Zone. It creaked and groaned with the sickly wind of her memory. Faceless laughter echoed down the corridor. Less than impressed, she followed it dutifully.

"Bring on the bullshit!" Catra called out. This false bravado, once a beloved blanket, now just an ill-fitting shirt. Still, she slipped seamlessly into the haughty, languid stance that she had taunted Adora with for years. She received no answer as she trailed the claws of one hand along the wall. It was silence, always the silence, that compelled her to keep talking to fill it. "I'm happy now, you know." She turned a corner sharply. *Nothing.*

"Who will it be? Shadow Weaver?" She barked a bitter laugh as she passed the empty prison cell, the Black Garnet, The barracks, Hordak's sanctum… everywhere she expected to be tested. Time and again she was met with nothing but stony silence.

Moment by moment, the rhythmic sound of her own footfalls chipped away at her polished and illusory composure. Finally, Catra had enough. She flounced to the floor in a display of grand petulance. Obstinate, she crossed her arms and legs and called out to the nothing.

“That’s it. You’re coming to me!” She held her breath in the waiting, but even a paragon of vigilance had to blink sometime. She opened her shuttered eyes to a dense jungle she didn’t recognize; crying out in surprise as she jumped to her feet.

“Crap.” She muttered. Fresh curiosity emboldened her to venture into the brush. It was wilder than the Whispering Wood. *Could it be Beast Island?* Catra had never been. But this place felt old in the same way that it felt new. She observed a solemn serenity as she clawed the tangles of vines out of her path. She pushed determinedly through the thicket–- chasing the sound of running water. As she came upon a trickling brook, she was struck again by the emptiness. Was it possible this in-between place had no interest in ghosts? But then, *who’s laughter was that?*

—

Emptiness . Micah’s fragile awareness drew toward a dank, cold dread that sunk deep into his bones. His nerves set aflame with panic. Otherwise senseless, he couldn’t tell which way was up; only that he was alone.

This void, neither dark nor light, picked at his sense of self. He couldn’t fathom where it ended and he began. His sense of time curdled. *Why had he come? Where was he going?* He struggled to remember anything beyond this greedy despondency.

It clawed hungrily upward, licking at his fear and devouring his will. It harkened to a memory; a hazy approximation of his years in exile. As his fear flared white hot; he recognized it for the life raft that it was. Fear meant something left to fight for.

Micah compelled himself to remember… and so he did remember– that he had not come alone. With fresh resolve, he shook this sickness from his bones. The nothing slunk back, revealing a darkness– a known darkness with a faint summer breeze.

Wherever he was, it was night. Night was something. He struggled to his feet.

"Together or not at all." Micah breathed. He would push on; blind, with only the faintest flickering flame of hope to guide him: *He needed to find Glimmer* .

—

*"We **need** to act."*

"And then what?"

Tears sprung forth as memory splintered and rained.

"You'll always be around, telling me what I can't do."

In half a lifetime and an instant, Glimmer bore down against these waves of swirling colour and pain that crashed over her.

"You have no plan!"

"We have to do something!"

Her mother's voice and her own roared in her ears.

"I won't lose anyone else–"

Glimmer pawed at her damp cheeks.

"...Take care of each other."

This tender whisper reverberated in Glimmer's chest. Fond words not in memory, Angella's call rung out like a clarion. Glimmer blinked back her guilt and diffidence. Prismatic light melted away to Bright Moon at dusk… *but it was not Bright Moon.*

Corridors bled into each other; Glimmer ran and ran, calling out for her mother as she went, quickly discovering that she could not teleport in this false friend of a kingdom. Empty room after empty room, the castle seemed to shift. Things were not where they were meant to be: missing doors and hallways, and rooms out of place. It spoke to Angella's struggle. Her mother was fighting. Glimmer pressed on.

As she advanced, Glimmer started to look more intentionally. She had to hope she could find clues in the distortions. As she bounded in search of her childhood bedroom, it became apparent that they weren't distortions after all. She crossed the threshold to find not her blushing, lively, bed and stuffed animals, but instead a series of elegant, opalescent furniture. Glimmer gasped softly. It reminded her of… *of course.* This Bright Moon wasn't broken. It was old.

She sifted through her memory for any hint toward the life that Angella had lived beyond her. Only one place came to mind. Empty room after empty room finally lead her to the edge of the garden.

A young couple stood fraught in the twilight. They whispered fervently. A distinct argument. The svelte young woman in the shimmering nightgown with tumbling iridescent curls leaned down toward a stocky young man with dark hair and kind eyes; a sorcerer by all accounts of his attire. Glimmer's stomach bottomed out.

"I said no, Micah." Her mother whispered sharply. "I will not tell you again. Leave. Me. *Alone.* "

In her distress, Angella leaned in to all of her most unbecoming attributes. She was distant, opaque, and punishing. Glimmer felt

the pain in her father’s eyes as he considered leaving his partner to her enigmatic suffering; but, he would have been a poor model of her father if he had.

Micah raised his hands in mock surrender. “Angie, please. You haven’t even told me what I’ve ruined.” His tenderness reminded Glimmer of Bow. Micah's forced chuckle didn’t reach his eyes. “Whatever it is, you know the only thing I could possibly want… is for us to face it together.” He set his stance more firmly, but Angella merely turned away. Glimmer wrestled with a torrent of emotional confusion. In this moment, Angella was no one’s mother. She was barely any older than Glimmer herself.

Micah’s tentative fingers tugged lightly at Angella's elbow. Her arms clung to her stomach; a clear attempt to hold all of her pieces in place. Begrudgingly, she allowed him to take her hand. As Angella turned back to look at him, she froze; locking eyes with Glimmer. Shock and something wretched splashed across her mother’s youthful face.

But she wasn’t looking at Glimmer. Glimmer turned sharply to reveal an imposing, matronly woman. She appraised Angella with a look Glimmer couldn’t read; she recognized her grandmother from her portraits if nothing else. Lumina’s poise and steely grace seemed to challenge the moonlight itself.

“Angella, darling,” She offered flippantly. “I’m hardly worth such a terrible fuss.” Angella bristled at this dismissive response.

“Mother!” She snapped. “This isn't a laughing matter!” Angella swatted Micah’s hand away in her anger. “You don’t just get to decide something like this without warning. There is still time for a plan, if only you would listen—-”

“--You watch your tone.” Lumina responded coolly. “As both your mother and your queen, I do get to decide things just such as this.” The resemblance pained Glimmer. Micah, at a loss, held up placating hands as his attention flicked back and forth. Lumina anticipated him.

“I’m dying, Micah.” Wistfulness laced through her resignation. Angella's reaction knocked the wind from Glimmer's chest. This soft echo of her mother, this girl, succumbed to gasping tears. Glimmer had never once seen her in such a state. Her eyes burned as Micah closed the distance. Angella finally surrendered to his comfort.

“But– you can’t?” Bewildered, Micah turned his gaze to Lumina as he stroked at Angella’s hair. His words echoed Glimmer's thoughts. Dying wasn’t really in the job description for Angelic beings except for violent circumstances. Angella refused to talk about it. Glimmer had stitched together a guess: that Lumina had fallen on the battlefield.

“Not unless I must.” Her grandmother’s expression turned stony and solemn. “The horde advances are relentless. The Moonstone’s magic fades with every passing day.” She turned up a hand and a faint, stuttering twinkling danced weakly across her fingers. “I can think of only one way to save it.”

Slowly, Glimmer came to understand. Even she had bore witness to the runestones flagging. As a child, she had often regarded the Moonstone as weak, herself as weak, because she shared only a portion of its power with her mother. But the fact that it could be shared at all was an indelible mark of its strength. This was a strength no other Runestone had ever exhibited– certainly not without consequence. But what Lumina proposed… to charge the Moonstone with her own angelic essence… It was unthinkable.

“It just can’t be that simple!” Angella pushed off from Micah, but her aggravation was reedy. It carried with it a sense of inevitability. As Lumina had said, it was the queen’s decision after all.

“Sweetheart.”

In a hereditary fashion Glimmer recognized all too well, Lumina swooped forward, pulling the young, anguished pair into an embrace. “You have to know I wouldn’t if there was any other

choice.” She kissed the top of Angella’s head and smoothed at Micah’s hair. “I *am* sorry.” She tutted. “To you both.”

The parallel to her own ascendancy was too fresh. Glimmer pulled back from the intimate scene with her heart in her throat. She struggled to consider if she was meant to confront Angella in her youth… but something told her it wasn’t right. If that had been the case… her father, *her real father* , would have found the memory too. At the thought of him, the hall lights dimmed. Glimmer couldn’t waste time on wondering. She set off down the corridor with renewed insistence. Calling now instead for them both.

—

Micah cursed quietly. Even as nightfall gave way to moonrise and the scenery better revealed itself, Micah inched further and further from Bright Moon. Every landmark he followed in this dreaded Untheria seemed to turn him in the opposite direction out of spite. He frowned while looking out on the cliffs that cradled Mystacor; questioning himself.

Could there be a reason why he kept circling out wider and wider from the very place he wanted to go? Was it possible that Angella had something to do with it? What if his presence in this place threatened everything they were trying to accomplish? If he couldn’t find his way back, what would happen? These were unhelpful questions. He tamped them down at once. There must be a better answer.

If he wasn’t meant to reach Bright Moon… this would be the place. But how was he to reach Mystacor without magic? He surveyed the drop down the cliff face grimly. Micah did not like his chances when it came to jumping or climbing. He thought again of how the world seemed to bend to his presence. With fresh

resolve, He shut his eyes tight and took the sort of risk a man takes when he has precious little time to spare and everything left to lose. With one final breath Micah stepped out off the edge of the cliff.

—

After an eternity, Glimmer found her mother again, older now, sitting in her chambers as Glimmer knew them. Angella stared out the window, not really seeing the twilight. A doe-eyed approximation of Glimmer's youth clutched at her dark mourning skirts. "You are so much of him." Absently, Angella patted at the fluffy head of this spectral imposter.

"Mom." Glimmer breathed through the pain. "Mom. *Please.* "

Angella seemed not to hear. "I just can't– How can I ever…" Her serenity splintered sharply. "I'm not half the person he was. I– I don't know how to do this– not any of it!" Her fear sent shocks through the space.

"But you learned, mom." Glimmer implored as she crept closer. "You are mine. My mom. Not this little–" She gestured to the contrived not-Glimmer and the vacant expression it wore. "I'm begging you– see me, yell at me, anything!" She swung her arms out blindly. One outstretched hand knocked a vase from a nearby pedestal. Unable to teleport, Glimmer was powerless to stop it. It flung just out of her reach and shattered to the floor.

"Glimmer!" Angella gasped as she rose sharply from her chair. She turned toward Glimmer; real Glimmer. "How could you? That was a gift from Casta." This intimate indignation filled Glimmer with a quiet hope. She crossed her arms petulantly.

"Aunt Casta has terrible taste. There! I said it!" The spectral whisper of Glimmer's childhood flickered in the face of present

Glimmer’s bold impertinence.

“I know! It’s *hideous* , but she will ask where it is every single time she comes to dinner.” Angella buried her face in her hands as she failed to stifle laughter. “I’m meant to be disciplining you!”

“Please do.” Glimmer’s chuckle sat heavy. “How I missed even this I’ll never know.” This dry admission stirred something in Angella. She blinked back the fog slowly; taking in everything about the woman before her.

“Glimmer… you–” She stepped tentatively forward. Glimmer braced for a hug she was desperate for. Instead, Angella placed a firm palm atop her head. “You’ve grown.” Glimmer blinked.

“You’ve got to be kidding me.” She grumbled. Angella drew back, as she turned quizzically around, the rest of the scene faded away to the throne room instead. What was left of the memory bled from Angella’s gown; revealing her royal attire. “Dad and I cross space time to save you and that’s all you have to say?” Glimmer harped. “Classic.” She expected Angella to roll her eyes, but instead she lurched backward. Her expression turned glassy with fear.

“Not again.” Angella admonished. “I won’t be tricked.” She shook her head sharply. Glimmer realized her thoughtless mistake.

“No, mom, listen–-” Glimmer floundered at first in her panic, but as Angella pulled her arm back, her daughter was insistent. “Listen to me; *look at me.* ” If there was ever a time for Queen Glimmer, it was now. As she drew from everything she had learned in the wake of the portal event and threaded it through her tone, realization dawned for her mother. Her daughter stood before her now as Angella had never known her. Angella's unease over such strangeness crystalized as proof that in her absence, her daughter had become a woman... and that woman had come back for her.

This soft hope was jostled by a low rumble from deep beneath the earth. It pitched them toward each other. They tumbled down, stumbling to the weathered stone steps of the ruins where Glimmer's coronation trial had taken place.

They staggered to their feet. Glimmer could barely make sense of her mother's fluttering hands as she appraised the many changes that had occurred in her absence. Finally, Angella clutched tightly at Glimmer's shoulders.

"My dear sweet girl… *what have you done."* She pulled her daughter into a crushing hug as cracks splintered up the walls.

"Come on! Can't we just have this?" Glimmer's cry was muffled by her mother's embrace.

"What does this mean?" Angella implored. Glimmer struggled to summarize.

"Entrapta– she–" and then they were falling.

To Bell the Cat

Chapter Summary

> As the wormhole begins to collapse, time is of the essence. Catra's world widens to new mysteries.

Chapter Notes

> Yes, you do spy a Taylor Swift reference. We’re in the final stretch. Indulge me.

“Catra!” Adora cried out. A voracious and senseless nothing pried at the edges of her sanity as the presence of her family slipped away. Her resolve was bitter and cutting and she clung to the blade of it with both hands; thinking fiercely of all that she had fought so hard to hold onto.

She didn’t know what she had expected. Visions? Trials? Instead she was engulfed by this hungry emptiness that would not be sated. “What are you waiting for?” She bellowed into the hollow expanse as she walked. It swallowed the sound up. She broke into a run. It made no difference. The pearlescent void seemed to mock her. She sunk slowly to her knees and pressed her hands against her thighs. In this attempt to ground herself; she realized that she was no longer She-Ra.

“So much for that.” She whispered softly, dejected. Her eyes burned with unshed tears, but she wouldn't give the void the satisfaction. She squeezed her eyes shut tight. The air shifted in front of her. Adora lifted her attention to meet the precocious gaze of a child.

With cheeks brushed with soft downy fur, they peered at her quizzically with one eye squinted shut. “Catra?” Adora groaned. “Not again with the ghost babies.” She rubbed stubbornly at her face; slightly grounded by the shock. With a deep breath, she pulled away to take it all in. Both eyes blinked back at her now… a hopeful and teasing turquoise. Adora realized it couldn’t be Catra. The child before her had a crest of silken blond hair atop their head.

“Who are you?” She implored. The child said nothing. Adora held up her palm. They met it firmly with a timid smile. Just a simple high-five. Playful. Solid. *Real*. Adora reached for the youth, enveloping them. Overcome by the tangibility of this silent, stolid creature.

After a moment, the child squeezed back. They clung with an earnestness. It spoke to an displaced innocence that Adora knew all too well. “Come on.” She pulled away, but clutched the child’s hand as she stood. “Let’s go find your mum.” Then, second guessing herself, “--if you have a mum, I guess?”

—

Catra couldn’t decide if this forest was an echo of something beyond her memory. Were they all just tumbling around in a soup of consciousness? Maybe Mara had known this place? She struggled to remember what Adora had told her of the past She-

Ra. The uncanny quiet had begun to grow on Catra. Something about it felt like home somehow.

"Nice try, forest." Catra crossed her arms again. Leaves crunched softly behind her. She turned with a jolt and dropped low– searching the foliage for the source of the sound.

"This way." The disembodied tenor was hushed and raspy. A fan of fronds was clawed back by a lean arm covered in shaggy, shale fur. Brushed aside, a young man with distinctly feline features revealed himself. He had the harried look of someone losing ground; fast.

"What kind of a name is Saz?" A girl called from behind in an affected, self-important sort of way. Catra couldn't see her face from this angle. She took dainty, tentative steps and clutched at her hood conspicuously. *Amateur* . Catra thought.

" *What kind of a name is Saz?* " Her companion grumbled under his breath. "You're some kind of ignorant. You know that?" To her credit, the girl seemed to take this seriously.

"Forgive me, I meant no offense. I– I've just never met anyone like you before." Her tone was penitent, if a little petulant. Catra kept close behind as they wandered forward in the brush.

"If I had any other choice, I would have kept it that way, princess." He scoffed as he held back a branch for her.

“I am the queen, I will have you know.” She huffed. Catra’s eyes went wide; suspicious and unsure.

“Makes no difference to me. I’m certainly not your subject. Come on. We’re almost there.” He motioned her forward. They had come upon a rocky outcrop that cradled the mouth of a small cave.

“Cloudfoot’s Blessing.” Saz announced, seemingly to no one. The young woman hung back. Catra realized she had been holding her breath only as a new figure stepped out cautiously from the cave.

The woman, like Saz, was leonine. Her fur was raven with bright scattered bursts of gold and bronze; the stuff of galaxies. Her cutting amber eyes were alert, but her expression was wan and pained. She clutched at her side; it was hard to see in the low light, but the fabric beneath the matted fur of her fingers looked distinctly dark and wet. At the sight of their visitor, she hissed; ears flat. Saz held up his hands but it did little to mollify her.

“C'yra, please. She’s here to help.” His tone was surprisingly earnest. It held none of the bitterness from before. Catra was certain, whatever trouble they were in, it was grave.

“I won’t accept help from *them*.” C'yra winced even as she said it. Finally, the mysterious so-called monarch lowered her hood. Apricot curls framed her fair cheeks. Though Catra knew her only

from stories and pictures, it was no surprise. Angella clasped her hands together and offered a diplomatic bow.

"I know nothing of your struggles, or your difficulties with my people… But Saz said you were in need and I will do all I can if you will let me." She reached into her cloak to reveal a small cache of medical supplies. She offered them up to C'yra. Saz approached his companion and put a hand to her shoulder imploringly. C'yra leaned in to the gesture. He offered her a slow, steady blink of his azure eyes. She returned it. After a moment of pregnant silence, she sighed and turned back to Angella.

"Thank you, miss." Though the sharp edge of her prejudice had been ground down by her desperation, her tone was still a little clipped. C'yra allowed Saz to help her to the ground. Angella knelt readily, blocking Catra's view of C'yra. She drew back behind a tree trunk and slid to the ground. She closed her eyes to focus; listening keenly for anything else she might learn. They were quiet for a long time as Angella set to work. Catra's ears lay flat, mirroring C'yra's suffering.

"It was certainly infected." Angella ultimately sighed. "These stitches will be painful."

C'yra laughed huskily. "More painful? Somehow I doubt that." Crawling minutes of agony followed. Catra bit back the urge to hiss.

"Based on what I am seeing…" Angella's tone was cautiously optimistic as she finished. "I don't believe there will be any lasting

harm-- though you've lost a fair amount of blood.”

“Thank Tao.” Saz trilled softly. Catra could sense the rumble of relief at the back of her neck. One or both of them was purring with solemn gratitude, though certainly too low for Angella to register. She would be ignorant too, to the stakes that Catra had sensed naturalistically. C’yra was with child. Catra peeked out again, feeling oddly bashful now about the whole thing. Angella rose.

“I understand you to be loyal to an altogether different cause… but if you find yourselves in Bright Moon again, as long as I am queen, you will be welcomed.”

C’yra chuckled mirthlessly at this. “That’s the thing about kings and queens. In our experience, they disappear when you need them the most.” She made as if to rise, but Saz urged her to sit still. Angella nodded, conceding the point.

“Very well. You should rest for a while longer without exerting yourself.” But C'yra shook her head.

“We can’t risk it.” She was insistent despite Saz's grimace. Angella let out a contemplative breath.

“I can only get you as far as the Whispering Wood.” She sounded nervous. Saz quirked a befuddled eyebrow. Angella released a harmless pulse of glitter from one palm.

“The Moonstone grants me certain abilities.” She explained.

“Whiskers.” C’yra spat sharply. It was an odd expression, but her tone made it sound like a curse.

“Gather together and hold fast.” Angella knelt back again to C’yra. Saz followed suit. A shower of starlight blossomed in their stead. Catra squinted against the stark burst of brightness. Suddenly, her scenic surroundings erupted in a tumultuous blur of colour. Was it melting? Igniting? She couldn’t be sure; but she was sure it was making her nauseous. She shut her eyes tight against it.

“STOP IT!” Catra hissed; already taxed by a sea of unanswered questions. Then there it was again, that stifled, knowing sort of laughter. She was certain now it was a child. Catra couldn’t place it. She called blindly out again, exasperated. “If you’re going to taunt me, at least lead me to Adora!” She sighed to herself. “She’s no doubt where all the trouble is anyhow.”

The clumsy force of clutching hands bowled Catra over. Flat on her back she opened her eyes to the incredulous gaze of her partner.

“Oh, Catra, thank goodness.” Adora’s laughter was pained. “I feel like we’ve been here forever.”

Catra grimaced. “Tell me about it.” Now she was laughing too; that breathy ‘near miss’ sort of laugh. She crawled to her feet. A child’s face with unnervingly and disorientingly familiar features peaked out from behind Adora. “--Hey, Adora?” Catra gestured toward the wee timid creature.

“I’ll be honest. I’ve got nothin’.” She shrugged.

“Adora...” Catra groaned. “This is how people die. We’re in some sort of nightmarescape and you’re making friends with creepy ghost kids?!”

“No, they’re real, I swear.” She scooped the child up abruptly by the armpits. They held up a hand. Gobsmacked, Catra tapped it with her own and received an unpleasant static shock in return. Hissing, she scrutinized the diminutive interloper. A mortifyingly vulnerable thought settled in her mind like sand. She reeled back, freshly suspicious of the child. Adora pulled them toward her, they settled against her hip as if they belonged there. Catra swallowed hard.

“What’s the matter, Catra?” Adora cocked a quizzical eyebrow.

“Nothing.” Catra deflected, but her puffy tail caught her out. The child giggled. Catra smoothed down her fur with frantic fingers. “They don’t look familiar to you?” Catra squawked. Her ears went flat. Adora lifted the child to look and bounced them up and down for a few seconds before setting them back to the ground. She smiled down at them; unable to help herself.

“Well, they are a cat.” Adora admitted flatly.

“Idiot.” Catra muttered; her face grew hot. “Forget it.”

“Where are we, anyway?” Adora looked around. The forest had been usurped. They were boxed in by craggy stone. A branching path lay up ahead.

“Underground, maybe?” Catra crouched to meet the child’s eyeline. “If you were the one laughing earlier, I will pop you one.” They stared back determinedly at Catra. Suddenly, the child took off like a shot. Catra looked pointedly at Adora. She shrugged halfheartedly in response. They bounded after the small stranger.

—

Micah braced against the expected drop, but it never came. Cringing, he opened his eyes to find that gravity was the least of his problems. He simply hovered above the raging Salinean sea. He took a tentative step, then another.

With no small sense of alarm, Micah picked his way across the sky until he finally crossed the cloaking threshold. He stopped

abruptly to admire the Arxian archway and allowed his hope to cling to this small bit of luck.

"Casta!" He called out as he crossed into Mystacor. Then tentatively, he offered, "Norwyn?" After all, there was a sense of timelessness to this place. But again, the halls of Mystacore seemed empty-- least at first. As he passed the Lunarium, Micah caught the sound of distant shouting down a corridor to the left. He sought after it eagerly. He struggled to catch snippets as he neared the source of the sound.

"--could you?"

"Casta, please–" Micah skidded to a halt just out of sight. Through a near doorway stood his sister and his wife.

"Are you daring to ask me to *forgive you*? " Castaspella goaded. "Mystacor is the last, reliable safe place and he walked out on that, on his daughter's future, for your floundering, hopeless war."

"That's not fair!" Angella cried. "He was fighting for his daughter's future– and for Mystacor. You call me a coward? What do you call this?" Angella threw up her hands. "Do you truly think Mystacor can't fall?"

"It certainly stands to protect my family better than you have." She retorted.

Micah is–" Angella faltered, but found she was not yet ready to correct herself. "Your brother is a grown man and a seasoned sorcerer and soldier. To act like he risked his life solely at my behest is an insult to his legacy– and to the life we built together." She drew herself up and challenged Castaspella with a glare.

"I came here in grief because *you* are my family. " Her tone shifted to a stricken sort of resignation. "Glimmer is your niece and nothing is going to change that. Think of me what you will, but I will not allow you to reject her—"

"I would never!" Castaspella was indignant. The set of Angella's jaw made evident what a crushing blow that was. She had come to think of Castaspella as a sister and a friend. But she had lost more to this grief than her husband, it seemed.

"Good." She turned to go. Micah's heart lurched at Angella's stone-cold response. He knew what roiled beneath it. Before he knew what he was doing, he barrelled into the room and up to his sister, determined to change circumstances he knew that he could not.

Castaspella made no reaction. His shoulders sagged with defeat as she paid him no heed. A soft gasp from behind him struck like lightning.

—

Adora and Catra collapsed to their knees wheezing. They had chased the child through a labyrinth of stone until it opened out to a fathomless chasm. A carved narrow walkway lay before them. The itty bitty menace observed them from the other side.

"My memory isn't the best." Adora admitted breathily. "But I definitely haven't been here before." She wiped a clammy hand on her pant leg. "...and we have to be underground." She gestured to the cool, damp stone and vines creeping from cracks in the rock.

Their eyes were drawn to sheer, erected imposing walls of slate. Though ravaged by time, the remains of a possible gate lined up with the walkway. Adora struggled to her feet, still favoring a stitch in her side. Catra peered over the edge of the chasm with a grimace.

"--and we're determined to follow this kid how far exactly?" Catra accepted Adora's outstretched hand; she pulled Catra up.

"If you have any other ideas, I'm all ears." Adora challenged. Catra shrugged and started her way across the chasm. Smug, Adora followed close behind. Patiently, the child waited.

"Where are we, you little monster?" Catra growled as they reached the other side. The child giggled at her frustration. "It

was you!" Catra finally decided. "They're messing with us, Adora. I swear."

"Catra!" Adora swatted at her. "They're just a kid. Come on. Maybe they're trying to tell us something." Adora's tone became saccharine. "Hey there, bud." She crouched low. "Any chance you've seen a really tall lady around here?" She hoped her smile was encouraging. Catra rolled her eyes. Their young companion tilted their head with a frown but made no answer.

The child reached up suddenly and tugged at Catra's jacket before pointing toward the outer curtain of rock. They scampered deftly up and over the ruins of the entrance, pausing to look behind as they reached the top; their tail flicked with excitement. Begrudgingly, Catra followed. Adora cursed inwardly and began her own awkwardly clambering ascent. The child bounded out of sight and out of reach.

Catra whistled in astonishment as she reached the top. Adora laboriously pulled herself just high enough to peek over the edge. She was not disappointed. Time had also not been kind to this place, but larger monuments remained identifiable. All such monuments were tributes to jungle cats. Catra's skin crawled at the aura of Adora's self-satisfaction. She looked off to the side.

"Shut up." Catra's warning was quiet.

"I'm not saying anything." Adora sang softly as she threw one leg clumsily over the edge. Catra dropped low and yanked Adora back.

“No. *shut up.* ” Catra hissed, pointing. Adora’s eyes were drawn to a nearby figure kneeling at the base of a fallen statue. a familiar voice rang out.

“Forgive me, Saz.” Angella’s words were thick with grief.

“Angella!” Adora impulsively blurted this with all of the stealth of an EKS bot. Catra smacked herself in the forehead. Angella paid them little mind. “I don’t think she can hear us.” Adora began clambering down the other side. Anxious to close the distance between them. Sighing, Catra bounded down after her. Their minute companion momentarily forgotten.

Adora whistled as she peered closely at Angella’s stricken face. She waved a hand back and forth crudely. Catra swatted it down. “How young is she here?” Adora wondered.

“Young enough, but still queen.” Catra’s tone was hard. Adora drew back a little, confused. Catra followed Angella’s eyeline to a paltry bundle of wildflowers at the base of the statue. She hissed with derision. It was her turn to be impulsive. She snatched at Angella’s cloak, yanking her to her feet. To the shock of them all, she made contact. Young Angella stumbled backward and slipped easily from Catra’s startled fingers. She could certainly see Catra now. A small shower of silt sprinkled onto Adora’s shoulder from above.

"--Please– I mean no harm–" Angella stuttered, thinking quickly and bowing low. "Cloudfoot's Blessing. I am a friend of Saz."

"What happened?" Catra couldn't resist. "What happened to them?" Suspicion and aggression snaked through her tone. "*What did you do?*" Adora was stunned to silence.

"I didn't– I swear– He had told me of Halfmoon… I only wished to honor his sacrifice." Catra's heart sank.

"So they're dead." She accepted with leaden finality.

"I saw Saz fall." Angella admitted with some difficulty. "But C'yra was taken." Catra snatched again at young Angella's cloak; it was no mystery as to who could have taken C'yra. A faint tremor followed.

"Uh— Catra?" Adora tried to interject.

" *Taken?* " Catra hissed. "You mean you *let* them take her." She shoved Angella backward, Adora clutched at Catra's arm.

"What are you talking about?" Adora was reeling. "We don't have time for this." Catra shook Adora off as the ground split open. Cracks snaked toward them.

“Where’s that brat?” Catra thought suddenly. “We can’t leave them here.”

“A child?” Angella whispered. The three of them whirled around, searching. “There!” Angella pointed across the expanse. The child trembled, backed against the slate with cracks inching toward their feet. Twinkling erupted in Angella’s stead. Before they knew what was happening, she had returned. She clutched desperately at the small wonder. They buried their face in her chest. Only now did Angella truly look at Adora. Her heart lurched as her vision seemed to double.

“... Adora?” The grave tone of an alarmed mother overtook the quavering insecurity of her former self. A chunk of cragged rock broke off above them, hurtling down faster than any of them could process. Unthinkingly, Angella pulled them in toward her. The world exploded in a dazzling, whirling shimmer.

—

Micah spun around to a look of recognition and his wife’s outstretched hand. He reached eagerly to meet it as the world shattered into a flurry of dizzying fractals.

“Angella!” He cried, flailing senselessly.

“My love!” her longing echoed in his ears. He struggled to draw toward the sound in this sea of fresh nothing.

“Dad!” It was Glimmer’s voice he heard from above. His stomach bottomed out as his wife and child barreled toward him at speed. They tumbled together, clinging. Angella was delirious in her joy.

“I don’t know how any of this is possible, and I’m certain I should be furious, but I don’t care.” She threw her arms around them. Micah reveled in the delicate details he couldn’t afford to remember before. The smell of her hair, the wrinkle of her nose when she laughed, and her slender fingers on his face. “I missed this beard.” Her face crumpled with embarrassment and relief as she choked up. She seemed to shrink slightly. Her expression painted instead the nervous fear of a girl. She tried to wrench free, suddenly disoriented.

“Mom?” Glimmer looked to her dad, but he was equally stricken. They struggled to hold fast as Angella’s form shifted; pulled in every direction. Her memories burst forth; a splintering of the cage she had built, raining down from all around them. A reaching arm caught Glimmer from the corner of her eye. “Adora!” She fumbled to grasp it. It slipped from her fingers like water. Micah’s gaze began searching now too.

They wrestled against the folding and unfolding of all that Angella was. Micah and Glimmer fought not to lose themselves in futures and pasts that they had not been a part of.

“Catra!” Micah finally cried. “There’s too much of Adora. We have to look for Catra.” Glimmer closed her eyes and thought hard of her brittle, scrappy, passionate friend; of Catra's bravado and her smug expression. Glimmer opened her eyes to Catra’s own.

“AAAAAAAAH!” They screamed together before clinging sharply to one another. Adora barrelled into them now. It was a mess of limbs and confusion.

“Think back to the portal, now everyone together!” Micah cried.

“Together or not at all!” They roared this battle cry like a prayer until the sound, the light, the everything was swallowed by the nothing.

Electric Feel

Chapter Summary

> Desperate plans call for desperate measures; but no risk, no reward.

Entrapta launched herself up to reassess the monitors as the readings continued to spike. Those blaring sirens that had alerted them to portal anomalies had made quite the alarm clock. Entrapta's whirring mind was grateful now for the rest. She dropped herself back down to the floor. They had been applying stabilizing protocols for 20 minutes now, but that was the problem. It wasn't working.

Hordak killed the lights and any adjacent draws for electricity that he could think of. The energy surges were eager and magnetic. They couldn't risk the portal amassing further power and the light it emitted was more than bright enough to see by. The Kimberlite fizzed.

"Entrapta…" Hordak hedged with alarm as static began to fill the room. Small bursts of crystal blossomed on the surface of the Runestone.

"Fascinating…" Entrapta breathed as she stepped away from the panel. She looked to the Kimberlite and back to Hordak.

They couldn't allow the portal scope to widen any further. They had to come up with something fast. Anything that wasn't the only plan that they had left… which was shutting the portal down

for good. Entrapta had just such a plan, but it was the sort of idea she couldn't have warned Hordak for. Not really.

She closed the distance between them determinately. As she yanked him down to plant a firm kiss on his mouth, the tendrils of her hair snapped her goggles into place. He grimly concluded what she intended to do.

"Here goes nothing." She yanked her gloves off with her teeth.

"Entrapta, No!"

She launched toward the crystal, propelled by her hair and slipped just out of Hordak's reach. With a loud clap, she slapped two bare palms firmly against the surface of the Kimberlite.

She had expected some kind of pain, a jolt, something like the shock of her machines as the magic sought desperately for somewhere to go, for room to run. Instead, a quiet thrum rang out through every inch of her. The magic sang and her cells harmonized. As the energy readings flattened, she waited for the moment that it would become too much; but the magic didn't spill into her like a vessel set to overflow. Like a channel of current carved out by a bend in a river, it flowed through and out and back and forth. It lived; it breathed. Containing it had been the problem after all.

“There we go.” She patted at the crystal with motherly affection. “No need to get excited.” With the circuit now complete, Entrapta lifted her hands from the crystal curiously. It and the energy readings remained contented for now. She spun around to face Hordak. Entrapta ripped off her goggles to reveal glittering eyes and threw her arms wide.

Every cogent thought had been bleached from Hordak’s brain. He staggered toward Entrapta with incomprehensible relief. Hands shaking, Hordak sank to his knees as he reached for her face. Entrapta’s cheeks grew hot as his gaze burned into her. It was furious, grateful, and ardent all at once. She flashed a weakly apologetic and so audaciously Entrapta sort of grin. Hordak’s defeated laugh was husky. His caress down her jaw was urgent, but tender. His searching fingers finally settled at the base of her neck.

“You are a menace.” Hordak rasped as he pressed her forehead to his.

“You love me.” She shrugged, laughing. His lips found hers and it was more than answer enough.

A sudden pulse of energy knocked them back. Hordak yanked Entrapta down to shield her from the blast. A mess of limbs and chaos burst forth from the portal. Hordak scrambled to his feet and toward the lever panel.

Catra yelped as Glimmer landed on her tail. Micah elbowed a tumbling Adora in the stomach as he yanked his arm through,

pulling with him a dizzy Angella shielding a small child from the ensuing fall. Hordak slammed the lever with little ceremony. They were plunged into darkness.

"Whoops!" Entrapta chuckled as she scrabbled to the main panel and powered the regular lights back on. "Have we got all our arms and legs?" She appraised the scene. Glimmer was recovering from a reactive scratch from Catra.

"Sorry, Sparkles." The low rumble of her embarrassment caught Angella's attention. As mystification splashed across her cheeks, Adora pre-anticipated and plucked the child from her arms. A lavender tendril snaked out toward the small surprise.

"Ooh! Look, a baby!" Entrapta leaned in. Hordak shook his head. Magic never ceased to confound him.

Angella's flummoxed gaze trailed from Catra past Entrapta to Hordak. Micah guided her up to her feet with a gentle hand.

"Now, honey–" His tone was placating. She looked down to her fingers clasped affectionately in his and back up to Micah with eyes widening in stupefaction. Her peachy skin blanched. She tumbled to the floor. Grateful for the return of her power, Glimmer ported closer to assist as Micah staggered forward. Thankfully, they caught the queen dowager just in time.

"Sounds about right." Adora winced.

Many Happy Returns

Chapter Summary

An exhausted delegation returns home to Bright Moon.

Bow, his dads, and Castaspella sat at the base of the stairs in the throne room with their hands clasped tightly together. The shower of starlight they had all been waiting for announced the returning queen, her parents, and friends. Bow scrambled to his feet and burst into sloppy tears of relief as Glimmer staggered gratefully toward him. Entrapta had sent word ahead, but Bow's heart hadn't left his throat since he'd kissed Glimmer goodbye. He pulled her into a crushing embrace.

Silent tears streamed down Castaspella's cheeks as she staggered after George and Lance. The three of them helped Micah guide Angella somewhere quiet to rest. She would need time to acclimate. Bow respected, no matter how desperately he wanted to hug Angella, that now was not the time. He had waited what seemed like multiple infinities for them to return to him. He could easily wait a few more hours now that they were home and safe.

Adora yanked Bow and Glimmer into a brief, rough squeeze. She and Catra then left for their chambers to discuss the child that Bow had so many questions about; who lay cradled quite shockingly in Catra's arms. Finally, the flurry settled and he rested a wistful chin atop Glimmer's head; feeling strongly that he was unlikely to ever release her again.

"Thank the light you're back. *I'm a terrible regent. Everything's on fire*." He whispered into her hair with mock severity. His chest shook with suppressed, slightly hysterical laughter.

“I love you, ya idiot.” Glimmer murmured. Her tone sank as the fatigue settled into her bones. Bow lifted her into his arms. Glimmer buried her face.

“Bed time.” He kissed the top of her head tenderly.

“Bed time.” Glimmer mumbled. Eyelids fluttering closed as she patted at Bow’s cheek; as if trying to reassure herself that he was real.

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Catra sat at the foot of the bed. Her legs were crossed with taut arms pushing her hands downward into her lap. Her tail swished back and forth as she stared at the tangle of Adora and this small, bundle of confusion-– long snoring-– as she tried to breathe through everything that had just happened.

Catra couldn’t deny the connection she felt to this child. Whether it was a result of the resemblance, the knotted jumble of misplaced grief from what Catra had seen inside Despondos, or simply their innocence… she was draw to them in a way that scared the ever-loving shit out of her. In the way she had long since forced herself to forget; that pushed her toward every mistake she had ever made. That terrifying love that nearly

destroyed everyone and everything-- *Was she strong enough for it now?* She wanted to be.

Catra contemplated whether she might someday need true confrontation from Angella-– rather than her bewildered ghost. After all, if it wasn't for the young queen, Catra would have never even seen those people so like her; those people that she had such strong suspicions about. It was entirely possible that without Angella… Catra questioned whether she would have been born at all. She would have to tell Adora eventually what she had seen… and decide what it meant. But Catra knew she wouldn't be ready for a long time. She scrubbed frustrated tears from her cheeks as she continued to wait and watch and think. Buried in the tumult roiling in her chest… was a small, delicate seed of hope. It settled, unbidden. Catra prayed that she could let it take root and grow.

–

Glimmer rolled over to face Bow. He had nestled against her as she slept for light knew how long.

"Hey." He whispered; already awake and just savoring her closeness.

"Hey." Glimmer bit her lip bashfully. It struck her, not for the first time, just how perfect he was.

“I’ve been thinking.” He murmured. “--There was a lot more to this…” He hedged as she sat up, curious. Bow held fast at her hands. “Your mom got tipsy one time— remember, that New Moon’s Night?”

Glimmer let out a throaty chuckle of recognition. “Oh yeah.” Her expression turned mischievous. “Definitely the first thing I’m reminding her of. Y’know, just to set the tone.” Bow shook his head, smiling.

“Well, she told me some stuff about her and Micah… it was gonna be real cute and everything…” Glimmer pulled Bow up to mirror her. He released one hand to scratch at the back of his head. It was a sure sign of his nervousness. “But—” Butterflies bloomed in Glimmer's stomach. *No…* She thought. “You’re already my wife, Glimmer. Who are we really kidding?” Bow lifted his gaze skyward with embarrassment. “The thought of life without you—” He closed his eyes and sought a calming breath. “It was the scariest thing… and we have been at war for *most of our lives.*”

“Bow…” There was a hint of warning in Glimmer's voice.

“Glimmer…” He mimicked her tone playfully. She wanted to smack the grin off his face; her heart was going to explode.

“ *Please.* Tell me you’ll marry me?” He looked to her now so seriously. His expression had turned comically grim. Glimmer half-laughed, half-sobbed. *As if she would ever say no.*

“You’re perfect and an idiot and of course!” Glimmer cried.

“Really?” Bow didn’t know why he was surprised.

“What about *you*, really?” Glimmer countered cheekily. “Isn’t being my official consort kind of a lot? You were regent for all of thirty seconds and for all I know everything *is* on fire.”

“No!” Bow was aghast. “Call me whatever you want, but being with you is never too much.”

“Never…?” Glimmer’s tone was dubious.

“Mostly never.” Bow laughed as she bonked him on the head. He dove forward, nearly crushing her. Glimmer threw her arms around him. “Phew. That was so much more stressful than I thought!” Bow yelled into a pillow.

Glimmer fought the smile on her face. “Gosh. My dad’s gonna cry!”

“Everyone’s gonna cry!” Bow kissed her once then twice. “We’re adorable!”

One Year Later

Chapter Summary

> Many moons have passed and what once seemed so unthinkable is now simply routine.

“Aun’trapta!” Finn called excitedly with their wispy bangs falling in their face. They sat primly on a plush, pink puff-like seat near Hordak’s flourishing ficus. “Look!” The puff had been donated by Glimmer when she realized that Finn had to recharge at the Kimberlite as Glimmer once had with the Moonstone. Sitting atop her pinwheeling hair, Entrapta barrelled over.

A hunk of unrefined metal floated before the child. Their look of concentration coincided with a mesmerizing shift. The ore unbound and coalesced into a new shape. A crude, but passable figurine of Swift Wind dropped into Entrapta’s outstretched palm. She pulled out her recorder.

“Objective: Finn’s ferrokinesis continues to refine. Unsure if artistic skill is within normal age parameters.” Entrapta turned it over. “Subjective: I think it’s pretty good.” Finn clapped at the praise. The figure squashed back down into a lump.

“Now you try!” They urged; as always, full of energy. Entrapta pressed her lips together and squinted at the blob. It crunched into an approximate abomination at first. She cackled as she lifted her recorder back to her face in mock seriousness.

“Objective: Horses are clearly not my strong suit.” Entrapta made a silly face at Finn. “Let me try something else.” She thought hard for a moment. The indiscernible creature morphed instead into a cartoonish humanoid. It sported small excitable limbs and a head slightly, but charmingly, too big for its body. It was clearly an attempt at Finn.

“It’s me!” They squealed. I’m gonna show grandma!” They bounded off the puff, sending air kisses behind as they skidded out into the corridor-– heading for the teleport launchpad. Now out of trials, it would seamlessly and safely return the child to their home at Bright Moon. Warmth blossomed in Entrapta’s chest. She tapped to activate her comms system.

“Break time, Beautiful. I miss your face!” She flounced onto the puff to wait.

“Five minutes.” Hordak’s answering rasp curled upward at the edges, like his smile no doubt.

“Likely story.” Entrapta teased. “Lab A?”

“Kitchen, in fact.” Hordak was a little smug. “I have attempted tiny snacks.” Entrapta’s ensuing stimmy sort of purr, an echolalic sound she’d picked up from Finn, belied her joy. There was no end to her love for this man.

—-

Angella’s laugh was feathery with fatigue as Finn jumped into her lap. Her energy levels were inconsistent: an observed consequence to her time in Despondos. Along with the loss of her wings, it was a trade she would make ten times over if the choice had been her own.

But it had not been her own. Her brilliant, head-strong, daughter, and the love of her life had crossed heaven and earth quite literally for her. Even now, she struggled to believe it sometimes. Micah’s hands settled at her shoulders with an affectionate squeeze; as if he knew she would appreciate the reminder. She kissed at his knuckles.

“It’s about time for dinner, my love.” He announced. “Who’s ready for siopao?” Micah leaned conspiratorially toward Finn. It was their favourite.

“ME!” They sang. Micah wheeled them out into the corridor and toward the dining hall. Finn’s chattering was hushed. “Mumma’s or Auntie Glimmer?” The preference was clear.

“Auntie Glimmer.” Micah whispered with pride as Finn clapped. He wiped a laughing tear from one eye in solidarity for Catra. He would carry this secret to his grave.

Confidence

Chapter Summary

Hordak asks Perfuma for a favor.

Perfuma had just started to doze when the trackpad trilled. Scorpia, long unconscious beside her, was dead to the world. She had been working herself to the bone in the Crimson Waste on the expansion at Hadra's. Perfuma kissed Scorpia softly on the cheek as she reached over to scoop up the trackpad.

"Perfuma." Hordak's tone was pressing. They were no longer seeing nearly as much of one another, she realized. *Was it possible that she might miss Hordak the teensiest bit?*

"Good evening." Though her smile was thin from fatigue, it no longer had exasperation clinging to the edges like it used to in the early days of their sessions.

"I need… help." Neither did Hordak's tone. It struck her. Instead, his embarrassment was bright and earnest.

"From me?" She grinned with a flowering sense of fresh curiosity.

"From you." Maybe he was still a little begrudging. Hordak tilted the screen to reveal that he had turned his room utterly upside-down. Swaths of fabric were strewn across nearly every surface. The poor ficus had a hat on. "I wish to look… appropriate. For the

upcoming ceremony-– as a show of respect.” He hadn’t yet shaken that nervous little cough.

Perfuma was taken aback. After all of their sessions, Hordak's most persistent difficulty was still his appearance; how he looked at who he saw in the mirror and what that all stood for. Truthfully, he had avoided it at all costs. By this point, his hair had grown well past his shoulders and unless Entrapta fashioned something from metal, he wouldn’t be caught dead wearing it. Until now, apparently.

“Hordak. Are you asking what I think you’re asking?” She clasped her hands together.

“I understand that it is called… a makeover.” He winced as Perfuma let out a burst of laughter.

“I would be *delighted.* ”

His mumbled “thank you.” made Perfuma’s heart sing. “We shall discuss this further tomorrow then. Goodnight.” He offered this brusquely before disconnecting the call. *Abrupt as ever.*

She shook violently at Scorpia’s shoulder, but it was no use. She wouldn’t be stirred even if Emily burst through the wall of their yurt. Perfuma leaned back and thought only of what tools she had to offer for this next great, glorious challenge. Sleep would be a long way off yet.

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Dusk settled on Bright Moon. It was the night before the big day. Perfuma threaded her fingers through Hordak's damp hair. As she rubbed the crushed herbs through, streaking it darker and darker as she went, she marveled at the journey they had taken together. Here he was: her once mortal enemy, patient under her guided hand. No longer flinching at the anticipation of touch-– asking for her help to look presentable for a wedding. They had settled on a maroon, high-necked tunic with a long hem and a sharp pair of boots with a decent, but comfortable, heel.

The silence was companionable. It cradled them like the warm night breeze that came in from the window. Hordak's gaze was fixed off in the distance with thoughts clearly occupied. Perfuma wiped her hands against her smock. The herbs would have to sit for a bit before she rinsed them out and began on styling. She pulled up a pillow and sat beside him. It felt nostalgic in a way.

"Everyone is embarking on new beginnings." Perfuma's eyes misted over. He looked to her with a start as she fanned herself; flustered.

"Perfuma?" He could divine nothing from her complex expression.

“It’s Scorpia… well… she’s–” Sniffling, she threw her hands up with a shrug. “She’s pregnant!” Perfuma clasped her hands to her mouth. “I wasn’t going to say anything yet. Trying to hold space for Bow and Glimmer, you know?” Hordak blinked; trying to catch up to the information as it unfolded before him.

“This child will be… very blonde.” Hordak was startled, but touched. “... and very loved.” He added firmly. Perfuma’s staccato giggle, something that Hordak used to find grating, warmed him now. “I am honoured to be trusted with this. I shall tell no one!” He raised a fist. “Not even Entrapta.” His expression was extremely serious, but Perfuma strongly doubted it.

“You can tell Entrapta.” She laughed again. Hordak’s bravado deflated.

“Oh-– thank the light.” Now he was laughing too-–really laughing, in a way she had never heard before. *The way oak trees laughed*, Perfuma thought. This small miracle was surprise enough, but he reached for her then.

As Perfuma, Princess of Plumeria, patted softly at the back of Hordak: reformed despot, narrowly avoiding getting dye in her own hair, she thought of all of the grief that had chased them here. Of all of the times in the war and out of it where she had wanted to give up, give in, to all of the things that had ever told her that she had to be hard to be strong. She thought of that same flat edge that had worked to file this man down into a weapon… and the pride that she felt, for both of them-– and for this queer and unlikely friendship. It simply could not be measured.

To Have and to Hold

Chapter Summary

It is a very special day for Bright Moon

“Bow," Glimmer began with a shaky breath. They stood before Castaspella, as their honoured officiant, surrounded by all of their loud, weird friends and family. Bow's eyes were misty at the sight of Glimmer's blush gown and fought the urge to tickle her at the tasteful fabric cutouts just above her hips. "You have spent your entire life doing the unthinkable for me. You’re like a quiver, ever at my back, gathering up every fragile hope I ask you to hold.” Bow, predictably, choked up at the clumsy archery allegory. The tone in the room was warmly teasing, but there wasn’t a dry eye in the house-– least of all Glimmer.

She sniffed, struggling to continue. “You might be the only person who can get me to admit when I’m wrong… and my most staunch supporter when no one else will admit that I’m right!” Her laugh was throaty as she called out with mock frustration. “My first friend,” She whispered now, tenderly, “my best friend…” A sob escaped. She tried to cover her face with her hands, but Bow held them fast, lifting them instead to kiss her fingers. Glimmer giggle-cried embarrassingly for an adorable moment or two.

“Can we please, please be married already?!” Bow finally gushed imploringly to Casta. She shrugged and chucked away her cue cards. Having relinquished all sense of decorum and ceremony, Bow kissed Glimmer all over her whole face. She swatted him away unconvincingly before they folded into a kiss that made Micah and Angella turn away, and Lance and Tsurune whistle. Swift Wind let out a whoop. The room exploded with laughter and applause.

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“How is it that you’ve always been such a good dancer?” Adora grumbled, struggling not to swoon as Catra twirled her deftly.

“Always?” Catra smirked, pulling her closer. “That one time really left an impression, huh.” She purred.

“Oh, shut up.” Adora looked down to hide her blush.

“Sometimes it pays to let somebody else lead.” Catra turned Adora out with a flourish before pulling her in again to a dip.

“So dramatic.” Adora’s eyes were laughing. Catra’s were too. A sudden blur of fur and fabric nearly bowled them over.

“Finn!” Catra cackled and scooped the little agent of chaos up from the floor. They were covered in cake.

“I love weddings!” They giggled brightly in the way of children discovering something new. "Teach me!" They wiggled.

“Mumma’s gonna have to teach you. I’m hopeless.” Adora beamed as she lifted Finn from Catra’s arms. She held them up in front of her and guided one small hand forward.

“It would be an honour.” Catra bowed grandly and clasped their sticky fingers. This three-person waltz was as delightfully clumsy as anyone would expect… and if they had asked, Catra might have even admitted that it was by far her favourite part of the night.

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“You are beautiful.” Entrapta’s eyes glittered in the moonlight. Hordak quelled the urge to argue or deflect.

“I certainly owe Perfuma a great debt.” He coughed humbly. As Entrapta ran her fingers teasingly through his restored navy hair, he was all the more grateful that Perfuma had talked him out of cutting it all off. Entrapta’s caress trailing down the shaved side was nothing short of electric. She leaned indecently close. Her chuckle tickled at his ear.

“I’m glad the eyeliner came back from the war.” Her playful whisper was husky at the edges. Hordak’s flush was vehement.

“Entrapta…” He chided her laughingly, compelled to turn his head away.

“Hordak…” Entrapta mimicked his tone as she caught his chin and brought his eyes back to hers. They challenged him playfully. He gathered his courage and kissed her despite the so very crowded room. Meanwhile, their neighbors at a nearby table were a unique mixture of tipsy, alarmed, and fascinated. Scorpia and Perfuma gaped.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

> The inaugural Princess Prom since the end of the Horde War is a special one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The glittering bead embroidery of Frosta's fur-trimmed gown rustled as she stepped up to the podium. Her hair loops were adorned with pearlescent feathers. Glimmer nearly teared up at the sight of her. Diplomacy's child, once born from war with all the brute-force to show for it, now an elegant woman and a fierce queen. Frosta cleared her throat gruffly. *Maybe elegant was a stretch*.

"Since the re-establishment of the Princess Alliance, the fall of the Horde, defeat of Prime, and so many other more recent a-accomplishments, we are here to celebrate." She parrotted. Bow's speech edits were a godsend in the face of her flat affect. "Obsidian's sharp and steady rise to affluence and prosperity made it the clear choice for the first Princess Prom since the iiinstatement of a rotating roster. The Kingdom of Snows is honored to pass the baton to such a worthy nation." Frosta stumbled through some congratulatory growling attempts toward Rogelio. Expansion of trade with the Kingdom of Snows had been the pinnacle of his re-election campaign. Everyone clapped lightly. Rogelio snarled back in acknowledgement with honorable diffidence.

" *He's so charismatic.* " Seahawk whispered to Mermista.

“Isn’t he?” She droned with fervency.

Rogelio added a short burst of hisses as he placed his arms around Lonnie and Kyle.

“We are in agreement. Lonnie is a boss as Health Minister and Kyle– a… Kyle. A Kyle all his own.” This is what happened when Frosta went off script. Glimmer snorted as Bow cringed.

Frosta continued resolutely, shuffling through her cue cards. “In the spirit of Princess Prom and its commitment to neutrality-– to fostering lasting peace-– with Rogelio’s permission, I present the next speaker: Hordak.” Slight whispering was to be expected, but there was little rudeness. Hordak stepped out from the wings. The work and talks it took to reach this point were considerable. Lonnie was still a little stiff about the idea. But, she would slap a supportive smile on her face for the sake of her partners, who had unfortunately talked her into conceding. Lonnie didn't have to like or forgive the guy; but she loved these sappy jerks.

“H-Man!” Scorpia whooped. Hordak shook his head, laughing.

“I cannot adequately express how humbled I am. That you have allowed me here today.” Hordak gestured outward. It was his first time in Obsidian since Horde Prime had touched down.

He pulled slightly at the high collar of his formal tunic. A quiet serenity was his armor now and it proved well-tailored. "I hold so much gratitude for everyone in this room. You have offered me endless patience… and in doing so, I have learned better how to wield it myself." He raised his glass to Perfuma, she fanned the acknowledgement away with a deferent chuckle. Scorpia enveloped her from behind.

"I spoke once to forgiveness." He paused; recalling the moment in his trial where he was asked to speak for himself. "That it wasn't something to be granted… and I believe I understand that better now. Forgiveness is not permission for what you have done… it's the opportunity to choose better." He smiled to Adora, Catra, and Finn. "These opportunities that I have been given…" He coughed. "There was a time when I would never have granted them to anyone, not even to myself."

"I will continue doggedly to repair what remains of what I have broken and to respect the wishes of those I have wronged. Again, I thank you for allowing my presence here tonight so that I may share this triumph with you and my beloved wife." He extended a hand toward Entrapta who, though attentive, leaned against the snack table holding a cookie in each hand. Bow gasped as he finally registered the slick, chrome band clamped to Entrapta's left wrist. It was set with the same inscription on Hordak's data crystal. She blinked as the room hummed with surprise.

"Oh, Right!" She threw the cookies over her shoulders. "We're married!"

"Wow." Mermista's flat shock was a standout reaction.

“Entrapta!” Bow and Scorpia wailed with shock at not being told first. Perfuma hid a coy smile behind her hand because of course Hordak had already told her. He offered a striking, low bow to Frosta and stepped off the platform to beeline for Entrapta. It had clearly taken a lot out of him to address the room in such a way.

He touched her shoulder gently. Entrapta returned this muted gesture of affection with a crushing hug. “Thank you.” He gestured for the crowd to return its attentions to Frosta.

“That’s enough of that.” Frosta dropped her remaining cue cards. They rained to the floor like confetti. Bow whimpered a little. She pumped her fist as she took advantage of the amplification runes that Castaspella conjured for the stage.

“Let’s party!” She bellowed.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you very much to the people who have been along for the ride. This was fun as shit and I am so proud of myself. I have the beginnings of another project in the works (not She-Ra though, alas) and look forward to posting again.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!